The Tenth Walker

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48780550.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), The Lord of the Rings - All Media Types

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Aragorn | Estel, Legolas Greenleaf, Gimli (Son of Glóin), Gandalf | Mithrandir, Merry Brandybuck, Pippin Took, Frodo Baggins, Sam Gamgee, Boromir (Son of Denethor II)

Additional Tags:
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Part 1 of The Wildcat of Arnor

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by Hotshot95

Summary

Despite any stigma against it, I have always found the potential of "Tenth Walker" fics to be incredibly fascinating, and have only encountered two in my life that not only completed the story but that I felt were worth the read. That being said, despite having made it to the end of the War of the Ring, neither of these stories conclusions sat well with me for a series of personal reasons.

So after an image of a particular character joining the Fellowship found its way into my mind, I have decided to give it a go for myself. My only hope is that the reader finds as much enjoyment in reading the story as I have writing it.

The Fellowship of the Ring Part I

There are many tales that can be told where what is usually a Fellowship of Nine becomes Ten. This is but one of them.

THE FELLOWSHIP OF THE RING

Catra didn't remember much of what came directly after pulling that lever, but she definitely remembered the end. By her guess and an odd gut feeling, at least the equivalent of a month had passed before the strange void that held Despondos in between the two realities she now knew existed spat her out and re-sealed.

The next four years would be a lot easier to recall.

Weathertop

Pippin was the first to voice his concern as the group neared the peak of the old watchtower, just after Strider had given the four Hobbits daggers from a nearby burrow that would serve as good enough swords for them.

"Does anyone else feel like someone's watching us?" He said tentatively, as not to appear too foolish. After all, their new Ranger companion had taken extensive measures to outpace the Black Riders. Frodo, Sam, and Merry looked at him with a small amount of worry, while Strider merely looked off to the distance impassively before allowing himself a small smile.

"You are correct, Master Took, but fortunately the eyes upon us are part of the few friendly ones that we would have been lucky to encounter. It seems that the Wildcat of Arnor has decided to act as our extra watch for the night."

"The what?" Merry asked incredulously.

“Her name is Catra, she is a traveler from a very distant land who came to Arda nigh on four years ago. She is of a race unlike any other seen in any known land, being as much a beast as she is maiden. Although she keeps to herself and prefers the Wild, she has sought to drive as many creatures of evil to remain where they hide throughout the North. I have had the privilege of making her acquaintance, but that is a much longer tale, and I do not have the time to tell it now. We shall rest here for the night.” And with that, the Ranger left to scout what ground was not being covered by this mysterious ally he spoke of.

Catra heard it all before she saw anything. She had just made her way up a tree that sported a large enough branch conducive to scouting when a distant clatter reached her ears. Although she couldn’t make out exactly what it was (something about tomatoes, she thought), it was definitely voices. Turning her head to the ruin of the watchtower, she was just in time to see the last flickering of a fire being stamped out before a shrill, unholy shriek pierced the night air.

‘Well, isn’t this just perfect?’ Catra thought as she bounded through the treetops. In the near distance, five shapes began to slink up the outcropping of rock. If those things were what she was really hoping they weren’t, she should at least try to make sure the last four didn’t follow them.

Catra didn’t have much experience with Hobbits outside of what Gandalf had told her once she’d began to open up to a few people, and the occasional interaction with the few that called the village of Bree home. But what had just happened was more than enough to confirm her initial impression of halflings. That being, that when venturing outside of their homeland, Hobbits were basically if one were to make an entire people composed totally of half-sized Kyles. An assessment that she figured would be particularly damning in this case, as it was more than clear that Strider had been guiding this group of four for at least a fortnight

now, and the Nine never came this far North. Something was really, really, wrong.

"Mr. Frodo, look!" Sam said, doing his best to comfort his master as he lay groaning under the influence of the wraith's blade. "It's Mr. Bilbo's trolls."

"I don't think he can hear you man." Offered a rough female voice from within the brush. Sam turned his head up and was met with a pair of mismatched blue and yellow feline eyes belonging to a literal cat-like woman covered in a thin coat of tan fur. She was dressed in a worn and weathered crimson jumpsuit held together with a few scattered odds and ends of cloth and leather employed to keep the old outfit together. The result of which had turned out looking like the most ramshackle traveling tunic and pants possible while still remaining usable. She had topped off her look with a hooded brown traveling cloak that suspiciously appeared to have been a blanket of some sort in a previous life. The clasp holding it a repurposed belt buckle, laden with small dents and numerous scratches and clearly not given the same respect from its owner as the garment it kept fastened. Finally she bore a coiled length of leather cord at her right hip. The mane atop her head had been shorn until it only barely reached the uppermost part of her jaw. There was no doubt that this was the Catra that Strider had spoken of.

"Catra," the Ranger in question asked. "Any news?"

"You sure put the fear into those five for a bit." The feline said. "No sign of the others though. What happened to the half pint?"

"Stabbed by a Morgul blade." Catra sucked a harsh breath in through her teeth.

"That does not sound good."

"Is he going to die?" Pippin asked.

“Not precisely.” Strider said. “Should the infection reach his heart, he will likely suffer the same fate as the Nazgûl.”

“And the last thing we need is ten of those things.” Catra said. “Is there any way we can slow it down until we can get him to Elrond?” Strider thought for a second.

“Sam, do you know the Athelas plant?”

“Athelas?”

“Kingsfoil.”

“Aye, that’s a weed!”

“It should help to slow the poison, Catra, if you could look after the others?”

“Right.” Catra responded, leaning against one of the stone trolls. She looked down at the still moaning and gasping Frodo as Merry and Pippin huddled near. Catra wracked her brain for any words of comfort she could supply to the young Hobbits, and came up with nothing. This long night just seemed to keep getting longer. Uneasily, she adjusted her stance on the troll and looked up at its frozen face.

“So, uh…” She inquired of the statue. “You come here often?”

The Council of Elrond

Suffice to say, Catra’s week was shaping up to be quite hectic. If anything, she was at least grateful for the fact that she at least had a proper bed for the next few days after making a mad dash to the last Homely House alongside a man and three Hobbits.

It was funny really. Four years ago she couldn't have imagined waking up in anything other than a cot or barracks bunk. And now here she was, fairly accustomed to the occasional bed and roughing it on the regular in a world that seemed a good seven hundred years behind the one she grew up in. If you could even call that growing up.

Sometimes her thoughts traveled back to Etheria. What was it like now that she was gone? If it hadn't been destroyed by the portal, it was likely a much better place than she had left it. But still, how could have things been like if she hadn't gotten blasted here? If she hadn't pulled that lever? What would she be doing now? What would Ad-

No. That was all in the past. Things were different now.

"I'm a different person now." Catra muttered to her reflection in the mirror that stood on the far wall of the room Lord Elrond had provided. She wasn't perfect, but she was still a long sight better than she was that cold night three and a half years ago. Nonetheless, she still felt as if the affirmation was more of a lie told to herself to feel better than actual fact. Gathering her bearings, she walked outside the room to see her suspicions confirmed as she looked into the room next to hers. Once again, Arwen had proved the morning person between them. Catra threw off the revelation with a noncommittal yet amused grunt and set forth to see if Frodo had woken up yet. She knew only a scant bit about the Nine, yet what she did know was enough to rile up her newfound and surprisingly enough to her, somewhat substantial concern for the well-being of others. A side effect of having nearly everyone she met the past four years not trying to skin her on the spot she supposed.

She could stand to start paying more attention to Gandalf's info dumps when he explained things to her though, she figured.

Thankfully, by the grace of whatever chucklehead who was in charge of reality and Elrond's healing skill, Frodo Baggins was up and about as Catra observed him and the other three Hobbits from a balcony, reuniting with one of their own by the name of Bilbo if she remembered correctly. Apparently he was Frodo's uncle or cousin or something, Catra found what she remembered of Hobbit family trees and the culture surrounding them to be as almost ridiculously convoluted as they were religiously recorded and kept. They could give the Royal lines of most nations she had bothered to inform herself of a run for their money, and the Hobbits seemed to be doing it for fun.

Catra was broken out of her thoughts by the sound of footsteps behind her, she turned around to meet a familiar Ranger.

"What's happening Strider?"

"Lord Elrond has called for a Council to fall at the end of the week, as it is a meeting of great importance, he felt that your presence would be…"

"A good idea due to my uh, unique circumstance?"

"That is certainly one way of putting it." Catra frowned intently. She hadn't been too big on heavy matters like this one since she'd arrived here, but something in the pit of her stomach was telling her that she really had no choice but to go.

"Right. I'll be there." Catra said. "Hopefully it'll be nothing like that dinner last year that Arwen's brothers thought would be a good idea to 'make interesting'."

The Council was held on the outdoor circular patio not far from where the shards of an ancient sword were held. Upon the patio sat a singular pedestal, and surrounding it was a crescent of chairs, around twelve, with a singular grand chair taking up the opposite end, just in front of a large tree. The Council in question was certainly shaping up to be quite the sight in Catra's opinion as

she found herself seated between Gandalf and a tall blonde Elf who was sitting in such a manner that Catra was sure he could give stoicism lessons to Rogelio. Further to her left was a host of other Elves, a couple Dwarves, and some Men, Strider included. Elrond himself sat at the grand chair, with one of his attendants sitting at a stool aside. Elrond rose to his feet.

“Strangers from distant lands, friends of old. You have been summoned here to answer the threat of Mordor. Middle Earth stands on the brink of destruction, no one can escape it. You will unite, or you will fall.”

‘Right,’ thought Catra. ‘No pressure or anything.”

“Each race is bound to this one fate, this one doom.” Elrond continued, turning to where Frodo sat. “Bring forth the Ring, Frodo.” Tentatively, the Hobbit stepped forward, lightly grasping something in his palm as an expectative silence filled the Council. An odd feeling of unease gripped Catra as Frodo approached the center pedestal and placed a small object upon it.

In the few times that Gandalf was able to talk to her of Middle-Earth’s history, Catra had learnt at least the scant basics regarding the legendary Rings of Power. With such a reputation they held, particularly the One, she had expected it to be much more impressive than a simple golden band. Or at least that’s what Catra would have thought had the Ring’s unassuming appearance only heightened the almost paralyzing dark energy that her heightened senses picked up from it. While somewhat weak, the still unworldy intense dark aura of the Ring conjured up many an unwanted memory of a similar darkness that she had gotten intimately acquainted with throughout her childhood. Even so, her ears were still attentive enough to pick up the awed whisper of “So it is true” coming from one of the human Council members. A red-headed man stood, and revealed himself to be the source of the sound as he spoke to the group.

"In a dream," He said quietly. "I saw the eastern sky grow dark… But in the West, a pale light lingered." He started moving towards

the table. "A voice was crying: 'Your doom is near at hand. Isildur's Bane is found.'" He reached for the Ring, Catra's eyes narrowed and she tensed, ready to pounce. "Isildur's Bane…" Suddenly, Elrond leapt from his seat.

"BOROMIR!!!" The Elf Lord reprimanded. Gandalf shot from his seat as well, voice thundering in a harsh and unknown language, the skies seemed to darken and the ground quaked beneath the Wizard's voice. The assembled Elves did their best to ignore the noise and the man, Boromir, quickly retreated to his seat, clearly regretting his most recent actions. Gandalf stopped, and everything returned to an approximation of normal. Even though she did not understand the words, Catra couldn't help but feel a similar sense of foreboding that the Ring was apparently exuding from them. Clearly annoyed, Elrond turned to Gandalf.

"Never before has any voice uttered the words of that Tongue here in Imladris." The Elf Lord said.

"I do not ask your pardon Master Elrond. For the Black Speech of Mordor may yet be heard in every corner of the West!" Gandalf answered. "The Ring is altogether Evil!"

"Clearly that much is obvious…" Catra muttered to herself as she smoothed out her fur, which she had just noticed was on end. Boromir had apparently regained his nerve as he stood again, speaking with a bullheaded conviction that brought back to Catra a whole other set of unpleasant memories.

"It is a gift. A gift to the foes of Mordor." He said. "Why not use this Ring?"

"Because clearly the smartest thing to do when fighting a war is give your enemies something they can use to take you out." Catra spoke up, annoyed by this man's apparent refusal to treat the clearly unpleasant jewelry as such. "If your enemy willingly gave their greatest weapon to you, they're obviously planning something." Strider then made to speak up, four years or not, Catra understood that she was still an outsider here, and

therefore needed any support she could find. She let him say his peace.

“She is right, you cannot wield it! None of us can!” Boromir eyed them coldly.

“And what would a mere Ranger and a beast know of this matter?” As soon as he had finished, the blond Elf next to her stood as well, and Catra summoned the will to stay her claws.

“This is no mere Ranger!” The Elf said. “He is Aragorn, Son of Arathorn, and you owe him your allegiance.” Gandalf stood again as well.

“And our new compatriot is called Catra, she is a traveler from a world unlike ours, sent by the Valar to help.” Well, part of that was true, Catra supposed, but as long as it prevented anyone from questioning her presence. Boromir paused before returning to his seat.

“This… is Isildur’s heir?”

“And Heir to the throne of Gondor.” The Elf confirmed.

“Havo dad, Legolas.” Aragorn said, calming the Elf who then sat.

“Gondor has no King. Gondor needs no King…”

‘What?’ Thought Catra, faux offended. ‘No witty comeback for me?’ Regardless, Catra felt some small sense of vindication at the results of the last exchange. Having crossed paths with him often, she’d had a feeling that Strider was more than he let on. Being a future King though, was admittedly not that high on the list of her suspicions.

“Anyway.” Gandalf said, hoping to get the meeting on track. “They are both right. We cannot use it. Sauron’s agents are tracking the Ring down as we speak.” Another name Catra vaguely recognized, and with the current context, found to be quite appropriate for a

Dark Lord, just hearing it sent an odd chill down her spine and to her tail tip. It sure beat the Hell out of calling yourself "Hordak".

"There is only one choice." Elrond said. "The Ring must be destroyed." Everyone gave the Ring a heavy look, before a red bearded Dwarf suddenly stood.

"Then what are we waiting for?!" He exclaimed, brandishing his axe. He quickly closed the distance between himself and the pedestal, driving the weapon down on the Ring! As soon as the axe head made contact, a striking clap sounded through the valley as the Dwarf was launched backward! Catra brought her eyes from the Dwarf back to the pedestal and they widened, small plumes of smoke surrounded a completely unharmed Ring. The smoke had come from the shattered blade of the axe. If there was any doubt about the unnatural status of the Ring left in her, it would have disappeared then. Catra briefly wondered how She-Ra's sword might have fared against the Ring, but she quickly banished the thought. Now was not the time to dwell on that.

"The Ring cannot be destroyed Gimli, Son of Gloin, by any craft we here possess." Elrond explained. "It was made in the fires of Mount Doom. And only there it can be unmade. The Ring must be taken deep into Mordor and cast back into the fiery chasm from whence it came. One of you must do this." A great, deep silence filled the Council. No one said anything.

'Well, isn't this just a fine collection of Heroes?' Catra spat in her mind. If any of those damned Princesses had been here, they would've practically jumped at the chance. Double that for Sparkles and Adora. To her great personal dismay though, it was yet again Boromir who spoke next.

"One does not simply walk into Mordor." He said almost defeated. "Its Black Gates are guarded by more than just Orcs. There is an Evil there that does not sleep, the Great Eye is ever watchful. It is a barren wasteland riddled with fire, ash, and dust. The very air you breathe a poisonous fume. Not with ten thousand men could you do this. It is folly."

“Of course it’s folly if your first instinct was to take the place head on with an army.” Catra said, the gears instilled in her mind by years of strategist study having begun to turn through the Gondorian’s monologue. “If this quest is to succeed, the best course of action would not be to merely walk into Mordor, but to sneak in and draw as little attention to yourself as possible. All you’d really need is a good minimum of two or three people light enough on their feet and beneath notice enough to fool the Orcs. And try to find a way inside less obvious than the Black Gate, see if Sauron has some sort of back door that he doesn’t keep heavy watch at.”

“And I suppose you think you’re the one to do it lass?” Gimli countered. “The Wizard may vouch for you, but what do you stand to gain?”

“And what happens if you fail?” Boromir added. “What happens when Sauron takes back what is his?” Catra had officially had it with this man.

“Well, I’d still probably last longer than if I tried to use the enemy’s not so secret weapon against them!” She shouted. “I’ve been down that road before, and trust me, it sure as Hell isn’t worth it!”

“The Ring corrupts any who hold it!” Legolas countered, aghast. “What makes you think you’d be able to resist it before you even approached Sauron’s borders?!”

“Oh what?!” Catra shouted back, having totally lost her cool. “You wanna give it a go, Blondie?!” This in turn, set Gimli off.

“I’ll be DEAD before I see the Ring in the hands of an ELF!!!” And so, much like accidentally bumping a hand into a close packed group of painstakingly balanced figurines, all Hell broke loose between any member of the Council who wasn’t one Frodo Baggins of the Shire. The ruckus was so loud, that only Catra’s powerful ears and the general wariness of Gandalf allowed them to notice the drowned out but strong in conviction declaration of

the small Hobbit the first time he attempted to raise his voice over the din.

"I WILL TAKE IT!" One by one, the individuals next to Catra and Gandalf noticed what had distracted them.

"I will take it!" The Hobbit declared again as the Council grew quiet. "I will take the Ring to Mordor. Though I do not know the way…" Catra stood in shock much like the others, Frodo had been silent for the entire Council. So silent to the point that she had almost forgotten that he was there. Her mind raced. What could have possessed such a simple, innocent Hobbit to work up the conviction to march headlong into a place that from its description made the Fright Zone sound like a pleasant meadow? She turned to Gandalf, a heavy and sorrowful look in his eye. He clearly understood the implications far more than she did. The Wizard stepped forward.

"I will help you bear this burden, Frodo Baggins, as long as it is yours to bear." Gandalf said heavily, at this, Aragorn stepped forth to kneel before the Hobbit.

"If by my life or my death I can protect you, I will." Swore the Ranger. "You have my sword."

"And you have my bow!" Legolas chimed in.

"And my axe!" Supplied Gimli, Catra gave a smirk, 'Let's hope he doesn't mean the one he just smashed to pieces.' Boromir stepped forward as well.

"You carry the Fate of us all little one. If this is indeed the rule of the Council… Then Gondor will see it done." That was enough for Catra. Ever since Frodo had declared he'd undergo the quest, Catra had felt something well up in her the likes of which she hadn't felt in three and a half years, something that felt like a chance for something. Redemption maybe, but probably not if she was being honest. But regardless, she was not going to pass this

up. With a deep breath, she steeled herself and walked to Frodo as well.

"You're going to need all the help you can get Baggins, and it's about time I did something actually worthwhile in my life. Count me in." Elrond looked like he was ready to say something, when a voice from the nearby bushes turned everyone's heads.

"HEY!" Out from the brush emerged Samwise Gamgee, sprinting beside Frodo.

"Mr. Frodo's not going anywhere without me!" He exclaimed, daring anyone present to challenge him.

"No. Indeed it is hard to separate you, even when he is summoned to a secret Council and you are not." Elrond said plainly, Catra had the distinct feeling the Elf just wanted to officially get this whole disaster over with.

"We're coming too!" Came a shout from the hall as Merry and Pippin revealed themselves, and from the look on his face, Elrond was truly at his wit's end. And seemed like he was ready to personally murder the next uninvited guest that volunteered to join the quest.

"You'll have to send us home tied up in a sack to stop us!" Merry declared.

"Yes!" Pippin agreed. "After all you need people of intelligence on this sort of mission… Quest… Thing."

"Something tells me Miss Catra's got that covered Pip." Merry muttered. Elrond did not want to chance another second.

"Ten Companions." Elrond said, looking over the now assembled group. "So be it…"

"You shall be the Fellowship of the Ring."

“Great!” Pippin said, then paused. “Where are we going?”

“Yeah.” Catra said matter of factly. “We’re all gonna die, aren’t we?”

The Fellowship of the Ring Part II

The Ring Goes South

Catra hadn't expected how nice it would be to traverse the wilds of Arda again after what had to be the second most stressful meeting of her life. The most stressful one had kept her mane in tangles for a good month afterward and led to the near destruction of the Fright Zone's training room. This one was thankfully remedied by two and a half weeks of camping and traveling. Even if a certain shield bearing Gondorian was still very much present and occasionally on her nerves.

Gandalf was a given for welcome company if she absolutely had to be around other people as possibly her first and only positive authority figure in her life. He really had that grandpa thing down to a science.

In Aragorn's case, he was practically all but officially her on and off Hunting Buddy ever since halfway through year one of her new life. That being said though, she made a mental note to have a talk with him as soon as they set out about being fully open about his past and identity, to which the Heir of Isildur promptly replied that he'd be glad to as soon as she was ready to do the same. Touché Strider, touché.

She had found herself warming up to the Hobbits a lot faster than she expected. Merry in particular had found himself in the enviable position of the few people who Catra let out-snark her without her attempting to gut them. Catra occasionally felt herself wondering how a pre-portal version of herself would react to sharing space with four others who had apparently decided that being overly friendly was the most admirable virtue in life. Once again, it would have more than likely involved a lot of unnecessary clawing followed by cold hearted indifference. Hindsight is a real pain.

She felt a bit too hesitant to interact more than was required or requested in regards to Legolas and Gimli on account of the clear distrust and tension between them. She would have compared said tension to what she suspected she and a certain other blonde she tried not to think about too much had, but she did not want to be presumptuous on the nature of either pair in question.

Boromir, Catra decided, was the Fellowship's greatest liability. An understandable liability once Gandalf and Aragorn had updated her on the situation in Gondor, but a liability nonetheless. He reminded her a bit too much of her younger self all things considered. Well, if her younger self had been Shadow Weaver's favorite instead anyway. Catra figured that he'd probably be a lot easier to get along with if there wasn't a malevolent piece of jewelry with an apparent mind of its own in their midst.

And so stood her feelings on the rest of the Fellowship as they stopped for the night near where the forests of Eregion gave way to the plains of Dunland. Catra and Aragorn had managed to catch a pair of deer for the night's protein, which the group was just finishing up as Gandalf and anyone else present who was of the habit lit their pipes. An uncomfortable silence filled the campground underscored by the mixed amusement and innocent bewilderment on the faces of the Hobbits following the last topic of campfire discussion, a quite uncomfortable roundabout wherein the Fellowship had all decided they now officially knew quite enough regarding each other's experience regarding their love lives, and too much about those of their Halfling companions.

Desperate for that to not be the last thing in his mind before they retired for the night, Boromir surprised everyone by actually being cordial to Catra for once.

"So, you are the Wildcat of Arnor." He started. "Outside of the obvious, what did you do to receive such a title?" Wanting just as much to get away from her near and almost compulsory overshare about the woman who was in many ways long gone

from her life as everyone else was to get away from the courting habits of Hobbits, Catra found herself more than ready to talk about something involving her that was actually pleasant.

"Believe it or not, that's not actually the first time I've been called 'Wildcat', but I guess that's beside the point considering my species, whatever it is. I'll have to start by saying, I was a really terrible person when I was younger. It was about half a year after I came here and a really bad storm had gotten me stuck in some caves east of Angmar, near this massive mountain."

"That would be Mount Gundabad." Aragorn supplied. "A very harrowing place. I had warned you about going that way if I recall correctly."

"Well, I'm kind of both glad and regretful that I ignored you after what happened that night." Catra said. "So if anything, it's a mixed bag considering that it gave me the motivation to start turning my life around after being raised as a soldier on the very wrong side of a war. I got the fright of my life and came out of that cave a slightly different person. Decided to take out the resulting stress and anger issues on whatever I could find that actually deserved it for once. Which I think is the first time the people living Northward were thankful for their Orc, Troll, and Warg problem as those monsters were getting the business end of my teen years made manifest, and not the people living there. I treated the whole thing as my second second chance and it turns out the whole Hero thing kind of goes a long way toward people tolerating someone like me. Mostly anyway, a lot of them just saw me as an extra hairy Ranger."

"And what do you mean by a second second chance, lass?" Gimli asked.

"When I was younger, I briefly made it out of the uh, it was basically a military cult really, that I was raised in, and had a chance to start over. Some stuff happened and I threw it all away. I made some really bad decisions, all of reality started to fall apart around me, the only person I've ever cared about disowns me, I

fall into a crack in the universe, and next thing I know, I've fallen into the Bruinen River and Aragorn happened to be near enough to fish me out." Gimli let out a chuckle.

"You wouldn't be the oddest thing to have been found in a river." He said. "My father and twelve of our kinsmen found themselves stuffed into barrels and sent downriver to Lake Town on their way to reclaim our homeland from a dragon."

"Okay, I know this is rich coming from the one who fell here from another world, but you've got to be making that one up." Catra said with a hearty chuckle of her own.

"Unfortunately, he is not." Legolas said plainly.

"How would you know? It's not like you were there or something." Legolas stared at her.

"I saw it myself as the company escaped from my father's dungeons. One of them looked like he nearly drowned."

"Oh." Catra had managed to hear a few things regarding Tharanduil in the past weeks. He definitely seemed like the kind of ruler prone to preemptive locking up of Dwarves. Even still, she had a hard time believing this story. So keeping up her jesting tone, Catra supplied her next query. "So who's harebrained escape plan was that then?"

"That would be my Uncle's." Frodo said in a matter of fact tone.

"Okay, guys, be honest with me, is this really your best idea for a prank?" The Fellowship members in the know exchanged a few glances. Gandalf merely allowed himself a wry smile.

"Guys?"

Suffice to say, updating Catra on the tales of Bilbo Baggins' adventures proved to be much more pleasant dinner conversation in the following days than some of the alternatives.

The Fellowship trekked on, passing a set of long abandoned ruins as the miles drifted by. They had gone two whole days since the Hobbits had ran out of songs to sing to bide the time and Catra was beginning to wonder just how much of this land there really was as they set up camp among a copse of rocks and brush. There had been been talk about the ever closing distance to the Gap of Rohan, and Catra found herself still internally debating on whether this was the right course.

Soon after they had left Rivendell, Gandalf had told her of the recent betrayal of Saruman the White, the apparent former head of his Order. Catra gave a small huff at the memory, not all that impressed by how said Order had apparently panned out in the long run. The two Blue Wizards had gone AWOL and hadn't been seen in ages, the Brown Wizard retreated to the wilds to live among the smaller creatures of the world, and now the White had sided with the former servant of a primordial force of Evil itself. What was it with magical alliances formed to do good being really ineffective at their jobs? At least Gandalf hadn't abandoned his mission in favor of renting out his services to birthday parties full time.

Catra let out another sigh as she took the time to look at the surrounding countryside. In all of her time in Arda, this had been the farthest South that she had wandered. If she had to be honest, it was probably about time that she had anyway. The forests and tundras of the North had their charms, but she had never seen a rocky plain like this before in her life. And with Legolas' occasional talk of the Greenwood and Gimli's boasting of the Lonely Mountain as she learned more of the quest for it, combined with her wonderings of what awaited the Fellowship in Rohan and beyond, she decided that she might as well see all she could while she had the means to. Well, if she didn't get herself killed in the meantime of course.

Casting her gaze over the range of the Misty Mountains one last time, Catra stood and began to collect a series of moderately

sized pebbles. Her task done, she set the pebbles upon larger rocks a few yards away from where Boromir was running sword training drills with Merry and Pippin. Uncoiling her whip, she gave a few practice swings before lashing out at the balanced pebbles, knocking them from their perches. The clangs of steel upon steel and the cracking of the whip echoed down the hill as Gandalf and Gimli debated the prospect of taking the passage to Moria, a Dwarven Kingdom that Catra had heard of a few times in passing before. She found it curious that a people would choose to live underground, but at the same time could not help but find it within herself to see an appeal to it.

The sparring match between the Gondorian and Hobbits had taken a downhill turn as the duo tackled Boromir, inadvertently drawing Aragorn into the impromptu wrestling match as well. Catra paused to allow herself an amused smirk. A smirk that disappeared as her gaze turned to Legolas as he peered ever Southward. Catra knew of the impossibly impeccable sight of the Elves, turning her line of sight to match his, her own eyes spotted something quite out of the ordinary.

“What is that?” She asked loud enough for the rest of the party to take notice, pointing at the anomaly.

“Nothing.” Gimli postulated. “Just a wisp of cloud.”

“It’s moving fast.” Boromir said.

“And against the wind.” Catra thought out loud. Legolas’ eyes widened as the mass grew close enough for him to accurately discern its nature.

“Crebain from Dunland!” He exclaimed.

“HIDE!” Aragorn ordered, and the camp descended into chaos as the Fellowship made to hide both themselves and any sign that they were there. From her spot between two large rocks, a crouching Catra watched as a storm of very large crows swept over the area, with the way they flew, it was clear to her that this

was no normal flock of birds. As quick as they had come, they retreated, flying back in the direction from which they had approached. The Fellowship emerged from hiding.

"Spies of Saruman!" Gandalf stated, confirming Catra's suspicion. "The Gap of Rohan is no longer open to us." Gandalf turned to face the mountains, his gaze focusing on the most notably largest summit in this part of the range.

"We must take the Pass of Caradhras!" The rest of the Fellowship looked at the mountains looming in the distance.

"I don't suppose anyone packed snow gear?" Catra asked.

Catra had heard of the Mountain called Caradhras in passing once from a traveler a few tables from her favorite secluded corner within the Prancing Pony. The pass in particular apparently had gained something of a reputation for its almost unusual treachery, coming to be known as Caradhras the Cruel. At the time, she had taken it to be just another piece of the enormous tapestry of folklore coming from a land that hadn't had nearly all of its history destroyed thoroughly by a malevolent force such as the Horde, instead surviving a succession of Dark Lords that did not care to utterly destroy their enemies' cultures in favor of merely wiping the people themselves out.

Catra had known for a while now that she could be just as wrong as every other sentient being from time to time.

And so now here she found herself clutching her cloak as close to herself as she possibly could, her tail wrapped around her right leg in a desperate attempt to spare it from the biting cold of the blizzard the Fellowship had been trapped in. She was at least thankful that her hood had managed to not be blown back in the torrential winds. If you had told her now that the mountain had a malevolent mind of its own, she would have taken your word for it, and likely with a small snark at your expense for pointing out

the obvious if her teeth hadn't been chattering so hard. Her fur did keep her warmer than most people, but a place such as this had only two states: cold as a snowman's heart, and the freezing depths of a dying galaxy.

"How were they even able to chart this pass?!" Catra yelled over the wind.

"The storm should not be this strong!" Aragorn said. "There is something else at play here!" Legolas paused from his position at the head of the group.

"There is a fell voice in the air!" Catra leant against the rock face and strained her ears, the Elf was right. She could just barely make out something over the roaring wind. Something deep and rhythmic. A little more focus and she was able to identify it as a great and commanding voice chanting in some form of ancient tongue unknown to her.

"It's Saruman!!!" Gandalf declared just as a bolt of lightning stuck the cliff above them.

"He's trying to bring down the mountain!" Aragorn shouted as another bolt hit and sent a small avalanche down upon them!

"BRACE!" Catra managed to shout just before all ten of them were buried beneath the snow…

For her whole life, Catra had scrapped and clawed her way to any goal she had set before her. There was no way that she intended to die frozen upon a mountain, buried beneath snow and rock only for her mummified remains to be found generations later by some enterprising anthropologist.

"Who do you suppose this group was?"

"Why, she looks like she could be the fabled Wildcat of Arnor."

“She must have been very foolish to come all this way without proper preparation and get herself frozen to death.”

“Quite right you are my friend, very foolish indeed.”

Screw. That.

With a mighty heave, Catra dug herself out of the drift, quickly finding to her relief that the rest of the Fellowship had managed to survive as well.

“Well, that sure was fun!” She grumbled to herself.

“This path is lost!” Boromir shouted. “We make for the Gap of Rohan!”

“No!” Gandalf exclaimed. “It is also too dangerous!”

“I say we pass through the Mines of Moria!” Gimli said. “My cousin Balin will welcome this!”

“Whatever we do, we’d better do it quick!” Catra added as she took stock of everyone’s current state. “The Hobbits won’t be able to take much more of this!” Gandalf paused briefly.

“Let the Ringbearer decide.” They all turned to Frodo as he weighed his options.

“We will go through the Mines.” He declared. Gandalf took a heavy breath.

“So be it.”

The Journey in the Dark

Despite Gandalf's clear apprehension regarding Moria, it was clear that everyone's spirits had taken a drastic upturn as soon as they had gotten out of the main pass and made their way down a lower mountain road, even if the place itself had a desolate gloom to it. They had been walking long since the sun had rested now, and Catra for her part was beginning to wonder if this route was preferable to chancing the Gap. She was of the mind that if she went her whole life without meeting Saruman, then it would be a life well spent, if incredibly turbulent at the beginning. She was brought out of her thoughts by a ringing clang of steel on stone. Turning her head up, Catra was met with the sight of Gimli tapping his walking axe along the stone faced cliff that overlooked the water to their right.

"Dwarf doors are invisible when closed." Gimli explained. "And they can be quite difficult to find if their secrets are lost."

"Indeed Gimli." Gandalf said. "Sometimes not even their own masters can find them."

"Why does that not surprise me?" Snarked Legolas. Ignoring him, Gimli continued.

"My cousin and his fellows retook the Mines from the East, so there is no telling if the West entrance is still in use yet."

"Is there any way of telling if we are even on the right road?" Catra asked. "If what you're saying is true, this door could be anywhere!"

"Do not worry Catra, I have walked this road before." Gandalf said as he examined a section of the wall, his fingers crossing over a clearly carved in indent. "Ah, ithildin. A substance that mirrors starlight, and moonlight." At that, the Wizard looked to the sky above just in time to witness the clouds part and reveal the moon.

Within seconds a great intricate design lit up upon the wall, featuring a set of images depicting emblems of Dwarven heraldry

and two trees that Catra figured were equally as important, as well as an arch of script.

"It reads." Gandalf said. "'Doors of Durin, Lord of Moria. Speak friend, and enter.'" Catra examined the writing.

"That's not Dwarven writing." Catra had figured that she was pretty lucky that something had allowed her to understand and read the common language of Middle Earth. Arwen had once offered to teach her to read Elven script, with some degree of success. But this was of a much, much older iteration.

"Yes, it is Elvish. The last part reads 'I, Narvi, made them. Celebrimbor of Hollin drew these signs.'"

"So the Elves and Dwarves weren't always arguing like children over the last ration bar?" Catra said. "What happened?"

"A disagreement broke out over a great jewel called a Silmaril, one of the three of its kind." Gandalf explained.

"Are all wars in this world started over magic jewelry?" Catra asked with a raised eyebrow. "Or just the ones worth writing about?"

"It would do more good for you to turn that ever working mind of yours from smart remarks to devising answers. As these doors are sealed unless one knows the correct word to say, and I may need assistance if any of the phrases I have in mind turn out to be of no use!"

"Okay, figure out the secret of the magic doors. I usually left that to the Princesses back home."

"These Princesses you speak of." Legolas asked. "Who were they to investigate secretive doors?"

"They were the rulers of the few nations of my home world." Catra said with slight discomfort. "We in the Horde were brought up being told that they were an Evil group bent on subjugating all

with their magic. I never really stopped to think on if that was a lie of course, despite the fact that the woman that was the closest thing I had to a mother had a habit of regularly torturing me with magic as a punishment."

"If torture was her manner of punishment." Gimli stated. "That woman was no real mother to you."

"My father may be harsh, especially to my brother." Boromir added. "But he never lowered himself to that."

"I know." Catra said ruefully. "Hindsight sure is something else isn't it? Anyway the current iteration of the Princess Alliance, and I can't believe I'm about to say this, truly had the protection of our world in their best interest and thought they could benefit from the artifacts of advanced technology and ancient magic left over from a race of people we called the First Ones. Who from the looks of things had the same preference in design to your people Gimli." Catra paused as Gandalf gave up trying to open the doors, frustrated as he sat upon a rock grumbling to himself before getting up to try again.

"It turned out that someone had the answers to making some of it work after all. But if you ask me, the fact that she managed to figure it out just led to a lot more bad than good for either their mission, or the Horde's for that matter."

"This person, you speak as if you knew her." Legolas said. "She wouldn't happen to be?"

"Yes. She was my only friend, the one I told you about... Maybe even more in my deepest of hopes. She and I did everything together, but then the universe in all its apparent wisdom, or boredom more likely, put a great epic path before her and she made a choice. And I made the greatest mistake of my life not following her."

"A mistake it may have been lass." Gimli said. "But you are in a much different place now than you were at that time. Perhaps you

will see her again."

"I don't know about that. I spent a good bit of the last two or so years trying to figure out just where here is in relation to my world, and even if I could find a way back, I'm sure she'd want nothing to do with me anymore. I nearly destroyed our home in a jealous fit and fell through a hole in reality for what felt like forever. For all intents and purposes, I'm beginning to think that this world is my home now. And after everything I've been through, I intend to try saving this one instead of destroying it."

"Then it would seem that you are in the right company for that." Legolas said. Catra gave a humorless, yet somehow simultaneously hopeful chuckle.

"You know, you guys aren't so bad when you're not trying to get one over on each other." Hang on, Catra's thoughts realized, is this what having friends is supposed to feel like? What a head trip.

SPLOOSH!

Pippin had apparently taken to tossing stones into the lake to relieve boredom. Catra couldn't blame him for that, her squad mates back in the day had resorted to much weirder pastimes to kill any extra hours. Aragorn apparently thought differently, scolding the Hobbit for disturbing the waters. The Ranger had an intuition that could rival the Elves sometimes, and in Catra's experience that had made the difference between life and death on some of their outings in the past. She eyed the lake wearily for the next hour, occasionally breaking that watch to discuss the merits of various dishes involving fish with Sam. Merry for his part was pacing back and forth in front of the doors, while Gandalf and Frodo sat in near contemplative silence. Catra gave a look to the doors to have a go at pondering their secrets herself, Gimli was starting to get a bit restless.

"Speak friend and enter." Merry said looking at the doors. "Hang on, it's a riddle! Isn't it?!" At that Frodo got up from his seat and beheld the doors himself, then turned to the Wizard.

“What’s the Elvish word for friend?” Gandalf looked to the doors.

“Mellon.”

A deep rumble resounded from within the stone walls, and soon with a grinding creek, the Doors of Durin slid open. Upon their opening, a small blast of air issued from the hole in the mountain, bringing with it a peculiar stale scent that practically uppercutted Catra’s nostrils. It was strange, yet familiar somehow. Slowly, the Fellowship entered the first chamber, and Catra elected to ignore the now more potent stench that joined that of dust and old stone. Gandalf attached a crystal to the top of his staff, which soon began to glow with a soft white light.

“Soon Master Elf, you will know the hospitality of the Dwarves!” Gimli announced as they filed in.

“Roaring fires, malt beer, ripe meat off the bone! This my friends is the home of my cousin, Balin.” The Dwarf continued, practically roaring with elation. “And they call it a mine. A mine!” Boromir landed a step that issued forth a sickening crunch beneath his boot. Catra, who was next to him at the time, looked down at what he had stepped on along with him.

“This is no mine.” He said gravely. “It’s a tomb.” Her eyes widened, Catra had been met with the clear sight of a fully decayed Dwarf skeleton, covered in dust, cobwebs, and what remained of its shattered armor. Its jaw limply lay upon its neck in a perpetual scream of dread.

Catra had seen Death before, having grown up in war and spent the last few years galavanting around the North, slaying any stray Goblin, Warg, or Troll who had been getting ideas of terrorizing the locals, but never had she seen the clear remnants of a battle whose news would not travel to anyone. Not even a single survivor to at the very least burn the fallen, their bodies left to the ravages of time. This skeleton was once a living person with

thoughts, aspirations, and even a family of its own. She seized up as Gimli realized what had become of his kin, howling in sorrow.

Legolas approached one of the corpses and plucked an arrow shaft from its breastplate, examining the plumed fletching. "Goblins!"

He cast the shaft aside as if it would burn through his skin should he hold it any longer. Catra managed to steady her breathing. She shook her head, confused as to what had just happened to her. She did not have any time to ponder upon it as her left ear twitched, picking up the unmistakable sound of…

Moving water?

She was too late, whipping around to look behind the group as a massive tentacle shot from the water's edge outside and grabbed Frodo by the leg, wrenching him outwards!

"Sam!" The Hobbit cried to his companion, and the gardener acted!

"Strider!" Aragorn turned to face the threat as well, and Catra was already ahead of him. Thinking quick, she dashed back outside and slid to a stop, couching as she went to pick up a branch of long dried wood that had drifted ashore as an arrow whistled past her head. The arrow impacted with something beneath the surface, causing the tentacle to drop Frodo only for another to shoot up and take its place! By then, several more reached out from the waters in attempt to keep the Fellowship away from the Ringbearer. Aragorn sliced one at the arm clean off with his sword, a throwing axe from Gimli impacted another, and Catra drove her improvised spear into her closest target, embedding it into the ground!

"What is this thing?!" She exclaimed, narrowly dodging another appendage. The beast gave off the most terrible stench Catra had smelt in her entire life, and the waters seemed to boil with the thrashing of its many tentacles.

"It does not matter!" Boromir exclaimed. "We must drive it off!" Sam managed to get close enough to the tentacle holding Frodo and let forth a mighty swing with his barrow-blade, cleaving the appendage off and allowing Aragorn to catch the falling Hobbit! Gandalf saw this and rallied the group back.

"Into the Mines!" He shouted, and Legolas fired off one last shot to stall the creature before dashing back in himself, narrowly missing getting crushed by falling stone as the tentacles rent the Doors of Durin to rubble behind them!

For a while, all was dark. The only sounds to be heard being the Fellowship collecting their breath.

"Is… Is everyone alright?" Catra asked. Her eyes adjusted, and a quick headcount showed everyone was okay.

"We now have but one choice." Gandalf said as he re-lit his staff. "We must face the long, dark of Moria. Be on your guard. It is a four day's journey to the other side, and there are older, and fouler things than Orcs in the deep places of the world."

'No kidding.' Catra thought. 'That thing could have gone for any of us, but went straight for Frodo. It had to be after the Ring, and it knew where to get it.' Filing the disquieting implications for later, Catra followed along, taking her place in the Fellowship's procession just a couple places shy of the rear. After they had cleared a few winding halls that seemed to go ever deeper into the earth, Sam looked up to her.

"Miss Catra?" He asked in a small whisper from behind her.

"Yes Sam, what is it?" She responded, also keeping her voice down, the groups most recent misadventure had caused all of them to keep their guard up.

"I saw you freeze for a bit before that thing grabbed Mr. Frodo. And I was wondering how you were holding up. A cousin of mine acted like that a lot after he nearly got himself drowned one summer. He kept saying that things that reminded him of it

enough brought his mind back to it." Catra knew what the Hobbit was talking about. Since the Horde saw no need for psychiatric experts, the cadets only knew the condition by the moniker of "battle shock". A lot of the older soldiers and Force Captains had it, particularly the ones with quite a collection of physical scars as well. As for Catra…

"Yeah, I think it might be the same thing. Or something like it. Seeing all those bodies it… It reminded me of something I did before I came here. Something I'll never be able to take back." Unwittingly, flashes of overheard words and the sight of a distinct silhouette making its way to deactivate that damned portal raked through her mind, the message clear. "Your fault. You did this. You do nothing but destroy." Catra clutched onto the sides of her cloak, trying to steady her breathing before she ended up re experiencing that night at Mount Gundabad.

"I messed up real bad that day Sam, nearly dying isn't the only thing that can haunt you."

"Well, if you ever need to talk about it, just remember that you've got me, Mr. Frodo, and the rest of us here. We might not fully understand, but we can try."

"Thanks Sam. I'll keep that in mind."

Just when Catra thought she'd go mad from having to travel down yet another uniform passage, the hall opened up into a narrow, yet incredibly deep cavern. Littered about were long discarded mining tools of all sorts. As the Fellowship made to shimmy along an almost haphazard pathway, Gandalf spoke.

"The wealth of Moria was not in gold, or jewels." He explained, casting his staff's light upon a seam of ore that Catra swore held an otherworldly glow to it, even in the dark of the mine and still lancing through the rock. "But in mithril."

"Mithril?" Catra asked, awaiting clarification.

“A very rare and unique metal.” Gimli said. “Only found in the deepest of seams. Lightweight, versatile, it is fashioned into the finest and hardiest jewelry and arms. There is seldom a warrior who falls in battle when they are adorned and armed with it.”

“Yes Gimli,” Gandalf said. “In fact, Bilbo had a shirt fashioned out of mithril rings, given to him by Thorin.”

“Ah, a kingly gift indeed!”

“I never told him, but its worth was greater than that of the Shire itself!” Catra gave a chuff of bemusement.

“I’d bet my tail that Hordak would have loved to get his gnarled hands on some of this stuff. It sounds even stronger than any of the metal back in my world.”

“What do you suppose became of this man?” Aragorn asked.

“Last I saw him, he was getting more vulnerable by the day without his armor. If the war is still going on, something tells me he’d be the least of the Rebellion’s worries. The witch who ‘raised’ me on the other hand, she’s only steps away from becoming Saruman’s ideal tea party guest.”

“If that is the case,” Boromir said. “Then it is most fortunate that you were the only one to travel here.”

“For the rest of you? Definitely. The last thing the Hobbits need to hear is all the stuff I’ve got to say to her.”

“We are right here you know!” Griped an indignant Pippin.

They marched on in silence for three days and change, their only company each other and the occasional noise of draft, falling silt, and dripping water. To break the monotony, Catra elected to teach the others a game she and her squad had created growing up to help each other get to sleep. Having not the most creativity in

distraction, the best title for the game they could devise was "What I See". The object of the game was for one person to pick an object within their sight and vaguely describe it to the others in hopes that they could figure out what said item is. Whoever guessed correctly had the next pick of the object. It was a very limited and repetitive game, and pretty much everything currently surrounding the Fellowship was either a personal item of theirs or made of rock. You do the math.

The Fellowship climbed a stair, at the top sat a set of three corridors.

"No Merry." Catra sighed, her voice laced with regret. "It's not Gandalf's hat. You've guessed that four times already." By the looks on the rest of the party's faces, they were equally as regretful of humoring Catra in regards to the game in the first place. At the top of the stair, Gandalf stopped to a full halt and glanced about the area.

"I have no memory of this place."

It was hard to count the hours in Moria, and at this point, Catra was actually ready to try her hand at bargaining with the universe for something to entertain her, like a book, a page from a book even. Hell, she'd even take a length of string at this point. Then, she heard it again. A slight shuffling. Frodo had noticed it too, and told Gandalf as such.

"It's Gollum." Gandalf said simply. "He's been following us for three days."

"Tenacious little sucker." Catra said, eyes investigating the nearby chasm. "Must've found a smaller way in. What even is he?"

"He was something not unlike a Hobbit once, Sméagol he was called, before the Ring took and twisted him. For a long time he had the One, before as you know, Bilbo encountered him."

“It’s a pity that Bilbo didn’t kill him when he had the chance.” Frodo said.

“Pity?” Gandalf asked. “Pity is what stayed Bilbo’s hand. Many that live deserve death. Some that die deserve life. Can you give it to them Frodo? Do not be too eager to give out death in punishment. Even the wise can not see all ends.”

“If all who deserved death were given it,” Catra said, mostly to herself. “I wouldn’t even be here right now.”

“And you, much like my heart tells me is the same for Gollum, may yet have a part to play in the coming days. For good or ill. Before this is over.”

Catra tuned out the rest of the conversation, deep in thought. How would have Shadow Weaver reacted to Gollum? More than likely the witch would have roasted the wretch on the spot. Even so, Gandalf at least implied that there was potential in the creature for some sort of redemption. And if it could be offered to Gollum of all things, then there truly was hope for her to make up for her past yet.

“Oh!” Gandalf exclaimed after a prolonged silence, almost out of nowhere.

“He’s remembered!” Merry said, getting up from his seat.

“Not remembered.” Gandalf said as he made his way to one of the halls. “The air down here doesn’t smell as foul. When in doubt Meriadoc Brandybuck, always follow your nose.”

“Hear, hear.” Catra said with a modicum of smugness.

“And when has your nose led you into anything but trouble Catra?” Aragorn said teasingly.

“Don’t you have another name to go collect ‘Estel’?”

“I can scarcely believe it, but I think I’d rather subject myself to the Seeing Game than listen to them pretend to argue again.” Boromir grumbled.

The Fellowship of the Ring Part III

The Bridge of Khazad-Dum

This hall was blessedly much shorter than many of the others found throughout Moria's depths. It was only a good five minutes down this latest passage before it opened up into a great spacious hall, possibly miles long and wide, supported by great geometric columns. Gandalf decided to risk a more brilliant light from his staff's crystal, shining upon the immediate area to bring more detail to the breathtaking sight.

"Behold, the 21st hall of Dwarrowdelf." Catra found herself struck frozen at the great sight, of all the places she had been to in her life, no other held such a wealth of grand history and odd sadness in the act of its abandonment. Not that it was exactly a high bar at the moment, but nonetheless, the Dwarves of ages past outdid anything the First Ones or any modern society could hope to achieve.

'But what was the cost of it?' She thought. 'Generations of work apparently undone by Goblins alone. And gone just like the First Ones, victims of their own grandiosity.' The Fellowship stayed there in awe of the sight for a few more seconds, before their own resident Dwarf turned with a gasp and sprinted to a nearby room that was currently giving of a light of its own.

"Gimli!" Gandalf shouted in an urgent attempt to stop him before the group as a whole cut their losses and followed Gimli into the chamber. Catra was the last to enter skidding to a stop as she took in the remains of a group of Dwarves. They had seen more than their fair share of skeletons over the last three days, but this was the first area since the West entrance by Catra's reckoning to have such a volume of corpses. The room featured a well and balcony running all along three of its walls, but the light shone through some sort of crystal based mechanism highlighted the centerpiece of the room: a rectangular block of stone, flat on the top and bearing Khudzul runes. Gimli knelt before it, his eyes and

beard awash with sorrow as he sobbed his heart out. Catra approached the structure.

“Gandalf?…” She asked uneasily. Gandalf handed his staff and hat to Pippin before reading.

“Here lies Balin, Son of Fundin. Lord of Moria. He is dead then.” Catra knelt as well, tentatively putting a hand on Gimli’s shoulder. As the Fellowship stood in silence, Gandalf walked over to one of the bodies lying around the room, particularly one clutching onto a large tome. Catra stood as Gandalf picked up the book.

“They all must have died defending him.” Catra said softly. “To think I expected such loyalty without giving it in return.” Gandalf scanned through the book, reading from it to discover the account of Balin’s now failed expedition, soon he came to the last few entries.

“They have taken the bridge, and the second hall. We have barred the gates, but cannot hold them for long. The ground shakes… Drums, drums in the deep. We cannot get out. The shadow moves in the dark. We cannot get out. They are coming…” He turned to Gimli and held the now closed book out, the Dwarf understood the gesture, taking it and solemnly stowing it in his pack.

“We must move on.” Legolas said. “We cannot linger.”

“I don’t think we should be that worried Blondie.” Catra countered, her voice noticeably uneasy in spite of her apparent confidence. “These ones have clearly been here a long time and we haven’t seen any sign of a living Goblin since we got here, maybe they moved much deeper to the point they’d never notice us or they all died too.”

Unbeknownst to the rest of the Fellowship, Pippin had gotten curious and twisted the arrow stuck in the chest of the skeleton sitting atop the well, the action causing whatever was left keeping the head in place to finally decay and send the helmeted skull tumbling down, issuing cacophonous knocks as it fell. Those

sounds however, were nothing compared to the racket that followed as the rest of the corpse fell down as well, the sound so loud to the Fellowship that it seemed the impacts echoed across all of Moria.

"Fool of a Took!" Gandalf scolded, snatching his staff back. "Throw yourself in next time and rid us of your stupidity!" Despite everything, Catra found herself holding back a snerk of laughter. For his part, Pippin held his head in shame and embarrassment. The Fellowship slowly began to move, this time intending to leave.

THOOM

Everyone stopped dead in their tracks.

THOOM THOOM

'That…' Catra thought. 'Is not good.' Frodo drew his sword, Sting, the blade glowing a brilliant blue, a blue that was soon joined by the glow of Gandalf's own Elven blade.

THOOM THOOM THOOM THOOM

The deep pounding resounded across the caverns and passages of Moria, growing ever frequent and closer. Exchanging a glance between each other, the quartet of Aragorn, Legolas, Boromir, and Catra dashed to the double doors of Balin's Tomb to shut and brace them with anything they could find. Boromir managed to fully close the doors, narrowly missing an arrow that flew too close to his head for his comfort as a great roar resounded from outside.

"They have a Cave Troll."

Catra threw up the last of her improvised door braces and took her spot next to Boromir and Gandalf as Aragorn and Legolas readied their bows, the Hobbits huddling together behind them all. Gimli hopped upon Balin's last resting place, an axe in each hand.

“Let them come!” He shouted. “There is yet one Dwarf in Moria that still draws breath!” The door began to crack open, Catra extended her claws.

“Heh,” Catra said under her breath. “This might actually be fun.” Spears and halberds broke holes in the door, allowing Aragorn and Legolas to let off a few calculated shots. It was a couple seconds afterward that the doors split open in earnest, and the swarm of Goblins rushed in!

Aragorn forgoed his bow and drew his sword, joining Boromir in wading through the enemy, Legolas attempted to back up and regain the distance while firing all the way, but was eventually forced into close combat with his daggers. Gimli leapt from the sarcophagus to hack at the targets of his choice. Quickly surveying the mayhem, Catra crouched and made her move! Letting out a fearsome hiss, she charged forward to bob and weave through the crowd! Her incredibly sharp and iron tough claws rending through Goblin after Goblin, drenching her hands to the wrists in their warm, vile, tar black blood! The Goblins for their part desperately hacked and slashed at the beast that had been apparently set upon them, their weapons only succeeding in catching the ends of her cloak! The ones that she had wounded flailed about in their pain, clutching their wounds and occasionally stumbling into the waiting blades of the rest of the Fellowship!

Catra stopped, her initial rush dying down as he became acutely aware of what was currently coating her clawed hands.

“Ugh!” Catra exclaimed in revulsion, the foul stench of the bodily fluids assaulting her nose as she attempted to shake off the gore. “Disgusting!” Until this point, the only things to fall by her claws had been the game she hunted throughout the wild, at least those had smelt and felt like food. Her distraction had almost cost her life, and she narrowly dodged another blade with a “Whoa!”, the strike only managing to cut off another stray ribbon of her cloak!

An arrow whizzed by her head and stuck the offending Goblin, and she turned to see that Legolas had found some proper high

ground to shoot his targets, off to the side Sam was engaging the stragglers with both sword and frying pan of all things in hand. She exchanged a glance with the Elf, reviving a slight nod in turn. Turning to focus on the battle, Catra readied her whip; if her claws were to be out of the picture, a new strategy was needed. With a whoosh and a crack, the corded leather wrapped around a Goblin's blade and Catra yanked, pulling the sword from its hand and sending it tumbling to the ground to be beheaded by an overhead strike from Gimli! She caught the sword in midair with her right hand, only now realizing that this was the first time she had ever held one with intent to use it as her weapon in battle.

'Well, if Sam is managing…' Catra's thoughts supposed. Then she rushed forward to cover Gandalf's back as he swung sword and staff in turn. For their first real battle against something that wasn't a giant underwater abomination, the Fellowship was faring quite well. So of course that was when the Goblins decided to bring in their very large insurance.

Led into the tomb by two Goblins yanking at the chain around its neck, the great Cave Troll loped into the battle, holding aloft a mace that was comparable in size to Gimli. Catra had been trading clashes with a particularly vicious Goblin, and only just barely saw the edge of another jagged sharp blade rocket toward her from her left side. In a desperate move, she leaned backward and to the right to avoid it, but she had not acted fast enough. The smallest edge of the blade's tip raked at the middle of her left cheek in an upwards diagonal motion, barely missing her eye and continuing upwards to continue the cut, leaving another sizable gash ending just a small bit after where her eyebrow gave way to her forehead!

This was concurrent with the time of the Troll's first clumsy swing, and Catra was caught by the great mace! Fortunately, the swing had not come at full force, and merely knocked Catra across the room and into a spare rack of weapons, where she crashed clear through and hit the ground with a bounce and a skid!

Having witnessed this event, Frodo charged for the Troll, his sword raised above his head, and with a cry of “For the Shire!”, he dove and drove his blade into the beast’s foot! The Troll in turn, raised its head to the ceiling and bellowed in pain before diverting its attention to the Hobbit. Frodo’s eyes widened in realization of the consequence of his attack, and pulled Sting from the Troll, bolting to the far side of the room!

In its pursuit of the Ringbearer, the Troll ended up harming the Goblins who had wrangled it here more than it did the Fellowship. This allowed the group to refocus a bit, as Catra had managed to finally get up and shake the cobwebs from her brain. Ignoring the heated sting on the left side of her face, she dashed to help Boromir pull the beast back by taking its chain while Aragorn thrust an iron pike into its belly! This caused it to drop its mace, and swat the Ranger away with its bare hand! It then grabbed onto its own chain, yanking Boromir and Catra to the ground and the chain out of their grasp. The Troll then swung the chain at Legolas, who had been letting arrow after arrow into its hide this whole time. The chain caught on a crumbled pillar, the length of it becoming taught in the process. Legolas sprinted across it like a tightrope, mounting the Troll’s shoulders and sinking an arrow into the back of its neck before he was thrown off!

The chain broke, and now free to move, the Troll picked up the pike that had stabbed it and began to attack Frodo once more. The Hobbit managed to dodge three strikes as he was backed into a corner, and the fourth thrust hit true! With a pained groan and wide eyes, the Ringbearer fell to the ground.

There was a moment of shock as everyone witnessed this. Merry and Pippin were the first to move, leaping from a balcony to ride the Troll’s shoulders, stabbing into its hide as it tried to flail them off, Gimli swung an axe at its ankle, momentarily staggering it as Catra, who had recovered her weapons, thrust her borrowed sword into its side! These combined attacks caused the Troll to roar to the ceiling again, and Legolas fired an arrow directly into the soft underside of its jaw, where it sailed straight through to the brain!

At once, the demeanor of the beast changed entirely. It swayed about, almost shocked that it could be hurt like this, letting out a pathetic gurgling moan as it finally lurched forward. After a couple stumbles it fell to the floor of Balin's Tomb, stone dead.

"Frodo!" Sam shouted, dashing to his fallen friend. The rest of the Fellowship followed, Aragorn kneeling next to Sam where the Ringbearer lay. A few tense seconds passed as Aragorn picked up the Hobbit, who surprised everyone by moving of his own accord and gasping for air.

"He's alive!" Sam exclaimed.

"It's alright." Frodo wheezed. "I'm not hurt."

"How? That spear could have skewered a wild boar!" Aragorn asked.

"What does my former guardian have to do with this?" Catra said.

"I think that there is more to this Hobbit than meets the eye." Gandalf said as Frodo unbuttoned his shirt, revealing a familiar silver gleam from the mail coat he wore underneath.

"Mithril." Gimli stated in reverence. "You are full of surprises Master Baggins."

"I wonder which of the two of us is going to get the nastier bruise later." Catra said, turning to examine the dead Troll. She knelt down and took off the tattered remains of her cloak, cutting off a length of it with her claws. Wincing as she tried to open her left eye with little success, she had found at the very least she hadn't lost her use of it. She wiped the oozing blood from her wound with the back of her left hand and produced a salve made from Kingsfoil from her belt pouch, spreading it across the torn cloth before she brought it to her face with a hiss, pressing the cloth back and around her head, where she tied the makeshift bandage off. Before she stood, she grabbed the old Horde emblem belt buckle she had been using as her cloak clasp and stowed it in another pouch. It was her last piece of home now.

“You took a great cut yourself.” Boromir said as she had gone about this process. “How will you fare?”

“I think I’ll still have two eyes by the end of this.” Catra said. “It’s gotta be the second worst sting I’ve ever felt though.”

“That is likely the most fortunate outcome under the circumstances.” Aragorn noted as he helped Frodo to his feet.

“Yeah. Just don’t ask me to do anything that needs good depth perception until it’s healed up.” As Catra’s piece was said, a distant chorus of Goblin cries sounded from outside. “Didn’t we just finish this party?” Gandalf wasted no time.

“To the bridge of Khazad-Dum! Fly!”

While the bridge was indeed relatively close enough that the Fellowship would have made it in another relatively short walk should they have been undaunted and undiscovered, the Ten Walkers now had to become the Ten Marathon Runners as they flew from Balin’s Tomb and out into the hall! They did not make it far, as like a swarm of cockroaches, Goblin after Goblin emerged from holes in both the ceiling and the floors, crawling along the many columns before the Fellowship found themselves in a circle. Completely surrounded by a practical ocean of green skin and spiked armor. Catra for her part, had every intention of going down fighting if she was to end up being torn apart, Goblin innards on her claws be damned. As the horde grew ever closer, Gimli let out one last challenging snarl.

They did not hear it at first, but the Goblins sure had, and just as quickly as they had surrounded the Fellowship, the horde scattered back into their lairs. Gimli, apparently quite pleased with himself, let out a chuckle before it sounded again. Much louder this time. It was a strangely familiar sound to Catra, akin to the grinding of metal and concrete that could be heard in the most

industrial depths of the Fright Zone. Others who had witnessed such things would have likened it to the might of an erupting volcano. But it was much deeper, and more clear, almost as if it was not the sound of materials being moved, dropped, or fashioned into devices of war. This sounded strangely, and concerningly, like the roar of something alive. With a steady pace, an unnatural red-orange glow danced across the cavernous surfaces of the hall. Boromir walked up to Gandalf.

"What is this new devilry?" The Gondorian asked under his breath as the Wizard hung his head.

"A Balrog." Gandalf said. "A demon of the ancient world." Catra stared at the Wizard, disbelief in her eye. She could tell by the way that he had said it. Gandalf had known this whole time that whatever this thing was had been down here. This was why he had been so hesitant to come. Was it just her, or was the place getting hotter?

"This foe is beyond any of you." Gandalf finished. "RUN!!!"

Catra had probably never moved so fast in her life. In the back of her mind, she was really impressed, the Hobbits and Gimli seemed to have no problems keeping pace with the rest. But then again, running for one's life tended to bring out such a performance. Through the expansive halls and down a steep staircase they ran, coming to another, much larger staircase. There was no question to it now, Catra could see the flames billowing from the cracks in the floor in the next hall below. Whatever they were fleeing from was responsible for this sudden heat. An arrow clattered upon the stone stair, and the Fellowship turned to see Goblin archers firing upon them from a walkway.

"I thought they'd given up!" Catra exclaimed as she jumped over a gap in the stairs. Gandalf and Boromir followed her, and Aragorn and Legolas set to tossing the Hobbits to him until only Frodo was left. Legolas fired a shot, and the arrow sailed across the chasm,

striking clear through a Goblin's forehead, sticking itself into the stone behind it. The Goblin fell down the pit with a squeal, and another great rumble shook the mines, sending down a massive stone on the stair behind the Fellowship, leaving a lone pillar with Legolas, Aragorn, Gimli, and Frodo atop it. Legolas jumped the gap, and Aragorn made to pick up Gimli, who thrust his palm in front of him.

"Nobody tosses a Dwarf!" And the Dwarf in question made the greatest leap he could manage, only to find himself being weighed back by his signature double headed axe. Legolas thought quick and reached out to grab him. And grab him he did.

"Not the beard!!!" Despite it all, Catra winced, recalling an incident where a Force Captain had dragged her to Shadow Weaver by her at the time long, unruly mane of hair. Regardless, Gimli was now safely across, but the same could not be said of Aragorn and Frodo. Another tremor came, and the pillar began to crack! Aragorn and Frodo found themselves desperately leaning to and fro, trying to get the pillar to fall where they wished! Their efforts were not in vain as the pillar fell forward, and the duo leapt to be caught by Boromir and Legolas! They recovered quickly as they could, and the Fellowship fled down the rest of the remaining stair as fast as they could, coming to the currently burning hall. They weaved between the columns, dodging the flames as they went.

Gandalf stopped suddenly to direct the rest to make another turn, at last the bridge was in sight! As the others passed, he turned to the great gap behind him. Catra, who was the last to pass, noticed that the Wizard had not moved in her peripheral. She turned to beckon him to follow, but she never got the chance to speak, as from out of the depths emerged a massive shape! At least six meters tall it was, wreathed in shadow and flame, sporting great curved horns on the side of its skull like head, cloven hooves shaking the ground as it landed, its massive wings folding behind it as it stooped down to roar at its quarry. Durin's Bane had arrived. Catra found her voice.

“Oh, FUCK!”

What followed was what had to be the fastest 180 turn that Catra had ever taken in her life, breaking out into a brief sprint on all fours before recovering a typical bipedal stance. She could just barely hear the faint footfalls of Gandalf behind her over the thunderous strides of the demon chasing them. Was it just her, or did the final stretch of the hall before the bridge seem to go on forever?

It was just when Catra felt her lungs beginning to burn that she reached the start of the bridge. It was an oddly narrow thing, only allowing one, maybe two persons to comfortably walk across it abreast. Not that it mattered to the Fellowship, as they quickly assumed a single file position, running across the arching length. Catra skid to a stop as she reached the blessedly less treacherous staircase leading to the East Gate that had been carved into the cavern wall, she looked up from catching her breath to discover that the rest of the Fellowship had stopped dead in their tracks. She turned to look at the bridge. Gandalf stood alone in the center, still brandishing his staff and sword as the Balrog strode toward him.

“You cannot pass!” The Wizard commanded.

“Gandalf!” Exclaimed Frodo, who had to be held back by Boromir. The Balrog seemed to pause, as if measuring up the one who stood in its way.

“I am a servant of the Secret Fire,” Gandalf declared in a measured, yet commanding voice. “Wielder of the Flame of Anor. Dark fire will not avail you, Flame Udun!” Catra’s fur stood on end as she felt a noticeable change in the air. She had felt something very similar a few times before, always near any Runestones she had encountered. But this power felt even more imposing, more ancient.

The Balrog was undeterred, and summoned forth into its raised right hand a great sword made of flame, which it then swung down onto the Wizard! The blade shattered in an explosion of sparks upon a shield of ethereal light that surrounded Gandalf before dissipating a few seconds later!

"Go back to the Shadow…" Gandalf commanded again. The Balrog reached for something near its waist, and pulled out a glowing, red hot strand of plasma fashioned into the form of a whip, which it then lashed about. The energy in the air only seemed to increase, and Catra was getting a very uncomfortable sense of deja vu. Though the circumstances were entirely different, this was not the first time she had witnessed a person of great power stand to defend others against an insurmountable existential threat. Her chest tightened. Gandalf's face set into a more determined countenance as he brought both his weapons together and raised them over his head.

"YOU! SHALL NOT! PASS!!!" He declared, his voice echoing across the chasm as he brought his staff down, arcane energy lancing through the imperfections of the bridge in a brilliant flash of light! Undeterred, the Balrog simply snorted as if unimpressed and stepped forward, only to have the bridge crumble underneath him! The great beast seemed to almost fall in slow motion and Gandalf briefly looked down the pit, watching the demon fall. Catra let out the breath she didn't notice she'd been holding.

The Wizard turned to join the rest of the Fellowship, and the cavern was filled with the sound of rushing air followed by a deafening crack! The Balrog's whip had shot up and caught Gandalf by the ankle, pulling him down and off the bridge as he just barely managed to get a grip on the shattered edge! Catra seized up and Frodo tried with all his might to breach Boromir's grip with a cry! Gandalf desperately held on, just enough to make eye contact with the rest.

"Fly you fools!" And with that, Gandalf the Grey's grip gave out, and he fell into the abyss.

Catra could only barely hear Frodo's anguished prolonged cry of "No!", she could only see the Wizard fall. Distantly she heard someone cry out something that sounded like Aragorn's name and felt a firm grip on her shoulder that wrenched her to the side. She found herself running up the steps, past the gates, and into the light of day without even noticing, Goblin arrows uselessly clattering behind her. A few meters outside the East Gates of Moria, Catra fell to her knees. Suddenly, they were back just like they were at Mount Gundabad. The accusatory voices that sounded too much like a more intense version of her own ringing in her head.

"This is all your fault."

"The Queen falls endlessly between worlds because of you."

"You could have done something."

"You should have saved her."

"Why didn't you save her?"

"You bring suffering to all around you."

Aragorn had been taking a headcount of the remaining Fellowship. Boromir was trying to comfort the sobbing Sam, Merry, and Pippin. Gimli stood silent in the combined sorrow of the loss of his kinsmen, Moria, and now Gandalf. Legolas stood in silence as well, more perplexed than anything that the Grey Rider had fallen. Frodo stared into the distance, quietly crying. And Catra…

Aragorn had been ready to ask her assistance in getting the rest back to their feet, but all thoughts of that plan were dashed as he immediately recognized what had befallen the youngest member

of the Fellowship. Catra was on her knees, tail ramrod straight and ears pinned back on her head so far they may as well have been flat. Her visible pupil a mere sliver against teal blue as tears streamed from her eye. Heaving breaths escaped her lungs, one right after the other. She didn't even notice him as he approached her. Aragorn had seen this more than a few times before, with the most prominent being a young rider of Rohan he had met while riding under King Thengel. The stress of battle was something he would never wish on anyone, nor was any other thing that could cause this state. The condition was still not well understood by any of the peoples of Middle Earth, but Aragorn's passing curiosity had led him to discovering a method that tended to bring those who suffered these panics through them.

Catra didn't process the sensation of physical touch at first, but it was there nonetheless. A gentle but firm arm around her shoulders, gripping her close to another body. Distantly, she began to hear a voice softly talking to her.

"…tra… okay, you… be alright." Her breathing had been calming down since the arm gripped her, and now it was beginning to even out. The sounds of her surroundings were getting more clear.

"Ado- Aragorn?" Catra asked meekly.

"Yes Catra, I am here." The Ranger calmly responded.

"It's my fault. It's my fault she's gone. That Gandalf's…"

"What happened to Gandalf has nothing to do with you. Catra, I know that it is hard, but I cannot help unless you tell me. What happened before I found you in that river?" Tears still falling, Catra looked up to the Ranger's face and saw nothing but compassion and concern as opposed to the pity and judgment she expected. She then looked to the rest of the Fellowship, still in the process of recovering.

“You’re right.” She said finally. “But not just you. Everyone deserves to know. Once we get moving.”

Aragorn had led them well down into the lower foothills and to a safe camp when Catra called for everyone for a meeting over breakfast two days later.

“I haven’t been completely honest with all of you about my past.” Catra started nervously, then let out a deep breath. “But it has come to a point that I don’t think I can move on until I have nothing left to hide.”

“Ever since I came here, I have been running from the person I was back home. A person who had spent her entire life being manipulated and abused by the one who should have been by all rights taking care of me. Her name is Shadow Weaver. A dark sorceress obsessed with power and perfection over anything else. For whatever reason, she saw the most potential out of any of the children growing up in the Horde in my best friend, Adora. I suppose in a sense she was right in retrospect. Regardless, this caused her to heap the most unrealistic expectations you could imagine on the both of us. Trying to turn Adora into her prized pet project and disparaging me at every turn under the pretense that I was holding the one person I truly cared about back. Failure was met with harsh punishment dealt to me with the stolen power of an ancient artifact we called the Black Garnet. Years upon years of this made me… Bitter, defensive, and combative. I know now all she told me were lies, but at the time, the damage had been done.”

“Until a day about six and a half years ago. Adora found a magic sword of all things in the nearby Whispering Woods. We’d been told never to go there because of how dangerous it was, but since when did teenagers ever do exactly as they’re told? Hell, as if the Fright Zone was any safer with all the toxic sludge and exposed

machinery. A lot of freaky stuff happened that day, and Adora ended up learning that everything we had been brought up on was a lie. The Horde wasn't keeping the peace and crushing radical terrorists. The Rebellion was fighting back an oppressive regime. So she went turncoat and begged me to come with. But I was so blinded by my own insecurities and a fear of abandonment that I managed to convince myself she was betraying me. The demeanor of one of her new friends certainly wasn't helping."

"And so it went on since then. Adora had tapped into the power of a legendary warrior called 'She-Ra', and Catra of the Evil Horde would go on to combat the Rebellion, being thwarted at nearly every turn by the friend that in reality she had betrayed. Two and a half's years of this only made me all the more angry and hurt. And eventually it was all too much, I snapped. The leader of the Horde had been working on a device to bring our world out of the pocket in reality it had been trapped in, in hopes of what, it did not matter to me. All I heard was that this portal wasn't ready to turn on yet and was more likely to rip reality apart. I didn't care, I just wanted everything to end. So I threw the switch."

"I still don't know just how long we are under the effects of that thing. Honestly I don't care. Getting slowly ripped apart until I was nothing but the individual smallest things that make something up was more painful than I could have imagined. But even then, there was Adora, always having to be the Hero. In my desperation, I fought hard to stop her. And I nearly succeeded if it weren't for the leader of the Rebellion, Queen Angela of Brightmoon. Just as everything was going to be torn apart forever, I saw her fly up to throw the emergency switch that was the only chance of shutting the portal down and putting everything back. The effort would be at the cost of whoever did it though. She'd be trapped between worlds forever. In my distraction, I fell off a ledge, and the last thing I saw was the Queen's own daughter, and the most annoying person I've ever dealt with, pop into existence one last time as she saw her mother give up her life for everyone else. Sometimes… Sometimes I still hear that scream, when all else is quiet."

“That was enough to shock me into rethinking my entire life, and realize that it was too late for me to do anything about it. The Queen flipped the switch, and the portal closed around me. That was the last I saw of anyone I had known as I fell through… Everything. It felt like forever as I was pulled through all of time and space, witnessing some of what I can only assume is fragments of everything that could ever possibly be and happen anywhere. A world of living machines trapped in an endless war, a young girl using an ancient long forgotten magic to defeat a horrific monster made of decay, a man clad in clothes of blue or green fated to drive back a dark force for eternity, a group of four hunting beings made of shadows, and an army of really strangely dressed people fighting to stop an armored madman from merging and controlling all of time and space.”

“That part of my fall at least made sense, between that was a whole lot of bright lights and nothing. Just when I thought I’d be falling like this forever, I hit water and Aragorn pulled me out of the river. So what was left for some poor messed up kid to do but pick a direction and start walking? Eventually I found my way to a cave near Gundabad and took shelter from a storm there. I wasn’t alone though. Some… thing was trapped down there, frozen in a crystal. In what I’m guessing was a last ditch effort to get out, it tried to attack my mind. Showed me every mistake I’d ever made in their proper context, telling me I was the monster responsible for destroying my world. Somehow I managed to fight it off. Stabbed it right in the thing it was using for a head with the pointy end of the old mask that I used to keep my mane in place.”

“That was more than enough to shock me into trying to make up for my past though.” Catra finished as the Fellowship approached a forest of trees bearing golden-brown leaves. “Or at the very least run away from the memories as much as I could.” She stopped near the gently running waters of the nearby river.

“I’ve tried to find a way back home ever since, but found nothing. For all I know, my world ended up getting destroyed anyway, and I’m all that’s left. So that’s my story. And that’s who I am.” The

rest of them stood there for a bit, looking at her, before Aragorn walked up to join her at the shore.

“Your fate is something that I would not wish on anyone.” He said. “Yourself included.” Catra gave him a look of shock. Even after all that, he was acting with intent to just understand?

“With your actions since I have met you, and since you have joined this quest you have done nothing but aim to make amends for your mistakes. Perhaps part of that is finding a way to finally let go of your guilt, and your past.” Catra looked down, and thought about what he told her. Her hand idly went into the pouch where she had been keeping her repurposed Horde belt buckle, taking it out and holding it into her palm. It was the last surviving item of her old life that hadn’t been destroyed or modified nearly beyond recognition into traveling gear.

“You have been given a second chance.” Legolas said, turning the group’s attention to him. “You are not that person you were when you came here. And you do not have to be anymore.”

“But.” Catra said shakily. “If I’m not Catra of the Horde. Then who am I?”

“You’re our friend.” Merry said.

“Yes.” Frodo responded. “And perhaps that is all you need to be now, as a start.” Catra gasped, looking at each of the Fellowship.

She’d only had one person in her life who she could truly call that before. And that person had broken that bond at the source, even if rightfully so. The eight in front of her looked at her without judgment. She had traveled alongside them for months now, and in that time they had talked, laughed, even sang on a couple of occasions, and in a couple cases gotten perhaps a bit too familiar with certain parts of their lives than one should when in the early stages of getting to know each other. She actually had a group of people in her life now that she could see as more than just a

means to an end. These men were her friends. Friends all sharing in the burden of the one they had just lost.

"You know what?" Catra said, half of a smile growing on the unmarred side of her face. "I think you're right." And with that, she turned to the river and wound her arm back, chucking the belt buckle with a mighty throw! The piece of metal hit the water, plunging into the river with all of the grace reserved for an emblem of the Horde. She had no further need of it. This world was her home, and it was time she got back to helping to save it.

Catra looked back to her friends, her smile now reaching across her full face, but changed to one of melancholy. The loss of Gandalf weighed on her heart in full, but this pain was shared by those she stood with.

The Fellowship continued down the path, and Catra looked forward.

'Now.' She thought. 'Let's find out who I really am.'

She was not aware how oddly prescient that was.

Lothlorien

They had been walking through this wood for some time now, and Catra still couldn't shake the strange feeling she had since they had entered.

She had not said anything about it, as she figured they were dealing enough already after Gandalf had fallen and she'd word vomited out her life story. But she couldn't shake the sensation. It was like something or someone was watching her. And whatever it was, it was giving off the sensation that the Fellowship was not safe, but not in any real danger either. That was the most unnerving part of it really.

From the looks of it, Gimli was quite on edge himself, he fell back a bit, doing his best to usher both her and the Hobbits closer to him.

“Careful young ones!” He whispered conspiratorially. “They say an enchantress owns these woods. An Elf-witch. Those that are caught by her are put under her spell, and never seen again."

“If there was Gimli, I think she’d have a lot more better things to do than turn a group of travelers into frogs or make them into bread. Uh, that is what the witches here do right?” She turned to Boromir, looking to him for clarification.

“Old stories to scare children are more of my brother’s expertise.”

“Well, I’m at a loss.”

“Here’s one Dwarf she will not ensnare so easily.” Gimli blustered. “I’ve the eyes of a hawk and ears of a fox!” Before he could even process it, a drawn arrow appeared right in front of his forehead. A series of similar sights appeared about the Fellowship as a small squadron of Elves surrounded them. Catra gave a frustrated sigh.

“You guys just have to be good at everything don’t you?” The leader of this group came forward, he was adorned in the equipment of a captain and had long slicked back blond hair.

“The Dwarf breathes so loud we could have shot him in the dark.”

“And I woulda made you regret it Nature Boy.” Catra shot back. Aragorn merely put his palm to his face and sighed. He was not looking forward to tonight.

Aragorn had been expecting Gimli’s presence as they approached the Lady of Light’s realm to be a potential problem. He was not ready for Catra’s newfound sense of protective nature for the rest of the Fellowship. For the entire time they were under the custody of Haldir and his men, the young feline had been giving her

apparent signature evil eye to any Elf she felt was getting too close to her or anyone else for her comfort. She'd actually been able to make a couple of the newer recruits quite wary of her in turn. He would've found it impressive if it weren't making it significantly harder to reach their next destination without any unfortunate incidents.

At long last though, the travelers came upon a hill overlooking a great city built into the forest itself. Haldir stopped the procession and looked upon it.

"Caras Galadhon! Realm of the Lord Celeborn, and of Galadriel, Lady of Light." Upon observing the realm, Catra couldn't help but let out an impressed whistle. The sight was almost enough in her opinion to make up for spending those last ten odd miles with a sack over her head. As they were led further in, they were brought up into the trees and to a great balcony that held some significance as a formal meeting deck, if the large stairs leading elsewhere were to go by. Catra for her part, was of the impression that these Elves spoke so highly of their Ladyship merely due to her apparent reputation. Anyone who had risen to such a level of renown that they featured as some sort of boogeyman or borderline cryptid clearly did so mostly through clever tricks and misdirection.

She was immediately proven wrong as the Lady and Lord descended the stair. Galadriel had clearly earned her title, as she seemed to be giving off ethereal light by merely being present, but it was the look in her eyes that spoke more volume. Though she was blessed with eternal youth, her eyes showed the wisdom of ages and had a spark in them that very well could pierce even the most accomplished liar's falsehoods. So distracted was Catra by the Elf's presence that she had not been paying attention to the words being exchanged.

"… Tell me where is Gandalf, for I much desire to speak with him." Celeborn asked.

“Gandalf the Grey did not pass into our lands.” Galadriel said, her voice sounding far away yet present at the same time. “He has fallen into Shadow.”

“Gandalf was taken by both Shadow and Flame. A Balrog of Morgoth.” Legolas stated. Catra tuned everything out again. She had been so caught up in her own personal issues that Gandalf’s passing had only just started to weigh on her. Yes, she had been completely powerless to do anything regarding the potential destruction of Etheria, but why couldn’t she have mustered up the will to run back out onto the bridge and pull the Grey Wizard up? She eventually decided that now was not the time for what ifs. If anything, she should be concerned with the quest. The first thing she would need would be a map. Scout out the rest of the potential ways to Mordor, consult with Aragorn on the best rou-

‘I know who you are, Catra of the Etherian Horde.’ The voice of Galadriel spoke into her mind, Catra’s gaze shot to the Elf’s who continued to speak aloud about something else entirely. ‘And I have been expecting you for a long time.’

The Mirror of Galadriel

There was no way in Hell that Catra had imagined those words. It had been enough to throw her off for a good while, and she was only now recovering as the Fellowship settled into the campground provided for them. Throughout the inky night of the forest and through the otherworldly lights provided by the lamps placed about, the echoing of Elvish voices sang. Catra couldn’t help but listen to it despite not understanding as she changed her bandage.

“What is it?” Merry asked after a bit.

“A lament for Gandalf.” Legolas said as he brought water to the camp. “As for the words, I have not the heart to tell you, as the

pain is too near.”

“I bet they don’t have a verse about his fireworks though.” Sam said as he unfurled his bedroll. After some thought, he stood straight up, assuming the posture of one about to recite verse:

“The finest rockets ever seen,

They burst in stars of blue and green,

Or after thunder golden showers

Came falling like a rain of flowers.”

“That’s beautiful Sam.” Catra said sincerely as she tied the bandage off.

“Thank you Miss Catra, but begging your pardon, it doesn’t do them justice by a long road.”

“Don’t sell yourself short, I might not be much of a poet, but from where I’m sitting, you're leagues ahead of anyone else I've met.”

“Wait, where’s Mr. Frodo?” Catra looked around, and indeed, there was no sign of the Ringbearer.

“Hang tight, I’ll go find him.” She stood and left the campsite, eying the lower branches of the nearest trees. A small smile came to her face, it had been too long since she’d had a good climb.

Catra weaved through the available branches of the treetops, soon picking up the scent that she recognized as Frodo’s. A few more minutes of searching and she saw a strange distortion in a clearing before her. Shaking it off as her need for sleep catching up on her, Catra pressed on.

The clearing was circular in nature, lit mostly by the moon above and featuring a cylindrical pillar in the center, topped with a dish

full of clear water. Catra gave out a huff at the apparent architectural habits of the Elves. Then she sighted Frodo, a grave look on his face as he hurried back to the campsite. Galadriel stood near the water dish, looking oddly shaken herself, looking at the still fluid. Catra briefly pondered the implications of the Elf's countenance before turning to leave.

"I do not fault you for sneaking about." Galadriel said. "But I do ask that we speak before you retire." Stars above, how did she do that?! Taking a deep sigh, Catra hopped from the branches and made her way down the staircase into the clearing.

"So that was you talking in my head earlier, right?" Catra asked. "For future reference I'd prefer that if you've got something to tell me, say it out loud."

"Your distrust is not something I blame you for either. Your past is marred by a most particular Shadow." Catra stiffened, though the manner in which the Lady of Light referred to Weaver did win her a couple points.

"The only real shame of me being stuck here is that I never got any final closure with that pathetic excuse for a mother." Catra spat, then softened. "So you've been expecting me for some time, huh?"

"Ever since you arrived." Galadriel answered. "The rift that pulled you here, while unstable, was not the first connection between our worlds."

"What?! How?"

"Something beyond even my knowledge I fear," Galadriel said. "The Mirror allows me to see the past and the present, and potential futures. Both in this realm and those close to it. In many of these futures, your arrival was all but made certain two decades ago when, under a moon much like this one, the Mirror showed me a vision of rampant destruction the likes of which I had not seen in ages. All dealt to a settlement populated by a

people exactly resembling you. You have never met another member of your species in your entire life, correct?"

"Yes." Catra answered with a dry swallow. "I'd never really thought about it much. Kinda figured I was some kind of mutant."

"That could not be further from the truth, if you could, look into the mirror." Catra approached the pool. At first there was nothing, just a bright blue eye staring back at her from a bandaged face. Then, the water rippled and an image formed. A Horde attack, upon a small city that appeared to be underground. Dozens of bipedal felines fled the chaos, but all eventually fell to the attack.

Eventually the Mirror focused on one of the last standing as she ducked into an alleyway, a small bundle in her arms. In a panic, she set the bundle into a nearby box and pulled an amulet from within her tunic, a small chain connecting it to her neck. Her lips moved, but there was no sound, and the air next to the woman sparked before opening into an oval shaped gateway through which Catra could see the very familiar image of the very clearing she was now standing in. The woman tossed the pack she had been carrying on her back through, and bent over to retrieve the bundle from the box when a shot from a rifle struck her! Instantly the gate closed and a Horde soldier came into view, he glanced at the box and without looking into it, shut the flaps and carried it off. The image flickered again and changed to that same box now sitting in a new location as a young girl with blonde hair came into view and opened it. Catra tore her eye away. She knew what came next.

"You had better not be pulling my tail about this." Catra said, glaring at Galadriel.

"I can assure you that is not the case." She answered, striding to a small chest sitting by the closest tree. She opened it and produced the same war torn pack from within. From just the leather work alone, Catra could tell it had come from Etheria. Galadriel reached into the pack and pulled out a small leather bound book bearing a peculiar symbol on the front cover. "I do

not ask that you believe me, what I do ask is that you at least inspect the first page." Catra shakily took the book in hand and opened it. The page was filled with small but clearly legible symbols. It looked like no writing Catra had ever seen before. She was about to speak up, when suddenly, an odd tingling sensation crossed the back of her skull. Looking at the symbols again, Catra gasped.

"You understand the writing, do you not?" Galadriel asked.

"Yes." Catra said in disbelief. "But how?"

"Every world has its secrets. Without exception, many of them consider the words that are written and spoken by those who live on them. This particular secret appears to be known to your people alone."

"And that woman?"

"I would say the resemblance is clear enough that she was of some kin to you. That is all I was able to discern. The Mirror saw fit to only show me what may come of you after that. So I only had to wait for you to come here."

"Took me long enough." Catra said with a mirthless chuckle.

"Time does not have the same meaning to my people as it does to yours. Patience is as much a skill as it is a virtue. I suggest that you get some rest Catra. You have a long road ahead of you." Having bade her farewell for the night, the Elf left the clearing. Catra walked along the path to the campsite.

Sitting down on her bedroll, she opened the book once more, this time being instantly able to decode the meaning of the text as if she'd studied it all her life. Putting aside how flat out strange she found it, Catra read:

'As is the custom of our people I have decided that this journal, and the knowledge I have gathered within, will serve as the birthright of my daughter as much as it is the history of our tribe. We Magicats are not native to this world, hence we few have lived in the safety of our underground settlement of Halfmoon for generations. But this is not where we come from. Our tribe has been fortunate enough to obtain some of the most ancient texts and artifacts of our people, dating back to the very beginning. I have made it my life's mission to document and understand them, in hopes that we may understand ourselves. But this is second only to what I truly leave behind. My darling daughter. C'yra, whether I am still with you or not, know this. You are at once both my greatest accomplishment and treasure. And wherever your life takes you and what you decide to make of it, read the words of our history within these pages and know that I will always love you.'

Quickly, Catra closed the journal with a shaky hand, not wanting the tears that had begun to fall from her eye to damage the most important words she had ever read.

The Fellowship of the Ring Part IV

The Breaking of the Fellowship

Before the Fellowship was to set out from the wood, the Elves of Lothlorien gifted upon the Fellowship hooded cloaks tailored to each of them.

“Never before have we clad strangers in the garb of our people.” They were told. “May they shield you from unfriendly eyes.” Catra looked down at the leaf shaped clasp holding the garment to her neck. She looked back up and found that while the words felt strange upon her tongue and lips, it was not hard to thank the Elves of Lorien for their generosity.

They were led then to a set of canoe shaped boats provided for their journey south and east. There the Lady Galadriel would bid them their farewell, and bestow onto them final gifts in memory of the Golden Wood.

To Aragorn, came the Elfstone of the House of Elendil. An heirloom and further proof of his lineage as the heir to the throne of Gondor.

To Boromir was given a fine belt of gold.

To Merry and Pippin were given fine silver belts holding knives that could easily serve as Hobbit-daggers.

To Legolas, a bow of the Galadhrim.

To Samwise Gamgee, a cord of fine Elven rope and a little box of soil from Galadriel’s own garden.

To Frodo, a small crystal phial, bearing the caught light of the star of Eärendil, glowing within the waters of the Lady’s fountain.

“And for you, Catra of Etheria.” Galadriel said to her. “The second and last item that traveled within your kindred’s pack, now carried in a sheath of our people’s own make so that it may never be stained or broken, even in defeat.” In her hands was presented a blade in the form of a long dagger, its crossbar curving downward toward the pommel, above the cross guard was a circular ruby set on either side of the blade where the weapon slotted into its new sheath, within both faces of the ruby was a jet black slit that resembled a cat’s pupil.

“Thank you milady.” Catra said almost automatically. She accepted the dagger and strapped it to her left thigh, her whip still hung from her right hip. After that, the Fellowship was formally set off down the Great River Anduin. Aragorn was in the lead boat with Frodo and Sam, Boromir in the middle with Merry and Pippin, and Legolas, Gimli, and Catra brought up the rear, crammed into the boat with the majority of their supplies.

“So what did she give you?” Legolas asked of the Dwarf, who was looking quite uncharacteristically awestruck and bashful by Catra’s account.

“I asked for one hair from her golden head…” Gimli said. “She gave me three.” Legolas smiled at this, as if he had become privy to quite the amusing piece of information indeed. Catra saw this from her seat at the front of the boat, sitting so as to keep an eye behind them. She filed the look on the Elf’s face for later, and planned to ask him about it at a more appropriate time. For the first time since the Fellowship arrived in Galadriel’s realm, Catra felt like it would be easy going for a good while.

That good while did not account for the utter boredom one can feel when traveling down a River of course. While her instinctive reservations regarding water had been somewhat managed by a handful of incidents where plunging into it turned out to be the best course of action, Catra was still not a fan of being

surrounded by it as she was now. And somehow she, Legolas, and Gimli had run out of things to talk about.

“Ugh.” Catra groaned. “Too bad this whole river thing is making it hard to stay close enough to the others long enough to interact. I think I could use some of the Hobbits’ traveling songs right about now.”

“You have heard the songs of Arda’s peoples Catra. In fact, the act of song is how our world began.” Legolas said. “But we have not heard any from yours. Did the people where you come from not create any songs?”

“Not that I know of. The Horde wasn’t too big on letting those it crushed keep a hold on their culture.” Legolas nodded grimly.

“A shame.” Was all he said.

“There was one though.” Catra said after a pause. “The Force Captains would sing it all the time at dinner when I was growing up. Mostly after they’d had a lot to drink. The whole thing’s practically burned into my mind.” Her mouth curled into a smile, complex memories evidently came with their own form of nostalgia.

“May we hear it then?” Gimli asked.

“Yes.” Legolas said. “I am personally quite curious what any of your world’s people created at this point.”

“Okay Blondie,” Catra said with a chuckle, knowing full well how this was likely to effect both of her companions. “I’m not much of a singer myself. Just remember you asked for it.” And so clearing her throat, Catra burst into song.

It was called many things over the decades that the Horde laid siege to Etheria, but its most popular title was “The Force Captain’s Promotion”. The words of its lyrics ebbed and flowed

over time as well, but the content of said lyrics remained ironclad. By the time it had become known to Catra and her peers, it had settled in at an allotted time of four and a half minutes to sing, all instances of the chorus included. Provided of course it was sang at its most popular cadence, a tune that by sheer chance, was the exact tune of a different song known by many across the many planes of reality as “The Night Pat Murphy Died”.

With the way Catra set about singing it, that is at the maximum volume possible, her previous observations regarding inconsistent proximity to one’s traveling partners whilst on the river was rendered completely moot as everyone heard the whole thing clearly.

As for what the lyrics said, I haven’t the heart to tell you dear reader. As the song was, if you have not yet been able to tell, perhaps the most lowbrow, juvenile, and foul-mouthed bawdy song in all known existence. Detailing all manner of unspeakable hedonistic acts that would likely cause any parchment they were put upon to suddenly burst into flame and even the most experienced night worker to blush. And each syllable now echoed down the river. At this point, Catra’s level of skill in the art of singing (or lack thereof) was rendered completely null. Never before had the shores of the Anduin heard such jaunty filth.

By the time she had finished, Gimli was beside himself in an uproar of the deepest laughter. Legolas gazed unseeing down the river, deep into the process of cataloging and questioning every last decision he had made in his long, long, life.

Aragorn also gazed forward, but his was one of pure focus as he did his best to pilot his vessel while simultaneously electing to have ignored the last four minutes. Even still, if one looked closely, there was a ghost of amusement upon his face.

“I didn’t know she had it in her.” Pippin said in awe.

“Goodness.” Said a flustered Sam. “I would’ve never thought to use a boot like that.”

“How did they get the bear into the dining hall?” Asked a perplexed Merry.

“I’ll never be able to eat cheese again.” Boromir shuddered. Frodo, astoundingly, had managed to sleep though the whole thing.

The monotony was not broken again until a couple more days down the river. Aragorn was starting to look at the shores wearily, and Legolas and Catra weren’t far behind in following his suspicions. Yet, there was still no evidence to be found outside of the stray cries of bird and beast. Another day and the Fellowship came upon one of Middle-Earth’s most grand sights. Two towering statues of ancient Gondorian kings, facing the north of the river, their arms outstretched, behind them, the Falls of Rauros awaited. The Argonath.

“Now there’s a sight and a half.” Catra said to herself. “Right up there with Moria once you look past the Goblins and giant fire demon.”

They set up camp on the western shore of the falls for that night. As for what was next, that was still up in the air. Gimli was currently in the process of describing what awaited the Fellowship should they proceed eastward.

“All that lies in wait for us there is Emyn Muil, a vast twisting maze of crags and sharp rock. And after that, it gets even better! A great stinking marshland, as far as the eye can see!”

“Gee, that sounds just lovely Gimli. Maybe we can build a summer home there?” Catra said from atop the boulder she was lying on, turning her attention from the journal. She had been reading it ever since they had set out on the river, and the following periods of time after she’d finished for the day had left her increasingly contemplative. Thankfully, the rest of the Fellowship was kind

enough to humor her in sharing the findings of her biological mother. “What’s in store for us if we turned west?”

“Depending on our route? A few river crossings and the southernmost part of Rohan, where we would then proceed to Gondor and the White City.” Aragorn said. “It is our most safe option, but I am concerned how we may be received by Lord Denethor.”

“He’s Boromir’s father, isn’t he? I’m sure he could talk him into being more personable.”

“If you had proposed it before Lothlorien, I would have agreed with you. But Boromir has been acting more and more uneasy as of late.” Catra stood and returned the journal to its pouch on her belt.

“Then I’ll have a talk with him if he doesn’t want to speak to you. Where is he anyway?” They looked around. The only trace of the Gondorian was his discarded shield leaning against one of the stone seats surrounding the campfire.

“Oh great.” Catra groaned. “Now he’s started wandering off too. It’s bad enough that Frodo’s been doing it.” Aragorn sighed.

“I will look for Frodo.” He said, walking towards the woods.

“Right. Anyone else up for helping me find Boromir?” Catra was answered by a nod from Legolas and a commitive grunt from Gimli. Before the trio left, Catra turned to the remaining Hobbits.

“In case you see anything good or bad, yell as loud as you can. Hopefully we won’t be too far out.”

It can be quite astounding how much ground a single person can cover in under a short period of time. The forested terrain of Amon Hen was quite hilly as well, which served to throw the search party off even more. Catra was really beginning to wish

someone in Middle-Earth would hurry up and invent the compass already. They had been searching for about an hour when the clear sounds of clashing metal began to ring across the trees.

"And that's about where my mother figured that my species decided to use the place where we were born as surnames. Wait." Catra said. "I'm not the only one hearing that am I?"

"No lass," Gimli responded. "I hear it too." They strained their ears and the distinct sound of a man yelling in exertion joined the clanging.

"Aragorn." Legolas said, grabbing his bow from his back. In turn Gimli took out his axe and Catra unsheathed her dagger as they ran toward the din.

"Why am I getting a bad feeling about this?" Catra asked herself.

Up another hill they dashed coming to the sight of Aragorn taking on a small army single-handedly amidst a collection of crumbled ruins. His opponents couldn't be anything but Orcs, but they were nothing like any Orc Catra had seen before.

The typical Orc rabble was diverse in many ways, height, color, armor design, and level of wear and tear wrought by disease and scars. But this group was much different. Mostly uniform in height and much taller, skin color only ranging from a vibrant red-brown to the color of burnt jerky, and their armor practically identical. Heavy leathers and metals to compliment their impressive bulk.

"What manner of beasts are these?!" Legolas exclaimed as he fired an arrow into the back of one of these Orcs, managing to just save Aragorn from one of their cleaver style blades! "They walk unhindered and unafraid in broad sunlight!" Gimli ducked under a mighty swing, and returned it in kind.

"Their disposition appears to be nastier than normal as well!" The Dwarf said. Catra had not yet had a chance to strike, as she was

busy evading the attacks of two. Backed near a tree, she found her opportunity. Leaping to the branches and immediately springing off them, she sailed over the heads of her attackers and landed behind them! Rushing forward, she slit one's throat with a reverse grip, following it up by driving the blade into the back of the other standing to the right and running her extended claws across its face, cutting through the plate of the helmet!

"They're barely armored in the back!" Catra said. "What kind of army does that?!" Her left ear flicked, and she tucked and rolled out of the way of another attack. She stood straight and rushed her opponent, driving her dagger up and through the underside of its jaw! She waded through the thinning crowd, dodging a trio of arrows let loose by Legolas, one of which managed to skewer two Orcs at once! Gimli swung his double headed axe into the gut of another with a mighty chop, and Catra thrust her dagger into the back of its neck as it clutched at its innards! She and Gimli exchanged nods before he moved on to his next opponent, and Catra heard a challenging roar behind her. Turning to that Orc, Catra observed that his blade was much longer than the rest, and that this particular Orc had an almost uncharacteristic air of confidence. He strode toward her, reaching up with his free hand to pull off his helmet.

"Yeah, I've went one-on-one with much uglier than you." The Orc roared again in response, and Catra gave out a challenging hiss of her own as the two charged each other! What followed was a series of hearty swings and near misses as the Orc pressed the attack. There were still enough left to keep Aragorn, Legolas, and Gimli occupied, so Catra's options were limited to what she could do on her own. Which wasn't really all that much, given her much shorter reach. Sure, she could try to close the gap and get a stab or two in, but judging by the way her opponent reacted to her own swings to bait him, that probably wouldn't end well. Catra was beginning to get pretty frustrated by now, and so she expressed that frustration by putting as much power as she could into swinging at the full extent of the Orc's offhand as it threw a punch, only to be met with a sudden change in the balance of her blade and the sensation of it catching and cleaving straight

though the Orc's forearm! The Orc staggered back with a roar of pain and fury, and Catra looked dumbfounded at the weapon in her hand.

"What the?!" She exclaimed as she discovered that the curves of the cross guard had inexplicably changed directions so that they were facing toward the blade. And speaking of the blade, it had extended to two feet and eight inches in length! "Well, that's new." Quickly recovering from the shock, Catra managed to clumsily parry the Orc's ferocious counter attack, batting his blade out of the way before stepping forward and letting loose a desperate swing in the opposite direction, chopping the Orc's head clean off!

As the body fell, Catra looked across the rest of the hill to see that the other three had dealt with the rest of the squad.

"That was too close." Catra said, holding her "new" sword up. Aragorn, Legolas, and Gimli looked to the blade as well in a mix of fascination and astoundment. Catra regarded their looks before gesturing to the weapon with her left hand.

"Just what I needed huh?" She said incredulously, but with a bemused smile. "Another bullshit magic sword!" Before any of them could say a word, another sound rang through the woods, this one coming in deep, loud, short bursts.

"A horn of Gondor!" Legolas observed.

"Boromir!" Aragorn said, breaking out into a run towards the signal. The others followed close behind. As they ran down the slope, Catra could just make out a few more scattered Orcs running in the same direction as they were. Glancing quickly at the sword in her hand, her thoughts were briefly sent back to Balin's Tomb, and the much shorter sword she had briefly stolen and managed to improvise with. She had gotten extremely lucky then, and was not willing to take chances now.

“Aragorn, I’m pretty new to these things, you got any quick advice?”

“Parry with the wide edge of the blade, treat blocking more as redirecting your opponent’s weapon than stopping it, go for the weak areas of their armor, and don’t put unnecessary energy into your swings!”

“And do not worry, Catra.” Legolas added. “Gimli and I shall cover you!”

“Okay then!” Catra said. “Let’s do this!”

And so the four ran, desperately trying to catch up to their distressed comrade. Occasionally, they would cut off or be cut off course themselves by the attacking Orcs, or Uruks apparently, as Aragorn and Legolas had begun to refer to them over the course of the battles. Catra could not care any less as to what they were called. All that mattered was that they find Boromir. The sounding of the horn had stopped after some time. And the Uruks seemed increasingly less interested in fighting them.

Catra found the answers as to the strange behavior and the lack of signals as she turned one final bend to see the sight of the most imposing Uruk yet standing tall before a kneeling and weakened Boromir as it pulled back upon its powerful longbow. Boromir himself had already been struck many times, and this was to be the coup de grace.

“BOROMIR!” She cried out, rushing to his side and dropping her sword just as Aragorn managed to tackle the Uruk leader, engaging with the creature in single combat!

“Catra.” Boromir managed to wheeze.

“Don’t worry.” Catra said hastily, the sounds of the duel ringing behind them. “You’re going to be all right.”

“It’s a little late for that Catra.” Boromir said, bringing a firm hand to her shoulder. “I misjudged you when we first met. You are no beast, and you are not your past. Stay your path. You will become who you are meant to be yet, who you want to be.” Catra’s eye began to water.

Mere yards away, Aragorn fought tooth and nail against the Uruk, managing to catch his own knife midair with a swing from his sword as his opponent threw it back at him. The distance between the fighters closed, and Aragorn managed to cleave the creature’s left arm off at the bicep, following up by stabbing it through the chest! In response, the Uruk grasped the blade that had been thrust into its body and pulled itself forward, driving the blade even further into itself as it growled at the man responsible. Aragorn’s determined look briefly faltered, and he quickly pulled his blade back and swung, beheading the creature!

His opponent defeated, Aragorn turned his attention to Boromir, running to the dying man.

“He hasn’t got long left.” Catra said solemnly as the Ranger knelt next to the fallen Gondorian.

“Aragorn. They took the little ones, Merry and Pippin.” Boromir choked out. “Frodo, I tried to take the Ring from him. I…”

“It does not matter.” Aragorn said, bringing Boromir’s fallen sword back to its master’s hand. Boromir clutched it in turn. “You fought bravely, and have redeemed yourself.”

“I would have followed you to the end. My brother, my captain, my King.”

“I swear to you, I will not let the White City fall. Or our people fail.” Boromir managed to smile, and then passed from the world. Legolas and Gimli appeared from the trees and stopped at the sight of their fallen comrade, kept company in his final moments by the now silently grieving Ranger and Magicat. Catra listlessly picked up her sword glancing briefly between it and the Elven

dagger sheath. A sharp clicking sound resounded their surroundings as the weapon's blade retracted and it returned to its previous appearance as a long dagger, the gathered Uruk blood sloughing off with the force of the movement. Catra sheathed the weapon as she looked at Boromir's body, tears streaming down her cheek.

It took the four a little under an hour to remove the arrows from Boromir's body and prepare a funeral vessel for him from one of the two remaining boats at the shore. Once it was ready, Catra gently pushed it into the river, where Boromir was borne down the Falls of Rauros and to where ever afterward the Anduin led, past the city of Osgiliath and out into the Great Sea beyond. For a while, the four companions did not speak, gazing after their lost friend as the falls took him. Then Aragorn spoke.

"They will look for him from the White Tower. But he will not return from mountain or from sea." Then slowly he began to sing:

"Through Rohan over fen and field where long grass grows

The West Wind comes walking, and about walls it goes.

'What news from the West, O wandering wind, do you bring to me tonight?

Have you seen Boromir the Tall by moon or by starlight?'

'I saw him ride over seven streams, over waters wide and grey;

I saw him walk in empty lands, until he passed away

Into the shadows of the North. I saw him no more.

The North Wind may have heard the horn of the son of Denathor.'

'O Boromir! From the high walls westward I looked afar,

But you came not from the empty lands where no men are.’”

Then Legolas sang:

“From the mouths of the Sea the South Wind flies, from the sandhills and the stones;

The wailing of the gulls it bears, and at the gate it moans.

‘What news from the South, O sighing wind, do you bring to me at eve?

Where now is Boromir the Fair? He tarries and I grieve.’

‘Ask me not where he doth dwell- so many bones there lie

On the white shores and the dark shores under the stormy sky;

So many have passed down Anduin to find the flowing Sea.

Ask of the North Wind news of them the North Wind says to me!’

‘O Boromir! Beyond the gate the seaward road runs south,

But you came not with the wailing gulls from the grey sea’s mouth.’”

Then Aragorn sang again:

“From the Gate of Kings the North Wind rides, and past the roaring falls;

And clear and cold about the tower its loud horn calls.

‘What news from the North, O mighty wind, do you bring to me today?

What news of Boromir the Bold? For he is long away.’

‘Beneath Amon Hen I heard his cry. There many foes he fought.

His cloven horn, his broken sword, to the water brought.

His head so proud, his face so fair, his limbs they laid to rest;

And Rauros, golden Rauros-falls, bore him upon its breast.'

'O Boromir! The Tower of Guard shall ever northward gaze

To Rauros, golden Rauros falls, until the end of days.'"

Catra never considered herself the spiritual sort, but she recalled an ancient prayer of her people from her readings in her mother's notes, and decided that it wouldn't hurt.

'May he be welcomed into the halls of his ancestors, and may they rejoice at his arrival.' She thought in mourning.

"You left the East Wind to me." Said Gimli. "But I will say naught of it."

"That is as it should be." Said Aragorn. "In Minas Tirith, they endure the East Wind, but they do not ask it for tidings." Legolas made for the remaining boat, as he saw movement across the river. Aragorn and Catra hung back.

"It's Frodo and Sam, isn't it?" She asked. "They're making for Mordor on their own." He nodded.

"And you're not going after them?"

"It is still up to you to decide your path forward from here." Aragorn said. "Which is it you will choose?" Catra let out a breath and looked at the shrinking figures across the river.

"I've been doing a lot of searching inward since I got that book. Catra of the Horde recognizes that Sam's got a good enough head on him to get Frodo through, but would consider it tactically advantageous to go with anyway and see the quest through

herself.” She paused, reaching behind her head to untie her bandage, pulling it away to reveal her now healed face, golden eye shining but now taking up the space between two halves of the long, thick, and permanent scar leading from her cheek to her forehead. “But C’yra Halfmoon knows that she’s got two friends in great danger that are in need of help. Count me in.” At this Aragorn gave her a proud smile, and the two walked to join Legolas and Gimli on the shore.

“Frodo and Sam have reached the eastern shore!” Legolas exclaimed, getting the boat ready before pausing at the sight of Aragorn adjusting his gear. “You do not mean to follow them.”

“Then it has all been in vain.” Gimli said. “The Fellowship has failed.”

“Not while remain true to each other.” Aragorn said, placing a hand on each of their shoulders. “We will not abandon Merry and Pippin to torment and death. The Company has played its part, we cannot forsake our companions while we have strength left. Leave all that can be spared behind. We travel light.” Aragorn replaced his dagger.

“Let’s hunt some Orc.”

The Elf and Dwarf exchanged looks, sharing in a newfound conviction. The Magicat’s growing grin turned into a full fanged smile.

“Yes!” Gimli exclaimed with a raucous laugh. And from there on, the Four Hunters, Aragorn son of Arathorn, Legolas Greenleaf, Gimli son of Gloin, and C’yra Halfmoon set off upon their path to save their friends.

The Two Towers Part I

There are many tales that can be told where what is usually a Fellowship of Nine becomes Ten. This is but how one of them continues.

THE TWO TOWERS

The Riders of Rohan

Upon the eastern plains of the borders of a land called Rohan in the world known as Arda or Middle-Earth, a lone Ranger pressed his ear to the ground listening for a deep rumble traveling across the grass and rock ridden terrain.

"Their pace has quickened. Something must have alerted them to us." He said to himself as one of his three companions, an Elf ran up to him. They exchanged a nod before breaking back into a run.

"Come Gimli, C'yra!" Legolas of Mirkwood shouted backward. "We are gaining on them!" Huffing up the hill came a Dwarf of the Lonely Mountain, Gimli, son of Gloin. Next to him was a winded but still determined Magicat, a traveler from another world who called herself C'yra Halfmoon.

"Three days and nights pursuit." Gasped Gimli. "No food, no rest. And no sign of our quarry but what bare rock can tell!" The pair caught their breaths and ran forward as well.

"Look on the bright side, Gimli!" C'yra said as she slowly overtook him. "It's a beautiful day, the countryside is equally so. We've apparently gotten close enough to spook the Uruks and we're getting plenty of exercise while we're at it!"

“They run as if the very whips of their masters were upon them!” Legolas exclaimed.

“Argh! I’m wasted on cross country!” Gimli huffed. “We Dwarves are natural sprinters! Very dangerous over short distances!”

“I think what is actually going on is that you’re paying the price for lugging that giant axe on your back all day!” She said teasingly. “You’ve already got like five others, didn’t Aragorn say we needed to travel light?”

“That’s easy to say for the woman whose dagger extends into a sword!” The Dwarf fired back. “Hang on, why have they stopped?” Aragorn had crouched to the ground again, then stood, holding aloft a familiar leaf shaped brooch. At the sight of it, C’yra brought her left hand to the similar one keeping her cloak fastened to her shoulders.

“Not idly do the leaves of Lorien fall.” Aragorn said. “They may yet be still alive!”

Eventually the duo caught up to Aragorn and Legolas atop a hill overlooking the vast plains of yellow grass and scattered rock before them.

“Rohan.” Aragorn said. “Home of the Horse Lords. There is something dark going on in these lands, some Evil that gives speed to these creatures.”

“If they’re anything like the other Orcs, then it sure as shit isn’t their diet!” C’yra said. Aragorn gave her a stern look. “I’m right aren’t I? You’ve seen what they eat.” Aragorn simply began to run down the hill. C’yra looked off to her left and let out a huff of air, blowing at her bangs.

“Yeah. He’s right.” She said to herself as she followed her three companions. “There’ll be a time for mouthing off when we get

Merry and Pippin back. You really picked out a great coping mechanism there C'yra!"

They ran for a day and a half more without much in the way of updates to their progress. It was then that they came to another large hill, Legolas ran to its topmost peak to survey the lands.

"Legolas!" Aragorn shouted as he caught up. "What do your Elf eyes see?!"

"The Uruks turn northeast!" Legolas said. "They're taking the Hobbits to Isengard!"

"Isengard?" C'yra asked. "Why does that sound familiar?"

"Saruman." Aragorn said, almost as if the very name of the White Wizard was a curse.

"Oh right." C'yra said with equal disdain and a slight shiver as she turned her own eyes to the feet of the Misty Mountains in the distance. "How could I forget?"

C'yra had not really dwelt on it at the time, aside from a few of the more particularly quiet sets of hours they had spent traveling through Moria, but Saruman's attempt at burying them atop Caradhras was quite possibly the worst first impression that anyone had ever made on her in her life. And she hadn't even officially met the Wizard yet! That and her admittedly somewhat ironic disdain for betrayal had painted a vivid picture of the kind of person he was in her mind. A picture further embellished by her first encounter with the faction of Uruk-hai that the Four Hunters were now chasing. The only thing that she was missing regarding her idea of Saruman was his motive in all of this. The safe guess was a desire for power, followed closely by his sense of self preservation in the face of the Dark Lord Sauron's play at turning Middle Earth into his perpetual stomping ground.

Months ago C'yra would have laughed off the Dark Lord as just another wannabe conqueror like those she had grown up around in the Horde, like she herself had once been. But that had all changed as soon as she had seen the Ring. This upcoming war, as that was where all of this was surely leading, was for real.

'I sure hope that Frodo and Sam are having a better success rate than we are.' C'yra thought as she ran onward.

The sweeping plains of Rohan proved to be deceptively expansive. How much further could either the hunters or hunted run? The wee hours of the morning gave way to a brilliant crimson sunrise.

"A red sun rises." Legolas said as the celestial body began its day's journey. "Blood has been split this night."

"Let's hope it wasn't anyone innocent." C'yra remarked gravely. The Four Hunters ran for another couple hours before a distinct rumble was felt beneath their feet. Being the first to see the coming host, Aragorn signaled for the four to hide behind a rocky outcropping. A few moments later, a large group of horse mounted riders thundered past, their spears bobbing in the air. Aragorn emerged from their hiding spot, followed by his companions. Raising his voice, he called across the plain.

"Riders of Rohan! What news from the Mark?!"

The leader of the riders signaled, and the party circled around towards the four, eventually forming a circle around them, spears pointed inwards. C'yra found herself instinctively reaching for the magic dagger/sword that hung at her left thigh. Aragorn turned to her, holding out a hand to indicate that she should stay her hand. C'yra withdrew her hand, and eyed the leader of the riders suspiciously.

"What business do a man, a woman, an Elf, and a Dwarf have in the Riddermark?" The man asked as he dismounted, regarding the four like they were the ones liable to attack at any moment. With

his height and heavy armor, C'yra found herself reminded of Scorpia's imposing frame. But from his demeanor, it looked like bear hugs were not in any of the Hunters' near future.

"Tell me your name horsemaster." Gimli said. "And I shall give you mine."

"I would cut off your head, Dwarf. If it stood but a little higher from the ground." Quick as lightning, Legolas readied his bow and drew back an arrow!

"You would die before your stroke fell!" The Elf exclaimed as the thicket of spears grew ever closer to them.

"Yeah," C'yra said. "Then I'd take out whoever ends up spearing you, then they'd spear me, then Gimli, and Aragorn would spend his final moments wondering why he had to die in one of the most embarrassing ways possible."

"Peace you two." Aragorn said, reaching over to lightly push Legolas' bow out of the way. "I am Aragorn, son of Arathorn. This is Gimli, son of Gloin, Legolas Greenleaf of the Woodland Realm, and C'yra Halfmoon, the Wildcat of Arnor. We are friends of Rohan, and of Theoden, your King." This seemed to shake the head rider a bit.

"Theoden no longer recognizes friend from foe." He said, taking off his helmet. The riders withdrew their spears. "Not even his own kin. Saruman the White has poisoned the mind of the King and claimed lordship over these lands. My company are those loyal to Rohan, and for that we are banished."

That was when C'yra took notice of the quality of his armor. Much like the rest of his people, it was crafted from cloth, leather, and sparse metals. The difference with this man being that more metal was spared for his suit, and the equine heraldry of his people was more prominent throughout the pieces, particularly his helm. She still had no idea who exactly this man was, but it was clear that he had some relation to this King Theoden. Aragorn

seemed to have a look of recognition, and C'yra wasn't all that surprised. She'd been getting a sneaking suspicion of late that the Ranger to be King wasn't exactly normal.

Well, as normal as one can be when one travels the lands with an Elf, Dwarf, and Magicat as companions anyway. The rider considered the four a bit, then spoke again.

"An odd group you are though. Did you spring from the grass itself?"

"No." Aragorn said. "We passed here through Lothlorien, and the gifts and favor of the Lady go with us."

"Then there is a Lady in the Golden Wood as old tales tell. Few escape her nets they say. These are indeed strange days."

"And they're bound to get stranger if the stuff we've had to deal with the last few months is anything to go by." C'yra grumbled to herself, not noticing Gimli give the rider a look of great offense.

"Careful boy. I would warn you against foolish words! You speak Evil of that which is fair beyond the reach of your thought!"

"Gimli, I don't think now is the best time to start defending our allies' honor." C'yra said under her breath. The leader eyed the two suspiciously again, then turned back to Aragorn.

"The White Wizard is cunning." He said, circling the group. "He walks here and there they say, as an Old Man. Hooded and cloaked. And everywhere his spies slip past us."

"I can assure you, we're no friends of Saruman." C'yra spat. "The bastard tried to drop a mountain on us!" The lead rider whipped his gaze to her, almost shocked at her words.

"And if that wasn't enough, a band of his Uruk-hai kidnapped some of our companions a week ago! We've been tracking them ever since." One could practically see the gears in the man's mind turn.

“The Uruks are destroyed.” He said. “We slaughtered them during the night.”

‘Guess Legolas was right about that sun after all.’ C’yra thought. ‘Time to add accurate portent reading to the list of freaky Elf bullshit.’

“There were two Hobbits!” Gimli said. “Did you see two Hobbits with them?”

“They would be small.” Aragorn said. “Only children to your eyes.” The rider looked down and took a deep breath.

“We left none alive.” He said. “We piled the carcasses and burned them.” He pointed into the distance, where the smoke of a bonfire plumed. C’yra’s eyes widened.

“Dead?” Gimli asked shakily.

“I am sorry.”

“No.” C’yra said under her breath. Legolas put a hand on each of their shoulders. The lead rider turned away and whistled.

“Hasufel, Arod!” Two riderless horses were brought forth, of chestnut and speckled white coat respectively.

“May these horses bear you to better fortune than their former masters. Farewell.” He then mounted his own horse.

“Look for your friends. But do not trust to hope. It has foresaken these lands. We ride North!” C’yra’s face set as the riders went forth. She had been through and seen enough to know that there was still a chance, however small, that Merry and Pippin survived. After all, she was not trapped in the space between worlds right now.

She turned to face Hasufel with Aragorn, eyeing the horse with a small amount of nervousness. Horses she had found, tended to be a bit skittish around her when not under the ownership of Elves.

After a few moments of regarding the Ranger, Hasufel turned to C'yra and blew a gust of air right into her face.

"Ugh!" Despite all circumstances Aragorn chuckled as the horse proceeded to rest its head on C'yra's shoulder. He actually chuckled.

"She likes you C'yra."

"Oh does she now?" C'yra said as the chestnut allowed Aragorn to mount her, C'yra following. "We'll have to see if the feeling is mutual." Hasufel nickered. Meanwhile, Legolas was taking the saddle and rein off of the other horse before he and Gimli mounted him.

"Arod." Legolas said. "Your name is noble my friend."

"Not to question the literal gift horses," C'yra said as the Four Hunters galloped off. "But what was the deal with tall, blond, and grumpy back there?"

"That was Eomer, nephew of Theoden King." Aragorn said. "An ill tiding indeed, if he is banished, and without his cousin Theodred riding by his side. The two are like brothers."

"Then if the worst is the case, Saruman's swiftly reaching the top of my list of 'People to Claw on Sight'!"

"You have met enough who are despicable enough to create such a list, gwathel?"* Legolas asked.

"Okay, you've got me." C'yra said with a smirk. "There's only two on the list."

*(Sindarin Elvish, meaning a sister in all but blood, courtesy of the LotR fan wiki)

The White Rider

C'yra smelled the source of the smoke before she saw it, and by the ancestors did she wish then that her nose was not so powerful for once. Orcs, and by extension, Uruks she supposed, smelt rank enough without setting them alight. The Four Hunters dismounted and approached the aftermath of last night's ambush. C'yra walked to where an Uruk's head was piked upon a discarded spear, its tongue sticking out and drying in the winds of the plain. Surveying the rest of the macabre scene, she noticed the thick woods that lay somewhat north and eastward.

"These Rohirrim sure don't mess around." She said, searching for any sign of Merry and Pippin. "In any other circumstance I'd say I was beginning to like them."

"I would have thought with your demeanor towards the King's nephew, you would be more likely to come to blows." Legolas said.

"True. I guess there's something about tall, strong, blond people that sets me off in one way or another. Had he been the King's niece, things might've been different."

"Ah. So you would have been more amicable?" C'yra snorted in laughter.

"Oh Hell no. I'd probably get my face punched in then end up like Gimli every time someone mentions Galadriel."

"I heard that!" Came a gruff shout from the pile of burnt corpses, followed by a gasp of shock. Aragorn, Legolas, and C'yra looked over to watch as Gimli produced the brunt remains of a length of sliver colored leather from the pile. All of their faces fell.

"It's one of their wee belts." Legolas hung his head and began to recite a prayer in Sindarin as C'yra looked at the belt despondent. Aragorn clenched his fists and turned on his heel, throwing a

furious kick to a helmet that lay beside him. He dropped to his knees, letting out a scream of pain and fury to the sky.

C'yra had never seen Aragorn like this before. It would have come as more of a shock, had she not witnessed the friendship he had formed with the Halflings as she gave watch from afar during their journey to Rivendell. She walked over to console the Ranger, only for him to drop to his hands.

"A Hobbit lay here." He said under his breath. "And another…"

"Aragorn, I know that it's hard but…" Aragorn paid her no mind, crawling forward as his tracking skill read the signs in the grass.

"They crawled along, their hands were bound…" He followed the path a few more feet. "Their bonds were cut!" He pulled at something imbedded in the dirt, producing a frayed length of rope. He got up, and walked forward more paces, the other three followed him.

"He's onto something lass!" Gimli said.

"They were followed…" Aragorn continued. "But managed to escape. These tracks lead away from the battle!" C'yra's heart leapt! Those conniving little devils had gotten away! The four ran, following to the end of the tracks.

"And into Fangorn Forest." The Ranger finished. The Hunters laid eyes upon the barrier of trees.

"Fangorn." Gimli said in uneasy awe. "What madness drove them in there?"

"Oh come on Gimli." C'yra said. "There's nothing to be scared of, it's just a forest."

As it would turn out, Fangorn was NOT just a forest. The trees grew thick and wide, blotting out almost all light from the high

noon sun, a damp dank smell of natural rot and nature filled the thick air, and an oppressive presence filled the woods, almost as if it was looking upon any who dared enter with inherit malice and rage. To C'yra, it was like something or someone had wronged the Whispering Woods outside the Fright Zone, then had left them to stew in anger for at least ten centuries. At least the trees and other plants weren't moving of their own accord here.

"This forest is old." Legolas observed, treating the area with a wary reverence. "Very old."

"When the days of the world were young," he continued. "The Elves would walk the woods, and wake the trees, teach them to speak."

"And how'd that go for them?" C'yra snarked.

"Hmph. Talking trees." Gimli said. "And what do trees have to talk about?! Except for the consistency of squirrel droppings." At that C'yra gave a hearty laugh.

"'Could you believe it?' Says the oak to the elm," C'yra said between chuckles. "'The little beast had the nerve to relieve itself on me, then it made off with one of my acorns!' 'You think that's bad?' Says the elm, 'Wait 'til I tell you what this family of birds has been doing to my trunk!'" A deep, low, guttural groan sounded through the forest, oddly reminiscent of the creaking of an old chair when sat upon, or a well used bed frame. Gimli raised his axe and C'yra's tail and fur went on end, her claws extending! At this, the groan resounded again, much louder this time and… Angrier?

"Gimli!" Aragorn whispered. "Lower your axe! C'yra, your claws!" They did so, their faces now mildly nervous.

"They have feelings, my friends." Legolas stated. C'yra slowly raised her hands defensively to her shoulders.

"Er, sorry! It didn't even sound funny in my head, and I totally wasn't going to start climbing you guys!" She said awkwardly.

“I don’t think they believe you, C’yra.” Gimli whispered to her as they walked along. It was hard to tell how much time had passed as they walked, but it was long for sure. Long enough that C’yra soon found herself becoming frustrated.

“I’m up for a nature walk as much as the next Magicat, sure beats the Hell out of running, but I’m getting tired of this scavenger hunt shit. It’s so boring!”

“Perhaps then, C’yra.” Legolas said. “You would be interested in a game of ‘What I See’ to pass the time?” C’yra stopped on the spot.

“Was that a joke?” She said, amused. “May the ancestors rejoice, the Elf does have a sense of humor after all! I was getting worried it would have to be left to me and the Dwarf alone to keep Isildur’s Heir from being so stoic all the time.”

Eventually, the Dwarf found his attention grabbed by an odd collection of black liquid on a leaf, he brushed some off, and brought it to his tongue.

“Orc blood!” He spat.

“These are strange tracks.” Aragorn said, taking notice of a series of small craters forming a line. C’yra peered into one of them.

“Looks like we found out what happened to the Orc that was chasing Merry and Pippin.” She said, regarding the crushed corpse that lay within.

“What in these woods could have done that?” The Ranger wondered.

“Great, another giant ancient creature that even you don’t know about.” C’yra said. “Let’s hope that this one’s a lot more friendly.” Legolas stopped, and began looking about, searching for something. C’yra’s ears flicked.

“What is it?” Aragorn asked them, his voice low.

“We’re not alone.” C’yra said.

“The White Wizard approaches.” Legolas added. Gimli tensed up.

“Do not let him speak.” Aragorn ordered. “Or he will put a spell on us.” He and C’yra reached for their blades, Gimli and Legolas readied a throwing axe and arrow. They stood there for a short while, waiting.

“Behind us!” C’yra shouted, and the four turned to be met with a figure walking towards them, draped in brilliant white light! Legolas and Gimli attacked, only for the arrow to be deflected and the axe to be shattered! Orange-white flames surrounded the blades of Aragorn and C’yra’s swords, causing them to drop their weapons. The four tried to shield their eyes, and C’yra extended her claws.

“You are tracking the footsteps of two young Hobbits.” The figure said, its voice deep and resonating, sounding as if it were two people speaking instead of one. “They passed this way, the day before yesterday.”

“Where are they?!” C’yra interrogated.

“They ran into someone they did not expect.” The figure said, his voice evening out.

“Show yourself.” Aragorn demanded. The light began to fade, and the figure showed itself to be an old man, his long hair and short beard a silky white, draped in robes of the same color, and leaning upon a smooth white polished staff, its head a hollow carved knot of branches. It was the features of his face though, that gave the companions pause. They all knew this man.

“What the actual fuck?…” C’yra said. Legolas bent to one knee.

“Forgive me.” The Elf said. “I mistook you for Saruman.”

“I am Saruman.” The man said.

“Oh great.” C’yra said, retracting her claws and lowering her hands. “Returned from the grave and senile. A double threat!”

“Or rather Saruman as he should have been!” The old man stated, giving the Magicat an unamused look.

“You fell!” Aragorn exclaimed, still in disbelief.

“Through fire.” The man said. “And water.”

“From the lowest depths where Nameless Things dwell to the highest peak of the Misty Mountains I battled my enemy, the Balrog! Its flame snuffed out, the demon now a thing of slime and ash. Many days we clashed before my strike rang true and I smote his ruin upon the mountainside! Darkness took me, and I strayed out of thought and time, and I wandered on roads that I will not tell…” C’yra raised her uninjured brow.

“You too huh? It’s something else in there, isn’t it?”

“Then…” He said, paying the comment no heed for now. “I awoke, I felt life in me again. I have been sent back, until my task is done.”

“While that sounds foreboding.” C’yra said. “Still, resurrections or not, it’s good to see you Gandalf.”

“Gandalf?” The old man asked. “Yes, that is what they called me. Gandalf the Grey. I am Gandalf the White. And I come to you now, at the turn of the tide. Now come, we have spent all the time that is allowed for the meeting of parted friends. There is business we must see to!”

The five walked to the edge of the forest, Gandalf leading the way.

“So we have come all this way for nothing!” Gimli complained. “And now we have to leave the Hobbits in this dark, dank, tree-

infested…” Fangorn let out another threatening groan.

“I mean charming! Quite charming forest.” He said.

“I don’t think they believe you, Gimli.” C’yra said with a smirk.

“The Hobbits are quite safe!” Gandalf said. “In fact they’re a lot safer than you four are about to be!” He paused at the forest’s edge. “It was not mere chance that Merry and Pippin were brought to Fangorn, indeed their arrival is like the falling of small stones that begin an avalanche on the mountainside. The trees are awakening, and they will find that they are strong.”

“Strong?” C’yra said, glancing about the trees in question. “I wonder how that’s going to turn out.”

“It will be none of your concern for the moment C’yra Halfmoon.” Gandalf said. “There are tidings I bring to you from Caras Galadhon. To which I can only share those for Aragorn and Legolas. To Aragorn I was bidden to say this:

‘Where now are the Dunedain, Elessar, Elessar?

Why do thy kinsfolk wander far?

Near is the hour when the lost should come forth,

And the Grey Company ride from the North.

But dark is the path appointed for thee:

The Dead watch the road that leads to the Sea.’ And to Legolas the Lady sends this word:

‘Legolas Greenleaf long under tree

In joy thou hast lived. Beware the Sea!

If thou hearest the cry of the gull on the shore,

Thy heart shall then rest in the forest no more.’

“As for you C’yra, your tidings shall come later, when the opportunity is more appropriate.” C’yra was thrown off a bit, what sort of tidings from Galadriel would have to wait for an opertune moment?

“There is still one thing that has not changed about you old friend.” Aragorn said fondly. “You still speak in riddles.” Gandalf smiled as well.

“Right.” C’yra said. “Now all we need is for one of us to start speaking only in rhyme. I nominate Gimli.”

“If that is to be the case, I agree.” Said Legolas. “You’ve done enough rhyming already.”

“I did warn you Blondie.” She said with a smug smile as they exited the trees. Gandalf took in a breath, and then let out a four note whistle. A neigh was heard in the distance, and a trio of horses crested the hill. Two of them C’yra recognized, the third was a magnificent stallion of white coat and mane.

‘Leave it to Gandalf to really commit to a new theme.’ She thought idly.

“There is Hasufel, and my friend Arod!” Legolas said. “And the stallion could only be one of the Meras, unless my eyes are deceived by some spell.”

“I think we’ve more than proven that nothing can get past your eyes Legolas.” C’yra said as the stallion greeted Gandalf. There must have been some truth to the Elf’s speculation, as the look she got from the horse’s eyes and the way he regarded her were much too smart for a horse.

“Shadowfax.” Gandalf introduced his mount. “He is the Lord of All Horses. And has been my friend through many dangers.” As the rest of the companions mounted up, Hasufel trotted to C’yra, and nuzzled her.

“Hey you!” She griped in a fond manner, though she would deny it endlessly when asked later. “Take it easy. So where to Gandalf?”

“Edoras.” The Wizard said. “And the Golden Hall of Meduseld. Saruman has gripped a claw there, and it must be removed.” C’yra mounted Hasufel behind Aragorn once more.

“Sounds like a plan. Let’s see about giving an evil Wizard a black eye.” And off they road to the north and west, the wind on their side.

The Two Towers Part II

The King of the Golden Hall

The next couple days were spent riding across the Rohirric countryside. C'yra spent them either in silence as she read more from the journal, idle conversation, or taking in swordplay lessons from Aragorn. The ride was nearing the end of its first week when they came upon a great hill bearing a large settlement upon it, at the hill's peak sat a great hall with a golden colored thatched roof. Reaching the front gates, a flutter could be heard on the wind as a grand banner flew overhead, depicting the silhouette of a grand horse head. The banner fell to the ground, where the group sans Gandalf took notice of it. The gates were opened, and the companions filed in.

They passed many people as they made their way up the hill, each one more haggard than the last.

"You'd find more cheer in a graveyard." Gimli noted.

"What could have Saruman done to cause this?" C'yra asked. "The Horde was never able to cause this kind of despair."

"We may yet find out C'yra." Legolas said. "We approach the main hall." The five travelers dismounted and Gandalf put a grey mantle over himself. They made their way to the doors, where they were stopped. A guard came up to them.

"Halt! No one is allowed to enter as heavily armed as you are." The guard told them, before sighing out. "By order of Grima Wormtongue."

'Wormtongue?' C'yra thought. 'With a name like that, how'd he even manage to get in in the first place?' The companions exchanged glances between each other, then moved to comply, offloading their weapons. As she finished unstrapping her sword and began to place it on the table with her whip, C'yra's hand

brushed up against a pouch on her belt she hadn't used in a while. After setting down her blade, she reached in and produced a small smooth striped stone she found on the banks of the Anduin and had taken a liking to.

"This is a most ancient weapon and sacred heirloom of my people." She told the guards. "Anyone who is not Magicat that touches it will be subjected to a terrible curse." She set the rock next to her weapons and the guards regarded it with extreme caution. C'yra turned to walk into the hall with a satisfied smirk. The guard stopped them again.

"We cannot allow you in Gandalf Greyhame, while you hold your staff."

"You would not part an old man from his walking stick?" Gandalf asked, putting on his best grandfatherly facade. Whether the guards actually fell for it or they too were not so pleased as to what was going on inside, they let the group pass.

Inside the hall there was a great table stretching its length to the fireplace in the middle, where another table closed the distance to the throne of the King of Rohan. Other pieces of furniture such as chairs and smaller tables littered the area, indicating that in better times this was as much a meeting hall as the King's home, off to the back corners were doors that C'yra assumed were pathways to the royal family's living quarters.

Upon the throne sat a man who looked like he'd been there for the last eight hundred years. It was a miracle in of itself that cobwebs did not litter his form. Beside him was the most pitiable and wretched person C'yra had ever seen in her life, and she'd seen Gollum, however briefly. It was as if Hordak and Shadow Weaver had sired an heir.

'Oh no, I think I'm gonna be sick!' C'yra thought as the implications of that set in. Swallowing back a gag, she turned her attention to the here and now.

“The courtesy of your house leaves much to be desired as of late, Theoden son of Thengel.” Gandalf said.

“And why… Should I welcome you?” The king croaked. “Gandalf… Stormcrow?”

“You speak justly my lord.” Said Grima Wormtongue, getting up to meet with the company. “It had not yet been five days since the bitter tidings came that your son was slain upon the West Marches. In Eomer there is little trust, and even now we learn rumor from Gondor that the Dark Lord is stirring in the East. Late is the hour in which this wanderer chooses to return. Lathspell I name you. Ill news is an ill guest.”

“Silence snake!” Gandalf commanded him. “The wise speak only of what they know, Grima son of Galmod. Keep your forked tongue behind your teeth. I have not passed through fire and death to bandy crooked words with a witless worm til the lightning falls.” He raised his staff, and there was a soft rumble as the air changed. It was much like what C’yra had felt at the Bridge of Khazad-Dum, when the Wizard had engaged with Durin’s Bane. But this time, there was somehow even more power to him.

“His staff!” Grima gasped. “I told you to take the Wizard’s staff!” Gandalf strode to where Theoden sat, and the guard ran forward to restrain him. They were instead stopped by the combined prowess of Aragorn, Legolas, Gimli, and C’yra as they engaged the guards unarmed. Short work was made of them.

‘And now we know what happens when all of the warriors are banished from a kingdom.’ C’yra thought. ‘No one is left to defend it. How fortunate that the ones who came were not here to destroy it.’ Seeing that his apparent luck had run out, Grima made to escape only to find himself tackled under the weight of a Dwarf.

“I would stay still if I were you.” Gimli said as C’yra bent down and extended a claw to the worm’s face.

“Can’t take ALL of a Magicat’s weapons if you get my meaning.” She threatened.

“Theoden, son of Thengel.” Gandalf said, his voice carrying authority. “I release you.” There was a pause.

‘Was that it?’ C’yra thought. Then, the old man began to laugh, and many a concerned eyebrow was raised.

“You have no power here.” The King said. “Gandalf the Grey!” Gandalf doffed off the grey mantle he had been wearing, revealing himself for what he really was. The King was practically thrown back in his seat by an unseen force! A blonde woman tried to rush forward, but was stopped by Aragorn.

“I will draw you Saruman, as poison is drawn from a wound.” Gandalf said, pointing his staff at the now thrashing king, moving its tip as if aiming it at something.

“If I go, Theoden dies!” Saruman exclaimed through the possessed Theoden.

“You did not kill me, you will not kill him!” Theoden thrashed around for a bit more.

“Rohan is mine!” Saruman said, struggling Theoden to a sitting position before making him leap from the throne with a yell! Gandalf thrust his staff forward one last time, driving Saruman from the King of Rohan! Aragorn released the woman, who ran to his side. As the King was catching his breath, his very image changed. Slowly at first, but eventually catching some speed, the years melted from Theoden’s face, fading away until the image of a still aged, but much healthier and fit man locked back into place, looking about as if waking from a long dream.

“I know your face.” He said softly, regarding the woman. He then turned to the Wizard. “Gandalf?”

“Breathe the free air again.” Gandalf said. Theoden flexed his fingers.

“Perhaps your fingers would remember your old strength better, if they grasped your sword.” Gandalf suggested, and the King’s sword was brought to him. Reaching out he drew it slowly and examined the blade briefly, before bringing his eyes to meet Gimli and C’yra’s, turning down to their prisoner.

Grima Wormtongue cried out as he was kicked down the steps outside the Golden Hall. Scrambling to his knees, he pleaded.

“I have only ever, served you my Lord!” Theoden was having none of it as he strode forward. From the top of the stairs, the company observed the ongoing spectacle.

“I knew I should have saved my lembas ration.” C’yra said to herself. There was nothing like lunch and a show if you asked her.

“Your leechcraft would have had me crawling down on all fours like a beast!” Theoden accused as he raised his sword, Aragorn rushed to him.

“No my Lord!” Aragorn said. “Enough blood has been spilled on his account.” Theoden stopped, and noticed the crowd that had gathered. He lowered his weapon and nodded.

“Can we still at least knock him down the rest of the stairs before we kick him out?” C’yra asked. She would get no answer as Grima fled, leaving the settlement astride a ratty horse.

“Where is Theodred?” The King asked, getting his bearings further. “Where is my son?”

C’yra, Aragorn, Legolas, and Gimli watched the funeral from afar. The woman who had ran to Theoden’s side, his niece Eowyn, sang a song of mourning as her cousin’s body was committed to the burial mounds.

“Such a shame.” Gimli said. “That the young should die as the old linger.”

“And that many more shall die. Before all is over.” Legolas said.

“Hopefully we can try and save all we can.” C’yra said as Gandalf spoke with Theoden. “Gandalf’s too pressed by the time we don’t have. If he isn’t careful, his counsel will remind Theoden too much of Grima.”

“At the very least we will be able to rest the night.” Aragorn said. “A small thing in the coming dark.”

Regaining his mind had been a process for King Theoden. He was not sure if his new guests were helping it along or hindering it though. In the two days following the farewell to his son, he had often caught sight of the Dwarf and Elf discussing their personal tactics, with Legolas even offering to teach Gimli the bow. Aragorn strode about, helping the guards undo any remaining damage that Grima had done, tending to the common folk of Edoras. When she was not helping the guard go over defensive measures, Theoden often spied the fabled Wildcat of Arnor lounging atop the rafters of the Golden Hall, her nose in a small tome. He had heard of her skill as a hunter of evil things a few years ago, but never did he think he would meet the peculiar woman in question, or that she would have some aptitude for strategy. Still, her demeanor and habits unnerved him some. She did not seem all that inclined to talk with him either, and he supposed that for now it was best for them both to respect the current status between them until the proper circumstance where neither party was too busy to talk.

Eowyn on the other hand, managed to find some conversation with her, and Theoden was glad for that. He’d rather have his niece making friends than worrying over him.

C’yra thought she wouldn’t really like Eowyn at first, but was pleasantly surprised to find that the shield maiden was of a strong spirit, even going so far as to teach herself to use a sword in spite of her uncle’s misgivings toward the subject.

“Theodred’s death will likely hang on to him and make the subject more uneasy.” Eowyn told her. “He has had a hard time understanding that those without swords can still die upon them even in our position.”

“You wish to fight for your people like your brother?” C’yra said as she looked out over the plains with the Lady of the Golden Hall. “Be glad that you at least get to do so by choice. I was raised to make war, and it is not something that should be brought onto a child.” She paused.

“Your uncle is a man set in the ways he has lived by for a long time. Perhaps the best way to change his mind isn’t direct confrontation. I suggest you wait for the right moment to show him that you have as much a right to defend Rohan as anyone else with the means to do so has. It may take a while, but with things going as they are, you’ll have an opportunity yet.” Eowyn considered this, and gazed over the plains.

“What is that?” She asked. C’yra followed her sight.

“It’s a rider. Too short to be an adult, and I doubt any of Gimli’s kin would come here.” The distant rider fell, and the two women rushed to investigate.

The rider had turned out to be a young boy, in charge of bringing his smaller sister to the safest place possible atop their family’s pony as they fled their village. Attacked and burnt to the ground by Saruman’s forces.

“They had no warning my Lord.” Eowyn said as she comforted the shaken children at the table. Theoden sat on his throne, Gandalf

at his side. Aragorn and C'yra stood near one of the hall's supports, Legolas and Gimli took in lunch further down the table.

"This is but a taste of what Saruman has in store." The Wizard said. "You must act now!"

"Though open war?" The King asked, standing. "I respect your council Gandalf. But know this, I will not bring further death to my people."

So to the fortress of Helm's Deep it was. Gandalf was not amused.

"They flee to the mountains when they should stand and fight!" Gimli exclaimed as he, Legolas, and C'yra walked to the stables.

"I have to give Theoden credit though." C'yra said looking around the settlement. "A fortress built into a mountainside will be a lot easier to defend than this place." She paused.

"Don't tell Gandalf I said that." She added with a wince. "I think there's actually a good chance he might zap the next person who irks him this time." The Wizard had blustered his way down to the stables just earlier, Aragorn at his side.

"And deprive you of debating plans with him?" Legolas asked. "But I'm sure he takes as much enjoyment from your talks as you do."

"That was before he had a wardrobe change and got all hell-bent on saving Arda like he wanted it done yesterday. You were right Gimli, new Gandalf is WAY grumpier… Holy shit, is that how I looked bossing everyone around when I was Force Captain?"

"With perspective comes enlightenment." Legolas said sagely, thinking on what the journey so far had brought to himself as well.

"Yeah." C'yra said with a chuckle. "That and the Mother of all Road Trips." They reached the stables, and C'yra readied herself for

more miles upon an overly affectionate horse.

An Attack Upon the Road

"It's true that you don't see many Dwarf women." Gimli said as he rode Arod alone, Eowyn walked beside him, as she had spent practically the whole journey around the four Fellowship members, wanting to know more of the friends and their travels.

C'yra supposed that was what spending too long in one place could do to a person. From atop Hasufel as Aragorn was leading the mare behind Arod, she spared a glance over the Misty Mountains and then northward. Though she had decided upon it long ago in those hills past the Gap and under a different name, she still felt a simultaneous fond longing for Arnor along with the desire to explore more of Arda. Perhaps even a trip back to the Golden Wood was in order, under less stressful circumstances. She turned her attention back to Gimli.

"Though," Gimli continued. "They are so alike in voice and appearance, they are often mistaken for Dwarf men." Eowyn and C'yra both made a confused face at this, then Aragorn gestured to his face with a whisper

"It's the beards." They then both made their own expressions of understanding.

"This has led to the rumor that there ARE no Dwarf women." Gimli said. "And that we just pop out of holes in the ground!" Eowyn laughed heartily, and C'yra found herself amused at the thought of Entrapta excitedly watching such a thing happen and clamoring to take notes.

"Which is, of course, ridiculous!" Gimli remarked with a huff. Just then, something managed to spook Arod, and Gimli found himself

hurtling forward before being thrown off with a great clatter. C'yra jumped from the saddle and ran up to him.

"Oh crap! Are you alright Gimli?"

"I'm alright!" The flustered Dwarf insisted. "It was deliberate! It was deliberate!"

When they made camp for the night, Eowyn came to C'yra and Aragorn, bringing soup for them. C'yra had gone deep into the journal of her biological mother now. Turning the page, she was met with a drawing of an all-too familiar object. The very one that made its home in her left thigh.

"Well how about that?" She asked herself, looking to the blade before turning to the title of the entry. "The Sword of Omens? Every magic weapon's gotta have a name these days."

"It's not much, but would you two care for some soup?" Eowyn asked, bringing C'yra from her thoughts. She and Aragorn accepted the bowls that were filled, the Ranger eating from a small spoon and the Magicat drinking straight from the bowl.

"It's good." Aragorn said.

"Really?" Eowyn asked, enheartened by the comment.

"Yeah." C'yra said stiffly.

Upon the turning of Eowyn's back, they both turned to each other and exchanged knowing looks. Miraculously they prevented their faces from turning green as they moved to discreetly dispose of the unfortunate dish.

"By the way," Eowyn said, turning to them again, the duo scrambling to look like they were enjoying the meal. "My uncle

told me something Lord Aragorn. That you had ridden with his father during his reign." Aragorn mulled that over a smile on his face.

"Theoden has a good memory, he was only a boy at the time I rode with Thengel under the name Thorongil."

"But that was decades ago!" Eowyn exclaimed. "You'd have to be at least sixty." Aragorn said nothing.

"But you can't be anywhere near eighty."

"I'm eighty seven." The Ranger said. Eowyn's eyes widened in recognition.

"You are one of the Dunedain, a descendent of Numenor blessed with long life."

"There are few of us left."

"Don't worry Aragorn." C'yra said. "If you really want to fit in with everyone else, Legolas, Gimli, and I will have you looking your age in no time!" Aragorn gave her one of his signature stern looks that he often dispensed when she mouthed off. Over the years she had been here, C'yra had noticed that there was increasingly less of a bite to them these days in all but the most inappropriate circumstances.

"It is quite cute really." Eowyn said to Aragorn. "The way she treats you and the others as if you were older brothers." Neither noticed the offended look on the Magicat's face as she got up and walked off, Aragorn answered.

"Before she came here and joined our company, she had led a life of much pain and isolation. We and the rest of our company were the first in many years to treat her as a fellow person worthy of our companionship."

As Aragorn related what he felt was appropriate in regards to C'yra's life, the Magicat in question stamped off toward Hasufel.

“Cute?!” She huffed indignantly as she neared the chestnut mare. “I’m the fucking Wildcat of Arnor! I don’t do cute.” She then quickly looked to all sides, confirming that nobody was watching and held up an apple to Hasufel, who took it gladly.

“Yeah,” C’yra said as he petted Hasufel’s face. “You’re a good horse.” After that, she took out the journal, eager to figure out just what was going on with her sword.

The next day began like every other had on the journey to Helm’s Deep. C’yra was tempted to note their apparent good luck in this venture considering that there was an evil White Wizard at large who had thrown in his lot with a Dark Lord who wanted to conquer the world for his own, but she was not so confident as to tempt fate at this time.

Regardless, it would seem that whatever controlled fate had decided that the evacuation from Edoras was going much too smoothly for its liking. The two riders that had gone out to look ahead had yet to return. A distant ruckus and series of cries sounded out ahead, and C’yra felt something in her gut drop. Not too far away, Legolas’ voice called out.

“A scout!”

In the following chaos of the civilians fleeing to an alternative route, all she was able to hear was something about Wargs. She stiffened up in her position behind Aragorn atop Hasufel. Seldom did she have to deal with the creatures known as Wargs since she had come to Middle-Earth, and each time only solidified her growing weariness of them. Much like wild wolves they were, only more ravenous and possessing of the apparent inherent malice that every creature under the service of Evil seemed to possess here. For all the good that living in Arda had brought C’yra, she was glad that whatever primordial force there was behind the concept of Evil had not taken as tight a hold on Etheria as it had here.

The line of riders crested the hill where Legolas stood, the Elf had been taking some preliminary shots at the pack of oncoming Wargs and their Orc riders. As his horse Arod approached with Gimli upon his back, Legolas reached out with his off hand and pulled himself onto the horse with an elegant flip. Despite the oncoming battle, C'yra rolled her eyes.

A mounted charge in some ways shares a similar tension to a coiling spring, winding tighter and tighter until the spring snaps back outward. Such was the tension felt by C'yra just before the meager defenders of Rohan clashed with the Warg Riders of Saruman! Before the first clash of battle was struck, C'yra did what was probably the most ill-advised thing she had done in weeks and leapt from the horse, sailing through the air brandishing her sword in its dagger form! She collided with one of the mounted Orcs, knocking him from his Warg and tumbling to the plain! She had managed to catch the Orc in the shoulder with a dagger stab, and followed up with a quick stab to the neck, felling her enemy! Rolling to her feet, C'yra extended the Sword of Omens to its full length, sidestepping the now riderless Warg as it charged her, and thrusting her blade into its side!

And thus she moved about the battlefield, weaving around horse and Warg alike, striking a blow whenever she found the chance to! At a couple points she even managed to trip up a Warg or throw one of their riders by catching them with her whip! C'yra leapt to the side as a Warg pounced at her, rewarding it for its folly by slashing its neck! To her great luck, its rider had ended up pinned under the body, allowing her to finish the Orc off with a downwards stab to the chest! She raised her weapon again, hastily looking around the battle. A battle that had apparently ended as quickly as it had begun.

Catching her breath, C'yra retracted her blade and sheathed it. Noticing an oddly neat pile of Warg corpses sandwiching that of an Orc. Though all three were clearly dead, the bodies were moving. Curious, C'yra ran up to the unusual sight. There she found Gimli of all people, trapped underneath the pile and using his impressive strength to shift the bodies off of him.

“Gimli?” C’yra asked, kneeling down to help pull the Dwarf out. “What the Hell happened to you?”

“I’d rather not talk about it!” The Dwarf said as she pulled him from the pile, the force of the yank being enough to throw her into a sitting position. Once they had both stood and brushed themselves off, they began to search for Legolas and Aragorn. They found the former first, while he’d been searching for the latter.

“I last saw him this way, being dragged along by one of the beasts.” The Elf explained, leading them in the direction of a cliff, just a few paces away lay a dying Orc, a snarled smile upon his scarred face as he gave out a series of gurgling chuckles.

“Let’s see if he knows something.” C’yra said. Gimli set a foot on the Orc’s torso, brandishing his axe.

“Tell us what you know and I’ll ease your suffering.”

“You were the last one to see the Ranger, correct?” C’yra interrogated. The Orc nodded.

“He’s… dead!” The Orc coughed out. “Took a little tumble off the cliff!” Legolas reached down, grabbing the Orc by his bunched up and broken riding leathers.

“You lie!”

“Do I?” The Orc said before letting out a series of final choked laughs, then was still. Legolas noticed something clutched in the Orc’s hand, and investigated. C’yra looked to the Elf’s hand to see a distinctive necklace from which hung a white leaf shaped pendant that seemed to glow with its own light.

“Arwen gave that to Aragorn.” C’yra said. “Before we left Rivendell!” She bolted to the cliff side, Legolas and Gimli following her. They looked over the edge to see nothing but a rushing river. C’yra fell to her knees desperately trying to hold back the oncoming sobs. Legolas and Giml each put a hand on her

shoulder, hanging their heads. There they stayed until Theoden took notice. Still deep in grief, the three found their horses, and rode onward to Helm’s Deep.

The Two Towers Part III

Helm's Deep

For the first three days since they had arrived at the great fortress of Helm's Deep, C'yra barely spoke and was even more rarely seen. While Legolas and Gimli helped in matters regarding the refugees of Rohan where they could, the majority of their time was spent searching for the Magicat. But alas, it would seem that Aragorn was not the only one who could easily avoid being seen if they so wished.

Then, on the eve of the third day, Legolas looked over the ramparts to see C'yra standing upon the wall, looking out into the gorge as her cloak fluttered in the wind. She had not moved by the time that he and Gimli walked to where she stood. Her left ear twitched as she heard them coming.

"Oh, hey guys." She said, still not turning to look at them. "Sorry about earlier. I just… Needed some time alone."

"You had every right to that lass." Gimli said.

"We would happily give you all the time you need to yourself." Legolas said. "But next time we would appreciate it if you told us beforehand." C'yra turned to them then, her eyes still puffy from the last few days of crying.

"You're right. It's just… I still can't believe he's gone. After everything." She paused with a gulp. "If it hadn't been for Aragorn, I probably would have died as soon as I came here. And he was the first person who tried to befriend me, even though I was being a major bitch for that first year. I guess he always saw the real me. Even then. And now after this whole screwed up adventure with all of you guys, I was actually starting to feel like I had finally gotten… A family. Like you guys were the brothers I

never got to have. And now two of them are ancestors knows where lugging around the universe's most dangerous jewelry, two more are under the protection of a bunch of freaky trees, and now two are gone for good, while my pseudo grandpa is off looking for help. I'm just… I'm just a little scared that I might lose the rest of you before I have the chance to tell you this. What I couldn't tell Aragorn." Silence fell between them for a moment, and C'yra was caught off guard as Legolas and Gimli both brought her in for a firm group hug.

"You will not be losing us yet, gawthel." Legolas said.

"Aye." Gimli agreed. "And if that time does come, let us hope we fall together."

"Thanks you two." C'yra said, and then ended the hug. "So, we probably don't have much time before Saruman figures out where we ran off to. What can I do to help?" At that moment, a Rohirric soldier ran across the wall to them.

"Lady C'yra!" He said. "King Theoden requests your presence!"

"Lady?" C'yra asked. "That's a new one. What does he need me for?"

C'yra gave the rudimentary map of the fortress another glance as she leaned over the table, both arms supporting her. She stood back up to look at Theoden.

"If I were back on Etheria, I'd tell you that we would be in a word, fucked." C'yra told him. "The Horde's weapons technology is centuries ahead of anything we have, and the magical might of just one Princess would be able to turn the walls into dust in a matter of seconds. But thankfully, Saruman doesn't seem the type to want to do things himself and the worst he could bring in terms of siege weaponry are more than likely battering rams, ballista hooks, and ladders. It's like you said sir, they'll break upon the wall like water on rock. The only real problem is that there are so

few of us, and ancestors know how many of them are coming." Theoden thought on this.

"I thank you for your counsel, C'yra Halfmoon. Crass as it may be. If only my nephew and his men were here. If my greatest fears are realized, we will have to recruit every able bodied man and boy to our ranks."

"If we are all to die anyway, then at least consider to make it their choice and not yours. I've seen enough forced to fight against their will in my time." Theoden's face became stern, but whether it was because he intended to barate her, or it was a look of anger at those who would raise child soldiers, C'yra did not know. And she would never figure out, as the double doors to the keep bust open, allowing the one responsible to stride in. C'yra turned to greet them, and was met with a second impossible sight in as many months.

"Aragorn?!" C'yra exclaimed, sounding less and less angry about the sight as she rushed to him. "You son of a BITCH!!!" She practically tackled the Ranger in a great bear hug.

"I can't believe it!" C'yra raved. "That's two of us who've cheated death now! If I hadn't seen him pass on myself, I wouldn't be surprised if Boromir came barging in next, cursing us out for sending him down a waterfall!" Theoden, while also as surprised, saw in Aragorn's eyes that he was here on a mission.

"What news do you bring, son of Arathorn?"

"I swear to every last one of my ancestors." C'yra grumbled, taking a seat at a table and a flagon of ale in her hand. "If you're really out there, if he scares me like that again, everyone will not be able to forgive me for my actions."

"An army of Uruk-Hai march this way." Aragorn said. "Ten thousand strong at least. They will be here by tomorrow night."

"Ten thousand?!" The King exclaimed. There was a great sputtering noise as C'yra spat out her ale.

“It is an army bred with one purpose.” Aragorn concluded. “To destroy the world of Men.”

The next twenty-four hours were spent in a hurricane of movement as the would be defenders of Helm’s Deep rushed to prepare for the coming onslaught. Into the evening they set up all manner of defenses and ushered the civilians into the Glittering Caves that Gimli had become enamored with during their stay. Dusk had fallen by the time that C’yra managed to get into the armory. With her agility, she’d been managing quite well over the last years. However, the skirmish at Balin’s Tomb all those days ago had given her a long time to think, and so she found a spare basic leather jerkin that she slipped over her tunic, following up with two vambraces around her forearms and pauldron that she strapped to her left shoulder. Reclasping her cloak, C’yra managed to get a good enough look at herself in the polished center of a shield hanging on a nearby rack before it was taken and given to one of the older conscripts in the armory. At least she hoped they were not conscripts. It had taken quite a while, Gimli had managed to get his new chainmail under armor up to snuff, and Legolas had acquired shoulder protection of his own. The three gathered in the middle of the armory, watching the others mill about as Aragorn entered.

“Many of them have seen too many winters.” Legolas said.

“Or too few.” Gimli added. C’yra could tell what they were truly thinking from the grave tone of their voices. How could she not? She was thinking it as well.

“So this is probably it this time huh?” C’yra said, breathing out heavily. “Is… Is there anything you guys wanna get off your chests? Any regrets? Things you would have liked to have done?” They all thought for a while.

“I would have wished to look upon the White Tower one last time.” Aragorn said. “Meet with my kinsman. And, for one last

proper farewell with Arwen."

"I would like to talk with my father." Legolas said. "After my mother was taken from us, we've been distant with each other for too many years. I would try to rebuild our bonds."

"I would have liked to reunite with my kinsmen as well." Gimli said. "Bring the news of Moria to my people. And perhaps one day meet the Lady of the Golden Wood a last time."

"And you, C'yra?"

"I wish to explore Arda more." C'yra said. "To visit more of the lands East of the Misty Mountains, learn more of Legolas and Gimli's homes. I would like to reunite with all four of our Hobbit friends and thank them for the time we shared. And learn of Etheria's fate, if at least to get that last burden off my shoulders." All confessions were met with nods of understanding and approval from the other Fellowship members.

"If we are to meet our fates tonight." C'yra said. "Then I am glad that we're going to do it together, my friends. My brothers." Her statement finished, the resounding bellow of a war horn echoed through the small gorge, even into the depths of the Hornburg's armory.

"That is no Orc horn!" Legolas exclaimed. The four rushed outside.

Theoden could scarcely believe it himself, a battalion of some odd two hundred and fifty elves, clad in maroon cloaks and golden armor marched up the bridge and into the first section of the keep. Aragorn, Legolas, Gimli, and C'yra walked up behind him just in time for the leader of the battalion to make himself known. Aragorn and Legolas were the first to greet him in Elvish. Followed by C'yra Halfmoon's apparently customary overblown familiarity and utter lack of decorum.

“Haldir! I can sincerely say that it’s good to see you! You’re not too sore about that mouse I caught and hid in your bedroll, are you?”

“What in the name of the Valar are you talking about?” The Elf in question asked.

“Oh. That wasn’t YOUR bedroll?” C’yra asked awkwardly. “Whoops. My bad.”

“What is the meaning of this?” Theoden asked, getting the proceedings back on track.

“Once an Alliance of Men and Elves fought side by side against Dark forces.” Haldir explained. “We have come to honor that alliance.” Legolas conspicuously moved closer to his brethren.

“We are proud to fight alongside Men once more.”

An hour and a half later, Aragorn, C’yra, Legolas, and Gimli found themselves positioned and ready upon the Deeping Wall. A storm brewed in the distance, and the tension was thick enough to cut with a sword.

“You actually tried to plant a dead mouse in Haldir’s bedroll.” Legolas stated in disbelief.

“I would have done it to Aragorn, but he started only bringing out his when he was going to sleep directly afterward after I pranked him while we were scouting the edges of the Old Forest west of Bree two years ago. It’s surprising how high he can jump from a prone position.”

“I get the feeling you are missing the entire point of this discussion.”

“Haldir just seemed way too uptight for his own good.” C’yra said in her defense. “It’s not my fault all of his wardens’ gear looked

the same.” Thunder rumbled down into the gorge, and C’yra strained her eyes.

“Wouldn’t it be awkward if Aragorn was off by a day predicting when the enemy would get here?” Legolas just sighed, resolving to bring this up again later should they survive the coming battle.

“The lad’s seldom been off on such measures before. Why would you doubt?” Gimli asked.

“All this standing around and waiting’s been making me antsy.” She responded. “And that storm headed our way is definitely not helping things.” She idly tapped the fingers of her left hand on the scabbard holding her sword to her thigh, and then had an idea.

“Wait a second!” C’yra said, peering down at her weapon.

The notes on the weapon she had found within the journal had detailed a few old legends regarding certain abilities the sword had alongside being able to function as a dagger. She drew the weapon and extended the blade. Slowly, she raised it so that the crossguard was near her face.

“Ok sword…” C’yra said under her breath. She knew that the other functions of the sword were said to be magic accessed through the voice command of its wielder, but the exact words had been lost to time. Anything was worth a try though. “Show me what lies ahead!” Nothing happened.

“Uh, bring me visions of the distance?”

“Extend my eyesight?”

“Let me gaze beyond?”

“Enhance my perception!”

“May I see all!”

“Go-go binocular sword!”

“Ugh!” C’yra growled. “Some magic sword you are! Why don’t these things ever come with instructions?” Legolas, Gimli, and a few of the Elves surrounding them gave her concerned looks.

“Perhaps it is a matter of instinct?” Gimli suggested.

“More likely the damn thing’s stuck doing its extending blade trick.” She griped, looking forlornly into the ruby colored gem slotted into the blade. Who was she kidding? An artifact of her people or not, this weapon was clearly intended for use by those with a great lineage. The only reason the sword had even come to her was by the mere chance of her mother being an archeologist who got lucky. There was no way a sword meant for Kings and Queens would reveal its secrets to the orphaned daughter of a dead tribe cast from their home planet and locked into a starless pocket dimension. C’yra turned the sword in her hand as the distant lightning flashed, the inlit gem catching the light of the act of nature.

For some strange reason she could not comprehend, a great sense of calm washed over her. She breathed and exhaled deep. Almost absently, she lifted the sword to her face once more. The words came, through her mind and out her mouth with her only barely even realizing it.

“Sword of Omens, give me Sight Beyond Sight!”

The stone in the blade began to glow with a crimson light and a soft rumbling growl emanated from the blade. C’yra’s eyes widened as her vision magnified leagues forward and up the hill that led into the gorge. And there she saw them, Saruman’s great army of Uruk-Hai, thundering along in a wall of flesh and steel as they reached the hill.

C’yra disengaged herself from the sword with a gasp, nearly losing her footing at the shock. Off in the distance, one could now see unaided the torchlights of the ever coming force.

“What is it C’yra?” Gimli asked. “What did you see?” C’yra regained her bearings.

“Let’s just say that ten thousand is only a number until you see it for yourself.” She gulped. The storm hit them then, rain falling slow at first, before it became a full-on torrent.

The army marched ever forward, filling the gorge until none of the Hornburg’s defenders could see the ground upon which the enemy stood. The Uruk general gave a commanding roar, and the army stopped. All was silent but for the thunder and falling rain.

“What are they waiting for?” C’yra whispered to herself. Aragorn stopped his pacing about near the other three, looking to the clouds.

“The storm is ferocious. At least the rain won’t last the night.”

“Your friends are with you Aragorn.” Legolas said.

“Let’s hope they last the night.” Gimli said.

“Shouldn’t be too hard.” C’yra said humorlessly. “Aragorn can take the two thousand in the center, Legolas the two thousand on the center left, Gimli gets the ones on the center right. I’ll take on the two thousand on the outside right, and everyone else gets the rest on the outside left. Totally foolproof plan.” Aragorn merely backed up to be in signaling sight of the Elven archers stationed behind the wall.

Another roar came from the Uruk general, and the whole front line of the army began to rhythmically pound their pikes into the ground, those behind them simply stomped their feet or bashed their fists and shields against their chests in a display meant to terrorize the small army of defenders.

“What’s going on out there?!” Gimli questioned as he hopped in place, trying in vain to look over the battlements.

“Shall I describe it to you?” Legolas offered. “Or shall I get you a box?” Gimli looked at him and let out a mirthful chuckle. All of the defenders who could drew their bows, and then readied their first shots as they were told to hold for now.

For as long as C’yra Halfmoon would live, she would occasionally wonder why Aragorn had commanded the archers to hold for so long. Why wait to get the battle underway as opposed to getting it over with as soon as possible? Regardless of whatever the outcome would be.

Though it felt like an hour, only a minute and a half passed before one of the Rohirrim archers upon the Hornburg’s parapets lost his grip and sent his arrow sailing, right into the thin opening where the Uruk’s helmet separated from his breastplate as luck would have it. One of the very few weaknesses in their armor. Everything seemed to stop once the arrow hit, and all throughout the gorge, the pained groan of the first casualty of the battle could be heard as he fell forward to the ground with a great clatter. This in turn, made his fellow Uruks quite angry indeed, and their general gave out one last battle roar!

“Here we go…” C’yra said to herself as the army charged forward. The Battle of Helm’s Deep had begun.

The tide of battle was flowing to the advantage of the defenders at first, as a hail of arrow volleys from Men and Elf alike sailed into the throng of Saruman’s horde. Even some of the pure black battle banners carrying the Wizard’s White Hand faltered as their bearers were pushed forward and met their ends. The ranks of the Uruk-Hai were so thick that C’yra was of the impression that however many arrows they had in store for these creatures would be enough to hold the horde back, regardless of the skill of their archers. The only problem was they didn’t have anywhere near upwards of ten thousand arrows.

That and it appears that the beasts had begun to get lucky, running to the walls with ballistas and other devices engineered with only one purpose in mind. Aragorn yelled out something in Elvish, and the warriors of Lothlorien drew their swords.

"They're coming up!" C'yra shouted, raising her sword.

"Finally!" Gimli exclaimed, readying his axe.

The last truly extended melee that C'yra had fought through had been Balin's Tomb. And she had left that one down a cloak and now possessing a thick scar over her left eye. Whatever the Goblins of Moria could have brought to a battle was nothing compared to this. The Uruks fought with an impeccable fury and calculated cruelty that the chaos of those deep dwellers could never hope to match! Roughly fifteen minutes had passed since the ladders had been deployed, and C'yra began to wonder just how far Aragorn's lessons in swordplay had brought her, and how much was merely luck. Gimli swung his axe overhead, catching an Uruk who had just reached the ladder's top right below the belt! Seeing this, C'yra was torn between an urge to wince and the beginnings of a laugh reaching her throat. She chose the latter.

An Uruk of the berserker class jumped from the ladder and to the wall, whirling his great sword like a baton and catching many an Elf, taking out seven in only two swings! C'yra ducked under the backswing and thrust her sword into his unarmored chest, then charged and pushed the ladder itself with all her might! The ladder fell, taking those who were hanging upon it with it, and crushing a great many below under its weight!

"Now that looked like it hurt!" C'yra whooped, the adrenaline had kicked in now. Fear be damned, she was fighting 'til her last! "Let's see them top that!"

"Legolas!" Gimli shouted over the clamor. "Two already?!"

"I'm on seventeen!" Came the response from a few yards away.

"Agh! I'll have no pointy ear outscoring me!"

“Hey, I didn’t say anything about wanting part in a dick measuring contest!” C’yra said, her latest swing carving straight through the sweet spot at an Uruk’s neck!

“I believe he meant Prince Legolas, Lady Halfmoon!” Shouted an Elf next to her, the sounds of Gimli’s exuberant counting echoing across the wall.

“Ugh!” She grunted, flipping over and kicking another off the wall and down a set of stairs. “Blasted Elves and their propriety!”

This went on for another half hour before the oncoming flow of Uruks seemed to slow down. Both by the toppling of ladders and an apparent change in their strategy.

“Why are they slowing down?!” C’yra shouted. “Something down there must’ve changed!” She and Aragorn fought their way to the wall’s edge as Legolas reached higher ground. C’yra was the furthest away from the Hornburg, but she could clearly see what was coming.

“The culvert drain in the wall!” She shouted in realization as a torch bearing Uruk sprinted forward, tanking arrow after arrow from Legolas. “Saruman must’ve developed some kind of black powder!” She turned away from the Hornburg, breaking out into a run as she warned the remaining Elves with her.

“EVERYONE GET TO THE SIDES OR OFF THE WALL!!! IT’S GOING TO-“

KABOOOOOOOOM

C’yra felt herself thrown up and back by the force of the most deafening explosion she had ever heard! It was sheer luck that

she was far enough away to be hit yet not sustain permanent hearing damage. Not that it really mattered, as she soon found herself launched down into a puddle of rainwater, muck, and rubble, nearly losing consciousness! Working through the pain and the haze of the impact, C'yra stumbled a few times before finding her feet.

"MotherFUCKER!!!" She shouted, watching as Aragorn made to lead a counter charge into the Uruk ranks that poured through the hole in the wall. "Okay, that's it! They're gonna WISH that had killed me!"

As she was just one woman, C'yra wasn't exactly the best option for taking on the enemy's left flank, but she was better than nothing! In fact, she'd managed to catch at least three Uruks by surprise!

"Aragorn! Gimli! C'yra!" Shouted Legolas from atop the wall, and C'yra turned her head up just in time to watch him slide a shield forwards, jump on it, and ride down the stairs, firing arrows the whole way!

"SHOW OFF!!!" C'yra hollered, drawing her whip and flinging it at a loose stone in the damaged wall, where it managed to catch! She yanked with all her might, and the rock fell, crushing four Uruks as it landed and rolled a small distance! Speaking of which, she was also making great time on catching up with the rest of the Fellowship present.

The fighting went on for another ten minutes before Theoden managed to get close enough for his retreat order to reach their ears. Cursing once more under her breath, C'yra scrambled up the first stairs she could find and was met with two Rohrrim dragging Gimli away from the fight by his arms, the Dwarf kicking and shouting. In any other situation, she would have laughed at that. From behind, she heard a pained cry of Haldir's name from

Aragorn. That was when she noticed it. The only Elf to make it into the Hornburg was Legolas.

Though she did not understand the full picture, she knew that the majority of Elves had decided to forsake Middle-Earth, and cross the western sea to whatever promised land lay beyond the waters. The Elves were not subject to the ravages of age, and would only die if they were killed. As such, they had wandered and lived in these lands for far longer than any other people of this world. Whether the end of their dominion was because they had felt that they needed to leave or that they had lost hope for the future did not matter right now. Haldir and all who followed him this night would not see the Undying Lands. C'yra never had really thought on it until now, nor did she have the proper words to describe the odd heaviness it brought to her heart.

They had holed up in the Hornburg for two and a half hours now. Some of that precious time had been bought by the efforts of Aragorn and Gimli thanks to a secret door. C'yra had managed to see the feat from the top of the ramparts herself, and had she still been filled with the heart for it, she would have begun to make sure Gimli never lived down the fact he had to be thrown right then and there. There was another great ram to the final door that kept the Uruks from finally destroying them all. C'yra was more focused on what she decided was a small blessing. Both she and all three of her closest friends in the world had made it to the end of the longest night of her life, for whatever these last extra minutes were worth. She sat upon a bench in between Gimli and Legolas, her head hung and her hand limply gripping her sword.

"Figures I'd be on the losing side of a battle, even when I was actually with the good guys for once." She said tiredly. "In retrospect, the one good thing about commanding the Horde was knowing that the Alliance were too much of a bunch of goody two shoes to actually kill me."

“Is that your regrets I hear coming back to haunt you C’yra?” Legolas asked.

“Nah. Not really.” She said, raising her head to look at him with a weary, but still wry smile. “Getting to do all I did with you guys, Hell, even wandering around a place that always had fresh air for once made everything worth it.” She thought for a bit, taking in whatever sights there were left while she could. Dawn was breaking.

“Still, I kinda wish there was more to do than sit and wait.”

“Ride out with me to meet them!” Aragorn said to Theoden, a bit more loudly than he probably intended.

“For death and glory.” The King agreed.

“Eh?” C’yra said, perking up.

“Yes. Yes. The Horn of Helm Hammerhand will ring in the Deep one last time! Let this be the hour where we draw swords together!” Theoden declared. Gimli jumped from where he sat.

“Yes!” He said, running off and up a flight of stairs.

“So we’re actually gonna charge them?” C’yra asked as she followed the group to their horses. She gave a dark chuckle. “Fuck it. What else do we have to lose?”

They reached their collective horses and mounted, Aragorn now astride Theodred’s former horse, Brego. C’yra reached down to soothe Hasufel.

“Sorry girl,” She said. “But this isn’t going to be a peaceful ride.” The horse in turn gave a determined snort.

“Fell deeds awake!” Proclaimed Theoden. “Now for wrath, now for ruin, and a red dawn!” A great rumbling drone sounded from the great war horn built into the fortress, deep the echoes came, louder and clearer with each breath that Gimli put into them. With

a great cry and noise of their own the last defenders of Rohan charged forward, their weapons drawn!

"Forth Eorlingas!" Shouted the King as they rode through. They reached the gates and burst out into the causeway, running through the ranks of Isengard like a thresher through wheat! C'yra brandished her sword from atop Hasufel, stabbing and cutting at the Uruks who seemed to have some sort of fear put into them with the dawning of the day. Through the haze of the charge, she could feel her fur stand on end, as if the universe itself had bent over backwards to move things into their favor. She would get her answer when Aragorn, looking to the top of the gorge, gave a cry.

"Behold the White Rider! Gandalf has come again!"

C'yra looked to the top of the hill, and sure enough Gandalf the White was there, clear as the sun behind him atop Shadowfax. Another rider came forward to meet with him, and then many more, bearing the standard of Rohan!

"Eomer!" Came Theoden's triumphant shout.

Even from as far down as they were, no one could miss Eomer's shout of "To the King!" The Rohirrim let out a war cry and sounded their own horns, charging down the hill to meet with the rest of the defending army! The sun shone even brighter, the work of Gandalf, C'yra suspected. The Uruks who tried to circumvent the reinforcements were blinded and trampled beneath the might of Rohan's finest cavalry! The tide of battle changed, and C'yra found herself urging Hasufel back up the hill, chasing the retreating throng away and out the gorge. Through the chaos of the attack, C'yra managed to end up riding alongside Gandalf.

"You're late!" She exclaimed, no real annoyance in her voice. Gandalf simply smiled, then began to laugh.

“I don’t think I’ve ever seen him laugh before.” C’yra said to herself. “It’s really unsettling.”

The collected riders crested the hill, with Theoden, Gandalf, Eomer, Aragorn, Legolas, and C’yra at the head. Not far from the hill’s top where the Uruks fled, a great line of trees stood where there had once been plains.

“Keep away from the trees!” Eomer ordered.

“Wait.” C’yra said to Aragorn. “Is that…” The Uruks had disappeared into the woods, and not long after there was a great bellowing from within followed by the fearful roaring of Saruman’s remaining forces as the trees began to shake! The cries of the Uruks from within became ever fearful and pained, a cacophony of horrible screaming and angered rumbling followed, accompanied by the sounds of the forest itself engaging in battle.

“Fangorn?” C’yra finished weakly.

The company then went back to do what could be done so far as clean up after the battle, fallen allies were honored, and the dead foes piled and burned. C’yra looked at the hole blasted into the Deeping Wall, and hung her head.

“How didn’t I see that coming?” She asked herself. Aragorn strode up behind her. “Saruman’s Uruks were like nothing I’d seen before. Of course he’d be working, upping his warfare methods in other areas.”

“Even if we did know, we did not have the time nor the means to prevent the breach.” Aragorn told her, a comforting hand on her shoulder. “You cannot blame yourself for every unforeseen misfortune that battle brings.”

“You’re right. I didn’t do this. Saruman did.”

“Come.” Aragorn said. “Let us find Legolas and Gimli.”

"That shouldn't be too hard." C'yra answered. "I think I heard them arguing about the results of their Orc killing contest."

"It is at least good that they have found a more constructive means of competition."

"I'm just hoping that it doesn't become a regular thing. Before long they're going to drag me into it. And I don't like what contests do to me."

Much later Gandalf led them all, Eomer and Theoden included, out of the gorge to overlook the plains and out across the countryside. Off in the furthest distance, an unnatural dark cloud looked over a sinister looking mountain range, orange lighting lancing though the skies over the far off land.

"Sauron's wrath will be terrible, his retribution swift." The Wizard said. "The Battle for Helm's Deep is over. The Battle for Middle-Earth is about to begin."

"Let's not get too ahead of ourselves though." C'yra said. "I think our royal associates would have words with a certain disgraced colleague of yours?"

"Yes, there are loose ends to be tied, and friends to be re-met. Let us go."

It took the company a week to reach the borders of Isengard, now surrounded by a rearranged Fangorn Forest. The group entered the woods, their horses single file with Theoden and Gandalf in the front. C'yra was just near where the middle of the line became the back. While Fangorn's decidedly oppressive air was still present, C'yra found that she was feeling much less unease than the last time. Given Fangorn's proximity to Isengard and Saruman's war effort, it didn't take long for her to connect the dots.

‘Never thought I’d ever find myself on the same page as a scary enchanted forest.’ A small clearing was slowly coming up ahead, and C’yra had been so preoccupied in her thoughts that she had not noticed a trio of all new voices echoing across the trees, arguing about whether they had taken a wrong turn. C’yra’s ears perked at this and she found herself looking at Gandalf, a strangely smug smile on his face.

“Ah.” He said. “Right on time.”

“Hail fellow travelers!” Theoden greeted. “What brings you to Rohan?” The three persons who had walked into the clearing never answered, as they almost immediately made eye contact with C’yra, all four of their jaws dropping.

‘How in the fucking fuck did they fucking… And Gandalf fucking these fucking fucks. SHIT.’ Went C’yra’s thoughts. But what came from her mouth was:

“H-hey Adora.”

The Return of the King Part I

There are many tales that can be told where what is usually a Fellowship of Nine becomes Ten. This is but how one of them ends.

THE RETURN OF THE KING

The Road to Isengard

Adora had changed her hair. Gone was that dorky poof and ponytail, now replaced by her golden hair falling to her shoulders. It framed the now five years older curve of her face perfectly. She had apparently been traveling Arda for some time now, as no evidence of Etheria was to be seen on her reddish brown and amber colored traveling tunic and pants. A crimson hooded mantle draped over her shoulders, silver white leaf-shaped patterns embroidered into the hems of the garment. Upon her feet were sturdy dark brown leather boots. The five years that had passed had certainly been kind to her. By the ancestors, had she gotten even more buff? What was that saying about distance and hearts again? C'yra shook her head, coming out of her daze and leaning to her right, where Legolas and Gimli sat atop Arod.

"Gimli," C'yra said unevenly. "I know that this sounds strange, but I'm gonna need you to pull on my tail." The Elf and Dwarf exchanged a concerned look, but Gimli complied nonetheless. An ear-piercing yowl left the Magicat, and the assembled horses shifted in discomfort.

"Okay!" C'yra exclaimed. "I'm definitely awake!"

"Was that really necessary?" Eomer asked, shooting her a dirty look. The look of shock and astoundment had not left the faces of

Adora and her companions. The blonde shakily raised a pointing hand.

"Y-you, you're not dead." She said. C'yra gave a sheepish smile.

"Uh, surprise?" Next to Adora, one Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon regained her composure and strode forward. She was very much not amused, her new dark blue cloak flowing behind her. Oddly enough it went quite well with the equally dark magenta and purple clothes she was wearing. Her hair was a little bit shorter than C'yra's, styled in a slightly shaggy pixie cut.

"I'm sorry," Glimmer yelled. "But how the FUCK is Catra still ALIVE?" She paused, then made a perplexed face.

"And on a horse?" C'yra's fur bristled. Aragorn, Legolas, and Gimli watched with interest, so their sister-in-arms did know these strangers. There was some small tension. If these were indeed the people she had told them about, they could very well have a most unfortunate and unnecessary conflict on their hands.

"Catra of the Horde is dead." C'yra said. "You speak to C'yra Halfmoon. Though if it's any consolation Sparkles, I've nearly died plenty of times since I got here too. And with increasing regularity." She said that last part mostly to herself. Then Bow stepped forward, putting his hands to Glimmer's shoulders. He was dressed in similar colors to Glimmer, although with a bit more navy blue and a violet cloak, bearing similar embroidery to the other two. True to form, he'd taken the midriff from his new tunic. And he'd grown a beard and put his now dreadlocked hair into a ponytail. Had everyone back on Etheria gotten new haircuts?

"Easy honey, I'm sure that if Cat- Er, C'yra was still one of the bad guys, Gandalf wouldn't be traveling with her! It has been five years after all!" C'yra was taken aback a bit. She'd forgotten how… Oddly Hobbit like Bow was. Come to think of it, he reminded her a lot of Sam.

“Thanks for the vote of confidence, Arrow Boy.” C’yra said, still getting used to being friendly with the people she’d actively tried to kill for two and a half years before spending the next five wondering if she’d ended up succeeding after all. “Wait, HONEY?!” She turned her head to Adora, who had been pointing at her this entire time.

“Adora, how long was it after the portal until they got together?” Adora was thrown off by this, but quickly regained some composure.

“Uh, not long actually. Like a month? I think.” Adora answered. “There was this whole space adventure thing with a galactic conqueror we were dealing with.”

“Eh, still took ‘em long enough.” C’yra said. “I’m pretty sure I knew they had something going the longest.” She turned to Aragorn, Legolas, and Gimli. “They’d been acting like it since this time they caught me in the early days.”

“YOU WHAT?!” Glimmer blurted indignantly. C’yra smirked.

“Oh yes. Some of us in the Horde were even taking bets on it.” She said sarcastically.

“Really?” Adora asked, her shock momentarily overcome by excitement. “We were too!”

“ADORA!” Glimmer admonished, her face tomato red. Bow had a sheepish look on his face, he was blushing too.

“Perfuma won.” Adora finished. Having sat back this entire time Theoden and Eomer exchanged a look.

“We are incredibly out of the circle regarding this.” Eomer said. “Yet I find it strangely compelling.”

“Hmph.” Theoden mused. “Young people.”

"… Like you should talk, Adora!" Glimmer continued in a rant that had even managed to raise the eyebrows of Aragorn. "You spent three whole months stammering around that Bounty Hunter we met before asking her out! What was her name again? Sam-"

"As entertaining as all this is, I am afraid that we have an appointment with Saruman." Gandalf interjected. "As the three of you currently don't have any horses of your own, I recommend that Glimmer ride with me, Bow with Aragorn, and Adora with you C'yra."

"Agreed." Aragorn said. "If there's anything else you need to speak about, either do so on the way or once we return to Edoras." The four Etherians went silent. They couldn't find any words with which to voice an objection.

'Oh boy.' C'yra thought as she allowed Adora up onto Hasufel behind her. 'This is gonna be really awkward isn't it?' Closely ahead, she watched as Glimmer got on Shadowfax behind Gandalf. Just under her hair, C'yra caught the clear sight of a very odd rectangular scar on the back of the Queen's neck.

It was another two hours before C'yra worked up the gumption to say anything.

"So, your first instinct wasn't to go all She-Ra on me, and you willingly got on my horse. I guess you're really not out to kill me then?"

"I thought you were dead." Adora said plainly. "And it's been like five years. A lot's changed Cat, you've changed. And I can tell it's not an act. The magic of this world is a lot like Etheria's, but older… And not as damaged or tampered with. Glimmer's been using her powers for weeks without tiring out. And it's… Been telling me things. How old is this place?"

"You'd have to ask Gandalf about that. I never paid too much attention to the exact details and numbers, but he's at least a thousand years old, probably even ten times that and it's likely that he's only been around relatively recently."

"We went to a lot of different planets after we took down Hordak's master." Adora said. "Healed the magic on them. None of them felt like this. This might be the oldest planet in the universe, if it even is in the same universe."

"You guys got the planet back out into the universe?" C'yra asked. "I wonder what that looked like."

"Amazing. I never thought stars would be so beautiful."

"You and me both. And what do you mean 'tampered with'?"

"We found out that the First Ones had used Etheria's magic to turn it into a giant weapon. We only just got it back to a close enough approximation of what it was before they came. It's part of the reason that I broke the sword and ended up redefining the whole 'She-Ra' thing."

"You broke it?!" C'yra exclaimed.

"Thought you'd be happy to hear that."

"Conflicted is more like it, that thing's partly responsible for us being here and having decidedly better lives in the first place! On the other hand, it came with a Hell of a lot of pain. Speaking of, how did you guys get here?"

"About a month or so ago, Entrapta found a leftover resonance from the Portal Incident. We thought it might help us finally get a lock on Glimmer's mom if she was still out there somewhere. So she, Bow, and I went in. The funny thing is, we took all the proper precautions, got a stable gate and everything. But next thing we know, we've stepped into a strange forest with gold leaves and the gate shut. Then the scary Elf lady found us and

told us we were stuck, and that we wouldn't be easily able to get back unless this Sauron guy could be stopped."

"That sounds like you're leaving a lot out."

"Oh she is!" Glimmer said. "Like the part where she nearly got us shot! Lady Galadriel's head warden was grumbling about how annoying he found otherworldly travelers for like a week after that! Which considering that you're here, makes way too much sense now."

"About a month ago." C'yra said to herself. "Oh you've gotta be kidding me. You guys got sent to Lothlorien within days of us leaving it!" Her eyes narrowed.

"And you said Galadriel had tidings for me Gandalf! Okay, first off why didn't you tell me, and secondly, I don't know how this counts as a tiding! This is more like that Baggins family reunion party that Frodo told us about!"

"The very same event where a distant relative of his nearly burnt down Bag End?" Legolas asked.

"He didn't tell us about any others, did he?"

"My father has a few stories of his own concerning the more unsavory Baggins relatives." Gimli said. "The full number of them is concerningly large for a well regarded family."

"If I had told you then C'yra, you would have been incredibly distracted at a time that required your full focus." The Wizard said.

"He does have a point." Aragorn said. "The nature of them being here would have been quite the shock, and I've seen what happens when you are distracted. You may not have survived even the Warg attack."

"Hey, it's not my fault that that butterfly got in my way! And the nick you got from that Orc's arrow healed right up!" Bow had a contemplative look on his face.

“Excuse me, Aragorn right?” He asked. “How long have you known her?”

“Since C’yra fell into this world. Although it was our collective travels as of late that revealed her true self to us.”

“Wait.” Bow said, looking ahead to C’yra, his eyes lighting up. “You got to go on adventures with your own Best Friend Squad?!”

“It’s actually a Fellowship.” C’yra said. “And it depends on your definition of ‘adventure’.” She regarded Adora. “Is he seriously still calling you guys that?”

“It kinda stuck.” Adora said. “We at least talked him out of getting matching tattoos.” C’yra looked at Legolas and Gimli. No words were said but the message was clear, all three were in agreement that as far as bonding experiences went, they had evaded something fairly unpleasant indeed. The Magicat took a deep breath. Five years was a really long time after all.

“What are we Adora?” She asked, trying to process the last three hours.

“What do you mean?”

“We spent almost our entire lives together, I ripped us apart and went mad with angst and depression, tried to kill us all, you basically gave up on me and rightfully so, I fell through the universe, wandered the wild for four years, then went on a life changing road trip and ended up finding both myself and a bunch of people I can legitimately call my family. You’ve apparently been galavanting around the universe. And now you and the lovebirds are here, and we’ve got to find a way to rally this world against the Dark Lord that’s way too deep into accessorizing. What are we to each other now?” Adora understood then, and took a few moments to find her answer.

“Well, how about we start from the beginning, and try out being friends again?” She suggested, C’yra curiously cocked her head. “Hi, my name’s Adora of Etheria and Eternia, I love to spend time

with my friends, I've saved the universe a couple times, and I can turn into an eight foot tall magical warrior lady." C'yra couldn't help but let out a chuckle.

"Hi Adora." She responded. "It's nice to meet you. I'm C'yra Halfmoon. I've got eight older honorary brothers, a taste for travel, really enjoy carving the crap out of evil monsters, and yesterday I switched out half of Legolas' arrows with really long twigs when he wasn't looking." Legolas went ramrod straight, and grasped as many arrows as he could, taking them from his quiver to discover not a single twig among them.

"Gotcha!" C'yra said mirthfully, Gimli chuckled. Legolas simply gave a short glare, returning the arrows to his back. Aragorn rolled his eyes.

"Gimli, you do know that this means you are next?" The Ranger said.

"Oh I wouldn't say that Aragorn." C'yra said. "We just got three new people on the team, and we still have two more to pick up later. I still haven't gotten Merry back for making all those bird noises and trying to convince me that invisible sparrows were following us on the way to Moria."

"You actually fell for that?" Glimmer said. "I thought with that nose you could smell any creature a mile away."

"Well, you see the thing is I… Er, well I… Oh, screw you Sparkles!" It was very subtle, but Glimmer noticed that C'yra's voice lacked much of the venom in it that it would have had before the portal.

They rode for another hour in relative silence. Bow and Legolas had begun to discuss archery techniques, and as much as she loved him, Glimmer was beginning to go mad from the boredom.

"So…" She said, talking to Gandalf. "This Theoden and Eomer are the local rulers around here, Legolas is the prince of a place called Mirkwood, and Gimli's important amongst the Dwarves. I can follow that, but what's with the Ranger guy?" Gandalf raised an

eyebrow. While Glimmer had fielded the question, C'yra had urged Hasufel to match stride beside Shadowfax. She had something of a conspiritory look in her eyes. In the past few hours, the Wizard had concluded that the Queen of Brightmoon and the Magicat traded verbal spears in the manner they did more or less because they were almost practically the same person. Notably C'yra had managed to get something of a hold on her impulsiveness over the last two years. He decided there and then that the best way to get these two working with each other, which would surely create a force to be reckoned with, was to have them hash out their remaining aggression in a controlled manner until they were willing to speak to each other from the heart.

"I think I can take this one Gandalf." C'yra said.

"Very well." Gandalf answered, sometimes the best plans enact themselves of their own accord.

"I've known him the longest out of any of my brothers." C'yra said, recalling a little something Bilbo Baggins had shared with her before they left Rivendell. "And I've found that it's quite simple really." Then C'yra began to recite:

"All that is gold does not glitter,

Not all those who wander are lost;

The old that is strong does not wither,

Deep roots are not reached by the frost.

From the ashes a fire shall be woken,

A light from the shadows shall spring;

Renewed shall be the Blade that was Broken,

The crownless again shall be King."

“Okay.” Glimmer said. “But what the fuck is that supposed to mean?”

“Huh, speaking all cryptic like is actually pretty fun!” C’yra said. “I can see why you do it all the time, Gandalf.”

“Huh.” Bow said to himself, regarding the man he was sharing a horse with. “Oh, I get it!” Before Glimmer could question her boyfriend, Adora looked up and past the trees.

“Hey, everyone?” She asked, pointing to a tall spiked tower of obsidian glass in the near distance. “What is that thing?”

“That Adora, is the Tower of Orthanc.” Gandalf said. “Isengard is within our reach.”

“Alright.” C’yra said, determined. “Game faces on, we’ve got an evil Wizard to stick it to.”

The Return of the King Part II

The Voice of Saruman

As it would turn out, the front gate of the wall surrounding Isengard itself was locked shut. So they would have to settle for the giant hole that had been smashed into the wall just a little bit eastward instead. The horses strode down a small incline before entering the now flooded ring of Isengard's borders.

"There's no signs of an explosion here." Bow said. "What could have made a hole that big?"

"Aw jeez." C'yra groaned. "The whole place smells like hot garbage! That got left out in a swamp. In the summer."

"It looks like this Saruman guy got hit by something he wasn't expecting." Adora said. "Just for clarification, what's he like?"

"He is the former head of my order." Gandalf said. "Possessing of a great power and brilliant mind, now twisted and puppeterered by the Dark Lord."

"Yeah, and he tried to drop a mountain on us." C'yra said.

"Oh." Adora said. "That bad? Say no more."

"One of those types then." Glimmer thought aloud.

"Yikes." Said Bow.

"Intriguing." Legolas said. "Our new allies are the first of the countless that C'yra has told of the incident on Caradhras that did not react with shock upon learning of the event."

"Two years ago I found out my family was still around and that my uncle's an evil Wizard too." Adora said matter of factly. "He's

got a skull for a head.” C’yra looked back over her shoulder.

“Wait, like there’s no skin or muscle or anything?!”

“Yeah, all bone. The rest of him’s still normal. It’s a lot less scary once you hear him laugh though.”

“But how does he eat? Anything would just fall through the jaw.” A deeply haunted look befell the Best Friend Squad.

“We don’t know.” Bow said.

“We’ve all been trying to figure it out for years, and nobody can agree on the same idea.” Adora said.

“I still think he just mashes everything up into a paste and pours it down his throat.” Glimmer said.

“That sounds like the most reasonable option.” Gimli said, the topic bringing to him a macabre sense of fascination.

“It’s the most practical way I can think of. Adora thinks he ties a napkin around his jaw so he can chew without losing the food.”

“So Adora.” C’yra said, wanting to change the subject. “Who’s this bounty hunter?” Adora’s face went red.

“Oh, uh… Right. We met her when we crashed on a dead world on the edge of a galaxy after taking a wrong turn. She helped us fight off a bunch of monsters and stuck around for a while. Only went out a few times before we realized it wasn’t going to work out. She’s one of those married to the job types. Have you met anyone?” C’yra thought back.

“There may have been one farmer’s daughter that gave me a look, but I really wasn’t in the right place for that sort of thing. That and I was preoccupied with the village’s Goblin problem.

Typical hazard of living close enough to the mountains these days."

"Hm." Adora said with a thoughtful expression. "Hang on, what's that noise?"

"It sounds like someone talking." Bow said. "And laughing." Aragorn looked ahead and gave one of his rare smiles. C'yra looked forward as well.

"Well skin me alive and turn me into a winter coat!" The Magicat exclaimed. "What are they doing here?!" A few yards ahead, atop a particularly large piece of rubble, sat Meriadoc Brandybuck and Peregrin Took, partaking in a round of joyous merrymaking. Pippin was the first to see their aprocching friends, and upon sighting them, let out a whoop of laughter. Merry quickly got to his feet, extending his arms out and giving a tipsy bow in greeting.

"Welcome! My Lords, and Ladies. To Isengard!"

"You young rascals!!!" Bellowed Gimli. "It's a merry hunt you've led us on! And now we find you here feasting and- And smoking!"

"We are sitting." Pippin corrected. "On a field of victory, enjoying some well-earned comforts."

"Yeah, alright." Said an amused C'yra. "I'm calling bullshit on that, there's no way you two did all of THIS."

"Oh my gosh." Bow said, his eyes lighting up. "Are these Hobbits? They're! So! Adorable!"

"The salted pork is particularly good." Pippin remarked.

"Salted pork?" Gimli and Adora said at the same time, the Princess of Power perking up. C'yra's stomach growled.

"Hobbits." Gandalf huffed in exasperation.

“We haven’t had anything properly seasoned since Edoras.” C’yra groaned. “A woman cannot live on lembas alone.”

“Still tastier than ration bars though.” Adora said.

“Adora, you ate three whole loaves of that stuff in one sitting!” Glimmer accused. “I still don’t know why your stomach DIDN’T explode.”

“So what exactly is going on here anyway?” C’yra asked of the Hobbits.

“We’re under guard orders.” Merry explained. “From Treebeard, who has taken management of Isengard.”

“What’s a Treebeard?”

It was five minutes later, when Merry had joined Theoden and Pippin joined Gandalf and Glimmer upon their mounts, that C’yra got her answer as the party approached the tower.

“Okay.” She said. “There’s giant tree people everywhere. Now I’ve seen everything.” An even series of heavy footfalls sloshed through the water towards the party, and C’yra suspected that the large wooded being they belonged to must be this Treebeard person. Just a hunch.

“Ah!” The Ent drew out in a long breath. “Young Master Gandalf! I’m glad you’ve come. Wood and water, stock and stone I can master. But there is a Wizard to manage here, locked in his tower.”

“The tree man just called Gandalf young.” Bow said.

“I did not think that any of the shepherds of the forest had yet lived.” Aragorn said, regarding the Ents. “They have been here ere the beginning of this world.”

“We must be careful.” Gandalf said. “Even in defeat, Saruman is dangerous.”

“Then let’s just have his head and be done with it!” Suggested Gimli. C’yra had to admit that sounded pretty tempting.

“No. We need him alive.” Gandalf said. “We need him to talk.”

“So what’s the plan then?” C’yra asked. “Because if we end up having to break in there and drag him out by his robes, I’m all for it.” Gandalf merely looked up to the observation deck that comprised the tower’s roof.

“Saruman!” Gandalf called twice. “Saruman come forth!” There was a pause.

“Who is it, what do you wish?” Came a reedy voice.

“Go and fetch Saruman, since you have become his footman, Grima Wormtongue! And do not waste our time!” Soon another voice came from the heights of Orthanc, much clearer and commanding than that of Grima, even with the distance.

“You have fought many wars and slain many men, Theoden King. And made peace afterwards. Can we not take counsel together as we once did my old friend? Can we not have peace, you and I?” At the sound of his Voice, Glimmer tensed up behind Gandalf, a grave expression set on her face. Instinctively she ran her hand at the back of her neck.

“Peace?” Theoden asked, as if Saruman’s words had been a jest. “We shall have peace, when you answer for the burning of the Westfold! And the children that lie dead there! We shall have peace, when the lives of the soldiers, whose bodies were hewn even as they lay dead at the gates of the Hornburg are avenged! When you hang from a gibbet, for the sport of your own crows! We shall have peace.”

“Gibbets and crows?! Dotard!” Saruman hissed, his hair blowing in the breeze. “What do you want, Gandalf Greyhame? Let me

guess. The Key of Orthanc. Or perhaps the Keys of Bara-dur itself… Along with the Crowns of the Seven Kings, and the Rods of the Five Wizards!"

"Your treachery has already cost many lives." Gandalf said. "Thousands more are now at risk. But you could save them, Saruman! You were deep in the Enemy's counsel."

"So you have come here for information." Saruman said with a humorless smile. "I have some for you." From his robe, which appeared white as freshly fallen snow at first, but seemed to flash into all colors as it moved, Saruman produced a dark orb of a size enough to fit his palm and outstretched fingers.

"What is that?" Glimmer asked under her breath.

"Something festers in the heart of Arda." Saruman said. "Something that you have failed to see. But the Great Eye has seen it. Even now he presses his advantage. His attack will come soon. You're all going to die!"

"Like Hell we will!" Adora shouted. "I've spent my whole life fighting against Dark Lords! Each one more self assured and arrogant than the last! Sauron's no different!"

"Ah, so the fabled She-Ra has come to Middle-Earth. And what do you suppose a weapon of the First Ones can do against the former servant of Morgoth? Those that crafted the magic you carry within you sought to control and defy the very cosmos! And look where it brought them, doomed to fade away into obscurity as their ruin crumbled to dust across every land they sundered, their pitiful descendants living amongst the dirt and dust of a bygone age of hubris and failure, engaging in meaningless squabbles with those who would seek to harness a dulled power! One impudent brat cannot even dream to tap into the full potential of the failed experiment you found yourself a part of!" His gaze turned to Glimmer.

“And you, the young ruler of a shattered world, brought to a role you were unworthy of due to the actions of that halfbred mongrel you ride beside! Know this Queen Glimmer, no runestone’s power can even barely meet with the might that dwells within Mordor’s domain! Sauron has no need of an amplification to his power save the One Ring. And even so, he would have no need of it to overrun even the combined might of any Alliance that your decayed world could muster!” Adora and Glimmer gasped in shock, they had been here for barely a month, and yet somehow Saruman knew all of who and what they were.

“Alright! That’s it!” C’yra shouted, holding up the extended claws of her right hand. “Just give me the word Gandalf, I’ll scale this stupid tower right here and now and gut this asswipe myself! Ancestors know how long I’ve been waiting to get a claw in him!”

“Is that empty threat all you could conjure C’yra Halfmoon?!” Saruman sneered. “You may have changed your name, but that does not change what you are! An orphaned cur cast to the wayside by all who viewed you, thrust into this tale by mere chance where you stumbled into the possession of another failed people’s dead blade! To think that the great people of Thundera could have faded into such obscurity that they are all but forgotten and their most sacred artifact is in the hands of one such as you, crass and combative! Unworthy of even the most minor legacy! There is nothing that you could do to me that would have any lasting mark!”

“Oh yeah?! Why don’t you come down here and I’ll show you!”

“I’ve heard enough!” Gimli said, tapping Legolas. “Shoot him. Stick an arrow in his gob!” Legolas made to ready his bow.

“No!” Gandalf stopped him. “Come down Saruman, and your life will be spared!”

“Promise subject to debate for however long it takes for him to reach the last stairs.” C’yra growled under her breath.

“Save your pity and your mercy!” Saruman shouted, holding his staff aloft. “I have no use for it!” As he finished, he sent a massive blast of flame from his staff, which shot down to engulf Gandalf, Pippin, Glimmer, and Shadowfax! Glimmer made to summon her own staff, but was too late, and the flame reached them! Every horse near the blast was startled, but their riders swiftly regained control, all too shocked to say anything. The flames soon dissipated though, to reveal all of its targets were completely unharmed.

“Saruman!” Gandalf declared. “Your staff is broken!” Saruman’s face turned to shock as a brilliant golden energy lanced through his staff, blowing it up in his hand. Nervously, Grima Wormtongue stepped forward, regarding the scene. Theoden saw this and called out.

“Grima! You need not follow him. You were not always as you are now! You were once a Man of Rohan! Come down.”

“A Man… Of Rohan?” Saruman mocked, turning to Grima. “What is the House of Rohan, but a thatched barn where brigands drink in the reek?! And their brats roll on the floor with the dogs?! Victory does not belong to you Theoden Horse-master! You are all lesser children of greater sires!”

“Grima.” Theoden said again. “Come down. Be free of him.”

“Free?! He will never be free!” Grima found his voice.

“No.” He said simply.

“Get. Down. Cur!” Saruman exclaimed, swatting the man across the face and to the floor! Despite everything, C’yra and Adora winced. More now than ever did the Wizard remind them of Shadow Weaver.

“Saruman!” Gandalf said. “You were deep in the enemy’s council! Tell us what you know!”

“You withdraw your guard!” Saruman demanded. “And I will tell you where your Doom will be decided! I will not be held prisoner here!” Oddly enough, he was right about that. But not for the reasons he thought as Grima shot to his feet, brandishing a dagger that he thrust into the Wizard’s back! Saruman let out a gasp, and Legolas instinctively fired an arrow, sinking it into Grima’s side! The man fell first, hitting the flat top of the tower. As for Saruman, who had been standing close to the edge, he fell forward, tumbling as he rocketed toward the ground! Then he met his fate, as he was impaled back first on one of the spokes of his own industrial wheels! Merry and Bow winced as they witnessed the impact and everyone else processed what they had seen.

“How about that?” C’yra said. “We stuck it to him after all.”

“That is definitely gonna keep me up tonight.” Bow replied.

“Send word to all our allies,” Gandalf said. “And to every corner of Middle-Earth that still stands free. The Enemy moves against us. We need to know where he will strike!”

“Likely wherever he’s closest to, I’d imagine.” C’yra remarked as a metallic groan came from the wheel as it moved, dragging Saruman’s body into the mire. The same orb that he had held slipped from his sleeve and into the water, where Pippin jumped down to retrieve it, curious.

“Pippin!” Aragorn called out.

“The filth of Saruman.” Treebeard declared. “Is washing away. Trees will come back to live here. Young trees. Wild trees.” Pippin produced the orb, and the Ent saw what it was.

“Bless my bark!”

“My thoughts exactly!” Glimmer interjected. “What’s the deal with that thing?”

“Peregrin Took!” Gandalf said. “I’ll take that my lad.” Pippin hesitated, but handed Gandalf the orb before being picked up himself by Aragorn and Bow. Gandalf wrapped the orb into his robe. Their business concluded, the group turned to ride back to Edoras.

They at least reached the plains by nightfall, and found a suitable place to camp. Glimmer stirred fitfully in her sleep, muttering unknown words to an unknown person. Soon Bow, who lay next to her, instinctively turned over in his own sleep to embrace her. And she calmed down, if just a little. C’yra watched this from where she stood by the fire, then looked to the stars, her cloak flowing in the wind.

“Thundera?” She asked herself. “I wonder if it’s still out there.” Adora stood from her bedroll. C’yra turned to her.

“Couldn’t sleep either?” The Magicat asked.

“Saruman reminded me too much of too many things.” Adora said as she walked to meet C’yra. “I haven’t met anyone that despicable in a while.”

“Hard to believe he used to be one of the good guys.” C’yra said, then looked to Glimmer and Bow. “He really shook Sparkles back there.”

“Glimmer got kidnapped soon after the portal. By Horde Prime. She was with him for almost a month until we were able to fly out to his flagship and get her. He… It’s not my story to tell what he did to her.” Adora looked skyward as well.

“Gandalf told me once that Saruman’s real power was in his Voice. Everything he said, he was only doing that to drive us into despair and doubt. I’ve seen what you can do as She-Ra. You could probably walk right up to Sauron and give him a piece of your mind if you wanted to right now.”

“You might be right. But I won’t. Everyone else has as much a right to do something against this guy as we do.”

“And when it’s over, we’ll find you guys a way back.” C’yra said.

“Just us huh?” Adora asked, C’yra gave a huff and a small smile.

“A lot’s changed, Adora.” She said. “This place is my home now. Hell, after a few leagues on Hasufel I can’t even imagine taking a skiff somewhere anymore. I can still come and visit of course, there’s a lot of people I think I need to talk to. Starting with Shadow Weaver.”

“Shadow Weaver’s dead Cat- C’yra. She died not long before we took down Prime.” C’yra’s breath stopped.

“How?”

“She… Sacrificed herself. So I could do what I had to.”

“Hmph. A shame. It’s funny really, a year ago that news would’ve made my day.”

“A lot has changed.” Adora said. They stood in silence for a while.

“So, we’re going to a place called Edoras?” Adora asked. "What's it like?"

“Oh, it’s pretty much your bog-standard low tech village on a hill in the middle of nowhere. Great view though. And knowing what I’ve learned about the people of Rohan, snatching a victory like we just did means only one thing.”

The Return of the King Part III

Return to the Golden Hall

The Golden Hall of Meduseld was packed tight with all the warriors it could fit who had taken part in the Battle of Helm's Deep, included among them were the two Hobbits and the three mysterious new warriors who had come with Theoden King from his excursion to Isengard. They had only been back a couple days and rumors of the trio abounded. Interestingly enough, the most popular rumor was also the most accurate. All three of the newcomers had spent most of their time either in the company of C'yra Halfmoon or her friends, therefore the suspicion was that they were old acquaintances of theirs. Those that would learn the truth knew of course, that it was much more complicated than that.

Eowyn was practically gliding across the floor as she walked to her uncle with an ornate filled cup, which the King then took and raised.

"Hail the victorious dead!" He declared.

"Hail!" Sounded everyone present, raising their own flagons before drinking.

Adora moved the ale around in her mouth before swallowing as the clamor of a proper celebration started.

"Huh." She said. "This stuff's not that bad."

"I kind of prefer the drinks at the Prancing Pony myself." C'yra said. "But this sure beats the Hell out of Elvish wine." Off in a nearby corner, Eomer manned a barrel as Legolas, Gimli, Glimmer, and Bow sat at the table.

“Hon,” Bow said. “I’m not so sure this is a good idea.”

“Relax Bow.” Glimmer said as Eomer started to pass filled flagons to her, Legolas, and Gimli.

“No pauses, no spills…” Eomer explained.

“And no regurgitations!” Gimli proclaimed.

“So it is a drinking game.” Legolas said. “What is the object?”

“Last one standing wins!” Gimli said with a large smile, taking his first drink.

“Oh-ho!” Glimmer exclaimed. “It’s on now, Beard Boy!” And with that she threw back her first. “Damn! That’s good shit!” Bow could only look on nervously.

C’yra and Adora were a couple ales in themselves before they milled over to a table where several of the Rohirrim were engaging in a hearty arm wrestling contest. Once the current match had ended, Adora gave C’yra a cheeky smile and sat down herself to challenge the reigning champion.

“Oh, so the Wildcat’s pretty friend thinks she’s got some strength now?” The soldier taunted, his surrounding friends let out a chorus of laughter. C’yra only chuckled herself and finished her current ale.

“I’d be careful, she was taking down fellow cadets of ours twice her size by the time she was thirteen! And one of ‘em’s a giant lizard guy!” Adora only smirked and the spectators grew silent as the match commenced, having gotten thoroughly invested by the Magicat’s words.

Over at the other contest well underway, Legolas drained his third flagon uneasily, not used to the taste. Gimli had polished off his thirteenth, and Glimmer was chugging down her sixth. Bow sat there still, idly sipping on the very same ale he had toasted with earlier.

“Ah!” Gimli interjected. “It’s the Dwarves that go swimming, with little hairy women! Hehehe!” Glimmer slammed down her flagon, and grabbed her next.

“What about the average-ish furry ones tho?!” She slurred, her tone of voice an odd mix of anger and admiration. “Coming back afshter five yearsh of bein’ dead and Catra- Ah shit! C’yra or whatverrr the fucksh she’s callin’ hershelf now…” She waved the flagon over in the direction of C’yra, who was laughing uproariously at what was now Adora’s fourth straight arm wrestling victory. “And still way more attractive than she’s got any right to be!!! I mean fuck! Look at her, somehow tha scar only made her sexshier! I swear, if she triesh to take me ‘way from my Bowie-Bow! Theyrll be Hell to pay!” With that, she threw back the drink.

‘I’m beginning to think it was a mistake including her in on this.’ Eomer thought, though from the look on Master Bow’s face, trying to get Glimmer to tap out would be more than likely to prove excruciatingly painful… For Eomer.

At the center of the hall, Merry and Pippin had gotten up on the main table in hopes of contributing to the high spirits of those assembled, and broke out into a song and dance that C’yra recognized. Her thoughts drifted back almost a year ago to when the Fellowship first set out from Rivendell. It was in those first weeks that the two Hobbits had begun to devise the song they sang in full now:

“Oh you can search far and wide,

You can drink the whole town dry!

But you’ll never find a beer so brown,

(But you’ll never find a beer so brown),

But you’ll never find a beer so brown,

As the one we drink in our Hometown!

You can keep your fancy ales,

You can drink ‘em by the flagon!

But the only brew for the brave and true…

COMES FROM THE GREEN DRAGON!!!”

Having ended the song, the two were met with resounding cheers and clashed their mugs together, taking deep drafts. C’yra looked over to Adora, fresh off defeating her latest opponent before the others had given up. As they heard the faint shout of Merry proclaiming that he’d won an impromptu drinking race, the two former Horde cadets showed a knowing look. They quickly chugged another ale each, acquired replacements, and made for the grand table. Theoden spied them as they went, and he stroked his chin with interest.

Meanwhile over at the inaugural Fellowship-Best Friends Squad Enduro Kegger, Gimli added yet another flagon to his impressive pile and let out a giant belch.

“I feel something!” Legolas said, almost frightened. “A slight tingling in my fingers! I think it’s effecting me.” Eomer just raised his eyebrows. Glimmer, now having downed sixteen ales of her own, retrieved her next drink. She looked to the grand table as Adora and C’yra climbed atop it, Merry and Pippin looking quite intrigued themselves.

“HELL FUCKING YEEEEAAAAAAHHH!!!” Glimmer hollered over the din of the hall, thrusting the flagon toward the ceiling. “YOOOU GET IT GIIIIIRRRRLS! WHOOOOOOO!!!!!!!” And then with a soft, drawn out groan, the Queen of Brightmoon swayed forward and down, dropping the flagon with a clatter and teleporting out of the hall as she passed out, her customary sparkling cloud in her wake.

“Oh Glim.” Bow sighed, taking his second ale of the night in his hands. “Not again…” Legolas made no comment on the event, as he had spied his Magicat sister-in-arms and the Princess of Power

begin to rhythmically stomp on the table. He put two and two together.

“Valar protect us.” The Elf said. “I’m too late.”

There was no other option but to endure as C’yra and Adora broke out into a tipsy, but nonetheless incredibly passionate duet of “The Force Captain’s Promotion”. This time with accompanying gestures for the entirety of the performance. The people of Rohan, to whatever end, seemed to be quite taken by the song. Merry and Pippin were all too happy to oblige in directing the crowd to clap and stomp along. Gimli even waved about his own raised flagon to the tune. Gandalf and Aragorn did their best to ignore it, as they were in the middle of an important discussion. Theoden seemed to be internally debating on whether to throw Adora and C’yra outside once they were done. Bow looked completely unimpressed, and merely sipped his drink though the duration.

“What did I say?!” Gimli drunkenly blurted once the song was over. “He can’t hold his liquor!” The Dwarf seemed to freeze, and then leant back, toppling over to the ground as Legolas regarded the drink in his hand, calculating the pros and cons of trying to use the liquid within to forget the last four minutes.

“Game over.” Bow said matter of factly, taking another sip of his drink.

The Return of the King Part IV

The Palantir

Hours later, C'yra laid out on the floor of the room given to the Fellowship and their new companions, Gimli on one side of her, Adora on the other. It was she and Adora who had managed to haul the unconscious Dwarf to his bed for the night, and now he and Adora seemed to be trying to figure out who between them snored the loudest. Aragorn and Legolas hadn't come back inside from their talk yet. C'yra, for her part, simply took the time to enjoy the moment, despite the noise. It would probably be a long time before she was in the same area as a majority of her family and newfound friends like this again.

Well, she and Glimmer weren't exactly what you'd call friends just yet. More like acquaintances really, but C'yra figured that she was willing to give it a try once they'd figured out where the Queen of Brightmoon had poofed off to. Rolling over, she turned to the sprawled out form of Adora.

C'yra still wasn't sure how to process some of the myriad feelings that flowed through her when she beheld the blonde these days. A part of her was still in disbelief that Etheria had endured after all and that her oldest friend turned enemy turned whatever middle point between friendship and whatever the Hell she was feeling was lying next to her right here and now. She was just glad that they had been able to start over again so effectively as they had these past couple weeks. The fact that the other two were starting to get on like a fire with the rest of the Fellowship, particularly Legolas and Gimli, was just as appreciated and frankly odd.

'Well.' C'yra supposed to herself. 'We are all collectively in the unenviable position of fighting back against the collected evil bastards of the universe. And knowing a few of us, we probably will always be in one form or another. I'm only hoping that Sauron's gonna be the worst of it. And that we can all make it out

of what he's got in store.' There was a soft rustling behind her, perceptible even under the combined snoring. She turned over again to be met with the sight of Pippin sneaking up the the sleeping Gandalf.

'Has Gandalf always done that with his eyes open?' C'yra thought in a tired haze before shooting to sit straight up. 'Wait, why the shit is Pippin going after that weird orb thing?!' Merry had also gotten up, and was currently attempting to intercept his cousin.

"Pippin!" Merry whispered. "What are you doing?!"

"I just want to look at it. One time!" The younger Hobbit responded, beginning to carefully extract the orb and replace it with a water pitcher. He unfurled the small sack that the stone was held in, and grabbed onto it with both hands. Mere seconds afterward, the entire orb lit up a blazing orange lanced with yellow streams of plasma! In the center, a small slit remained dark, staring up at the Hobbit. C'yra could clearly see what, or rather who, that was.

As Merry called for help, C'yra shot out of bed in attempt to grab the orb from the thrashing Pippin's hands! It took a few practice grabs to properly one line up, but once she did the orb shot out a brief burst of energy, shocking C'yra!

"Ow! Dammit!" C'yra gave a quick glance to the orb, then to Pippin, after which she set her face in determination and thrust her arms forward, yanking the orb from Pippin's grasp. Almost immediately, she understood. The energy lanced out from the orb, this time with much more aggression that it initially had, covering her entire body in an unending stream of excruciating malice setting a fire in her veins. C'yra whipped her head into the air, and let out the loudest pained yowl she had in her life! Instantly, Adora awoke and took in the sight!

"C'yra!" She exclaimed, running to her friend to try to stop her from convulsing in the exact moment that Legolas and Aragorn burst into the room! Not wasting any time, the Ranger came to

Adora's aid, seizing the orb and briefly falling back with a groan before managing to roll it across the floor where it was then covered up with a cloth by the recently awake Gandalf! As the Wizard made to scold Pippin, C'yra found herself coming to in Adora's arms.

"C'yra, are you okay?!" Adora cried.

"Yeah," C'yra said. "I'm fine… I… I…" She looked up at Adora.

"You what?"

"I saw him Adora. What he looked like. Before he lost the Ring. He didn't look happy that I took Pippin out of whatever was happening to us. He looked into my mind, tried to do what Shadow Weaver used to do to me! He wasn't good at it, but he definitely means business." Aragorn had recovered and, after seeing that Gandalf was attending to Pippin, turned to C'yra with Legolas.

"C'yra." He said. "Do you need anything?"

"No, at worst he only made it tickle a little. Old Weaver practically had it down to an art. I'll be fine."

"We've got to do something about him." Adora said, her tone stone clad. "And fast."

"There was no lie in Pippin's eyes." Gandalf said to the assembled Aragorn, Legolas, Gimli, Theoden, and Adora in the grand hall that morning. "A fool, but an honest fool he remains." Adora set her face. It was bad enough that Sauron would brutally interrogate Pippin, but for whatever reason she felt angriest at what the Dark Lord had done to C'yra. Though she had been suspecting, and fearing, for quite a while that it would take significantly more than the power of She-Ra to take on Sauron, she found herself not really caring at the moment. She'd rip down the Black Gates herself barehanded if she had to.

“Right.” Adora said. “I assume you’re going to go to Gondor then?” King Theoden had made it more than clear his opinion on the matter. For what it was worth, C’yra had said that she’d try to find a way to convince him over to their side.

“Yes.” Gandalf said. “And I will not be going alone. Unfortunately the remaining parties are still not yet present.”

“Indeed.” Legolas said. “I have not seen either C’yra or Bow since breakfast. And Queen Glimmer has apparently gone missing.” As if their ears were burning, the doors of Meduseld burst open, and C’yra and Bow entered. A semi conscious body hung from their shoulders as they dragged them in.

“Sorry we’re late.” Bow apologized.

“Look who we found in a chicken coop!” C’yra teased their groaning passenger.

“Ugh. I can stand.” Growled the still very much hungover Glimmer. “You can let me go now.” Bow and C’yra did so, and the Queen of Brightmoon staggered to sit by Adora along with the other two.

“So.” C’yra said to Glimmer as they sat. “You think the scar makes me look hotter huh?”

“What?” Glimmer said, holding her head. “How did you… Oh no. Bow, what else did I miss?”

“Well…” Bow began, counting on his fingers. “You expressed concern that C’yra would try to seduce you for some reason, passed out, Adora and C’yra became the lives of the party, and a couple hours later Pippin’s curiosity got the better of him and he touched that palantir thing. That’s what it is right?” Gandalf nodded. “So now Sauron thinks Pippin has his Ring, and there’s a very likely chance he’s gonna attack Gondor soon.” Glimmer blinked.

“Gotcha.” She said. “Adora, remind me to never get in a drinking contest with an Elf and a Dwarf ever again.”

“Aw,” C’yra said. “But who would cheer me and Adora on then Sparkles?”

“Quiet you.”

“What’s the plan then Gandalf?” Adora said. “How many of us is this going to need?”

“This is not something that will require a great force Adora.” C’yra said. “I’d suggest something smaller, more diplomatic in nature.”

“And you would be correct.” Gandalf said. “Lord Denethor, the current steward of Gondor has become, difficult to say the least.”

“In that case, Bow and I can come.” Glitter said. “Turns out healing magic across a universe is great practice for diplomacy. If this steward is being difficult like you say, I could try and talk him into accepting our help.”

“Very well.” Gandalf said. “I was going to ask that you come when it was necessary that I go, but your volunteering is much appreciated.”

“It’s what we do.” Bow said. “But are you sure you’re ready to go Glimmer? You had a really rough night.”

“Oh please.” Glimmer said, getting up. “I’ve had worse nights than that, what’s riding cross country with a hangover going to do to me?”

Minas Tirith

“Agh, jeez!” Glimmer exclaimed, her head pounding as she and Bow’s horse did all it could to keep pace with Shadowfax. “How much further is this White City anyway?!”

“At the rate we’re going?” Bow asked. “Another four days and night’s ride without rest if the distance on the map checks out.” Glimmer merely gave out a prolonged groan of pain and embarrassment.

“I really hope that Adora and C’yra don’t find out about this…”

Eventually, it came into view, a great structure of carved white stone that shone in the midday sun, built into the very roots of the mountain range it stood in front of. The city of Minas Tirith. Bow and Glimmer let out a collective gasp of wonder. Though nearly completely different in terms of aesthetics, the current capital of Gondor bore a striking familiarity to Brightmoon. Off to the southeast, the shattered remnants of another city sat by the River Anduin, and beyond the black mountains that held the land of Mordor, a great dark cloud issuing leagues from its center and over the river.

“They’re practically on each other’s doorsteps!” Glimmer exclaimed as they let up to survey the rest of their path.

“Yes.” Gandalf responded. “The Shadow will come here soon enough. We must act quickly!”

The journey up the seven tiers of the city passed in a blur, and before long, all four dismounted and began to cross into the main courtyard that sat at the city’s top. In the center, a great tree with pale white bark was planted, its branches barren. Four guards were stationed around it.

“Gandalf!” Pippin exclaimed. “That’s it! That’s the tree!”

“Yes. The White Tree of Gondor.” Gandalf said.

“Why is a guard stationed here?” Bow asked.

“Because they still hold on to the hope that the rightful King will one day sit upon Gondor’s throne. And that the White Tree will bloom again. Alas, it has remained dormant for many a long age.” The group walked onward to Minas Tirith’s grand hall, which sat behind a door at the back end of the courtyard. Gandalf stopped, then turned to Pippin.

“Lord Denethor is the father of Boromir. Should he be made aware of his son’s death, our mission here may be made all the more difficult, so I suggest you do not speak of him, or of Aragon for that matter.” Pippin nodded, and Gandalf faced forward, thinking a bit more.

“In fact, it is probably best that you do not speak at all Peregrin Took.” Pippin looked very much embarrassed at this.

“It’s alright Pippin.” Glimmer said softly. “Adora puts her foot in her mouth all the time as well.”

As soon as the great doors were opened and the party of four entered the long marbled hall, Glimmer could practically feel the enormous melancholic shift in the air. There, at the far end of the hall, sitting on a black marble throne much smaller than the throne of the King, but no less ornate, was an old man hunched over the small object he was clutching. Glimmer raised an eyebrow, exchanging a curious glance with Bow.

“Hail Denethor, son of Ecthelion.” Gandalf greeted. “I come with counsel and tidings in this dark hour.”

“Then perhaps…” Denethor said, his voice uneven and grave with grief. “You can tell me why my son is dead.” Glimmer and Bow tensed briefly, the former clutching her staff tighter. So much for avoiding that topic.

“How could one so mighty fall to an enemy?” After the steward finished speaking, Pippin came forward unprompted, and too fast for anyone to intervene.

“Boromir was not felled by one enemy, but by many.” Pippin said. “He gave his life for me and my kinsman.” The Hobbit then kneeled.

“And for that, I offer myself into your service.” Bow brought his palm to his face as Glimmer winced. This meeting had barely even begun and it was already off the rails.

“Get up!” Gandalf hissed, smacking the Hobbit with his staff. Glimmer came forward.

“And who are you?” Denethor asked. “You bring with you only your guard and no evidence of who you are or whom you serve.”

“My Lord, I am Queen Glimmer, of the Kingdom of Brightmoon. My partner Bow and I have come from a world beyond, along with a powerful ally. We have ridden here with Gandalf the White to warn you. The Dark Lord has set his sights on your land. I can offer you both the aid of our own forces, and vouch for you in the recruitment of King Theoden of Rohan to your aid.”

“Indeed.” Gandalf said. “You must act now, light the beacons to send official word to Rohan. You do not have to fight off Sauron alone any longer.”

Suffice to say, the Steward of Gondor was in even less of a mood to treat with the party as he initially looked. Glimmer sent a blast of magic from her hand to the door in lieu of opening it normally, and Gandalf harshly bade Pippin to follow him out onto the courtyard’s observation deck as Bow followed the Queen back down to the lower levels.

“Can you believe the fucking nerve of that guy?!” Glimmer fumed. “‘Go back to your world, and be burdened by your own problems’?! I can get him grieving the loss of his son for a few months, but an army of Orcs could be laying siege to this place any day now! And it’s not like we could go home right now even if we wanted to! Is he seriously TRYING to get his people killed?!”

“I’m just really glad that Aragorn didn’t come with us after all.” Bow said. “It’s amazing that he didn’t kick us out of the city as-is.”

“AND speaking of that, how the Hell did he even know about Aragorn in the first place?! I thought he was trying to keep himself a secret for as long as possible! ‘Do you think the eyes of the White Tower are blind’ my ass!” Bow glanced at a banner as they passed, taking note of the items displayed above the tree on the heraldry. It was then that he was reminded of what Gandalf had told them of Gondor at their first meeting.

“‘Seven stars and seven stones’…” He said to himself. “Glim, I think I know how Denethor knew all that!”

“What?”

“He’s gotta have a palantir, like the one we got from Saruman! And Sauron has one too, that’s how he was able to command him. That’s three of seven stones like in that song if my hunch is right!” Glimmer stopped, the realization dawning on her.

“And if Denethor has one…”

“Then who’s he been talking to?”

“We’ve got to find Gandalf.” The two then broke into a jog, going back up to search for the Wizard. It took them a little longer than they had anticipated, and an hour later they found Gandalf, tucked away in a corner as he watched a small tower that loomed overhead.

“Oh, there you are!” Glimmer exclaimed, the Wizard turning to her. “Wait, why are you here?” Gandalf simply turned back to where he had been looking, giving a small gesture with his staff. Glimmer and Bow followed, watching as Pippin lit a large cube-shaped structure of wood in the main part of the tower before climbing back down.

“Oh.” Glimmer said. “I guess that solves that problem. Gandalf, Bow and I might’ve learned something really big.”

“Then we will have to wait. Denethor may yet be watching.”

“The Beacon!” Cried a nearby guard. “The Beacon of Amon Din is lit!”

“Hope.” Gandalf said. “Is kindled.”

It was a few more days of preparing before Glimmer and Bow could find time to safely tell Gandalf of what they had learned.

“A grave tiding indeed.” Gandalf said. “Unfortunately, we are not in a favorable position to do anything on this matter. Lord Denethor’s patience with us can only be tried so much.”

“Well, at least we have the things we can control taken care of.” Bow said, going over the meager leftover armor he was able to scrounge for him and Glimmer over the past few days. All he could find for himself were some half-decent armguards and a breastplate for himself, and a black leather tunic for Glimmer. He looked out to the night sky, and Mordor in the distance.

“The clouds are closer now.” Pippin said.

“Sauron’s Orcs despise the light of the sun.” Gandalf said. “So he sends forth a cloud of his own making ahead of his host. It is very well halfway over the field by now. We should expect an arrival sooner rather than later.”

“Well, at least once the forces arrive from Rohan we won’t be as hopelessly outnumbered and outfought.” Glimmer said. “All that I’ve learned about Orcs so far is that they’re much more dangerous in numbers than anything else.”

“Sauron’s influence spreads much further than Orcs Glimmer.” Gandalf explained. “There will be Men as well, from far off lands that have long since dissolved ties with any of the lands here. In the absence, Sauron has found ways to garner their favor, and turn them against their own. And the Dark Lord still has yet to

unleash his most deadly servant, one they say no living man can kill. The Lord of the Nazgûl, the Witch King of Angmar. You have met him once, Pippin." Pippin looked contemplative, recalling events a year past.

"He stabbed Frodo at Weathertop." Glimmer's jaw set. She, Bow, and Adora had been told of the Nine.

"We'll have to put that no-kill rumor to the test then." Glimmer said. "This world's magic may be similar to ours, but I doubt this Witch King's ever faced anything like me before. And besides, you're the White Wizard. That's gotta count for something."

"We can only hope that you are right then."

"If there's any left of it that is." Pippin said gravely.

"There is always hope." Gandalf said. "Even if it is just a fool's hope in the end." The four remained silent for a bit, taking in the sights from their room's balcony. Even with the dark tidings on the literal horizon, it was all still oddly beautiful. Bow was about to comment on it, but was interrupted by a distant rumble followed by a bright flash as a beam of sickly green light issued forth into the sky from somewhere in the mountains! The four beheld the sight, all knowing on some level just what it's emerald glow heralded.

"The board is set." Gandalf said. "And the pieces are moving."

"Adora and the others had better get here quick." Glimmer said under her breath.

The Return of the King Part V

The Passing of the Grey Company

C'yra paced back and forth through Meduseld's great hall. It had been around a week and a half since Gandalf, Pippin, Glimmer, and Bow set out for Gondor, and she was beginning to get impatient. C'yra casually noted that she hadn't felt this stir crazy in a very long time now, what with the majority of her life this past year spent on the road. The last time the Fellowship had stopped for a long while was Lothlorien. It had been like this ever since her first year in Middle-Earth, she never liked to stay for too long in one place.

"C'yra, I know you're getting antsy," Adora said from her seat at the main table. "But wearing a trench into the floor isn't going to help."

"I know." C'yra groaned, pinching her brow. "It's just that I thought we would have gotten some word by now." She gestured to further up the hall, were Theoden was convening with representatives from across the Riddermark. "And his silence on the matter just adds to the frustration. I thought I warned Gandalf not to be too pushy with him."

"Do you and Gandalf really argue as much as you're implying?" C'yra took a breath and chuckled, a fond smile on her face.

"Yes and no. When things weren't as serious, I did get a kick out of pushing his buttons, and he did seem at least a little happy to have someone to match wits with on the regular. Ever since he came back though, he's been strictly business."

"I can see that. With the way he talks sometimes, it starts making you wonder why Sauron didn't just get it over with and try to take us all out weeks ago." Adora said, then smirked. "I guess you two do still have a lot in common after all." C'yra's eyes practically shot wider at that, and she began to stammer indignantly. From the

looks of it, it would have truly been an impressive rant that she was about to go on, had it not been for Aragorn slamming his way through the doors of the Great Hall and shouting at the top of his lungs.

“The Beacons of Minas Tirith! The Beacons are lit!” He stopped. “Gondor calls for aid!” Having gotten the attention of everyone in the hall, all eyes silently turned to King Theoden.

“And Rohan will answer!” Theoden declared after a pause. “Muster the Rohirrim!”

“Finally!” C’yra exclaimed as she made to exit the hall. “It’s about damn time we got moving! Aragorn, you get Legolas and Gimli, Adora and I will get our horses ready.”

“Uh, C’yra? Are you sure that’s a good idea?” Adora said as she got up to follow, voicing her concern. “Brego will only listen to Aragorn!”

“Oh don’t be such a downer Adora.” C’yra said as they walked outside and started down the steps. “I’m pretty sure all we’ve got to do is give him a carrot and he’ll love us forever.”

“That is a gross oversimplification of how horses work C’yra!”

It was a five days journey to where Theoden intended to meet with any others across the plains of Rohan who would answer the call, where they found camp atop and along a cliff sitting within the face of the mountains. Not long after their arrival, many of the horses grew uneasy. And soon after that, some of the men had as well. Not a day passed where C’yra found that her fur was not standing on end. A lone rider came to the camp one night, disappearing into Theoden’s tent. Adora and C’yra witnessed this, then tried to settle near one of the fires.

“The day before we set out again can’t come any sooner.” C’yra said. “We’ve been here for almost two weeks and I still feel like

something's been watching us!" Adora nodded, while she hadn't felt anything, she'd seen enough from those that had to not disregard their unease.

"Whatever it is," She said. "At least it's kept to itself and not done anything."

"That just makes me more nervous." C'yra responded. "Why would something just sit there and be happy to merely watch us without doing anything?" Adora thought for a bit.

"Well, I did hear a rumor going around that the mountain we're on is haunted." C'yra sat ramrod straight, and her pupils shrank.

"Haunted?!" She said in a small voice.

"But it's just a rumor after all." Adora said dismissively. "I've been halfway across the Galaxy and back, and never once have I seen a real ghost. It's probably a local superstition caused by some phenomenon that's way beyond this world's current means to explain." C'yra glared at her.

"You wouldn't be saying that if you saw the fire demon."

"You're not scared are you?" Adora teased, raising an eyebrow.

"What?!" C'yra exclaimed in offense. "Me? Scared?! No way! I'm just starting to get impatient again."

"Right." Adora said, her tone still teasing. "Hey, where's Aragorn going off to?" C'yra turned her head, sure enough Aragorn was on the move, and with great urgency as well.

"He's definitely up to something." C'yra said. "Come on, let's go get Legolas and Gimli before he ends up doing something stupid."

Aragorn had finished strapping up Brego's saddle bags when the four approached him.

“Thought you could sneak off without us noticing Strider?” C’yra said. Aragorn gave them a once over before pulling a strap for a final time.

“I do not ask you to follow.”

“Have you learned nothing of the stubbornness of Dwarves?” Legolas asked mirthfully.

“And C’yra’s got enough stubbornness for the rest of us!” Adora joked.

“We’re goin’ with you laddie.” Gimli said. Aragorn couldn’t help but smile, and Adora got a good look at the new addition to his equipment. An ornate long sword that looked quite old, but nonetheless strong. At this, she gave an impressed whistle.

“Is that what I think it is?” C’yra asked upon beholding the blade. Aragorn gave her a look, as no words were needed. “Okay, that was a rhetorical question. Just hang tight while we get ready, King of Gon-dork.”

“Did you just come up with that one?” Aragorn asked.

“No,” C’yra said with a shit eating grin. “I’ve been holding onto that for months.”

A days ride into the canyon that opened behind the great camp, and C’yra’s initial unease somehow grew. The air within the maze of pale stone was somehow unbelievably thick, and the sun only managed to shine down into it with a white, sickly light.

“So, I know this sounds bad considering we’ve been on the road for a while,” Adora said. “But where exactly are we going?”

“The men of Rohan will be outnumbered upon reaching Gondor.” Aragorn explained. “Through here is our only chance at evening the odds.”

“Would it also have anything to do with that banner you’ve got on you?” C’yra asked.

“That is part of it, yes.”

“What kind of an army would linger in such a place?” Gimli asked, looking around.

“One that is cursed.” Legolas stated. “During the Last Alliance of the Second Age, Isildur came to the Men of the Mountain, and they pledged their allegiance to come to his aid, to fight. But when the time to fulfill their oaths came, and when Gondor’s need was dire, they cowered. And so Isildur cursed them. They are now bound to this place, never to rest until they fulfill their pledge and regain their honor.” Then, Legolas began to recite:

“Who shall call them the grey twilight, the forgotten people?

The heir of him to the oath they swore.

From the North he shall come, need shall drive him.

He shall pass the door to the Paths of the Dead.” C’yra’s eyes widened as she shot up in her saddle.

“The Dead?!” She exclaimed. “I thought you said they were bound to the mountain!”

“It’s been at least two thousand years, hasn’t it?” Adora posited. “Only the Elves and Wizards live that long here. Maybe they’re like a bunch of living mummies?”

“Ugh,” C’yra shuddered. “Don’t get my hopes up.” The party turned a corner and dismounted, approaching a carved rectangular opening in the rock. Above the door were etched a series of symbols.

“The way is shut.” Legolas read. “It was made by those who are dead. And the dead keep it.” C’yra looked at the carvings in disbelief.

“It said all of that?!”

“Oh that’s nothing.” Adora said. “We once met with a race of people who could fit an entire book on a napkin with their writing.”

“Not helping Adora.” C’yra grumbled with a shiver. “This whole place is giving me the creeps.”

“You’re not the only one feeling uneasy.” Gimli said, nervously looking around. Then, from deep within the passage, a gust of wind gathered and issued forth, blowing out of the opening with a sound too much like the deep, labored breath of a man for it to be mere coincidence. At once, the three horses panicked and bolted.

“Brego?!” Aragorn called.

“Hasufel?!” Adora shouted. C’yra was frozen in place, pointing into the door.

“Oh no! There’s no way it’s a bunch of grumpy mummies in there! That’s a fuckin’ ghost!” The rest of the party turned back to the door.

“Well, only one way to go, I guess.” Adora said. C’yra turned to her, and let out a strained whisper that sounded something like “are you kidding?”.

“I do not fear the dead.” Aragorn said, striding into the cavern. Wordlessly, Legolas and Adora followed. As they entered, each one was hit by a prolonged gust of wind. The Dwarf and Magicat stood side by side, just staring into the darkness.

“W-well this is unheard of!” Gimli said. “An Elf would go underground, where a Dwarf would not?!”

“I am so glad that Glimmer and Bow aren’t here to see this right now.” C’yra whimpered.

“Agh, we’d never hear the end of it, would we lass?” Gimli said, looking up at her.

“Yeah.”

“So here’s what we’ll do.” The Dwarf said. “You take my hand, and we both go in at once.”

“Sounds good.” C’yra said as she did just that. “I’m totally closing my eyes until we’re in though.” Each took a deep breath, and ran in.

It did not take them long to catch up with the others, as they were all waiting a short distance past the threshold. No one said anything as they pressed onward, until Ardoa looked to the still visibly concerned C’yra.

“I’ve never seen you like this before, C’yra. You always loved going into the deep parts of the Fright Zone.”

“Let’s just say that the last time we all went underground, it didn’t end so well.” C’yra explained. “Hey, did you know that Gandalf used to be the Grey Wizard?”

“What’s that got to do with this?”

“A lot.” C’yra squeaked. Aragorn soon found a torch, and their way was lit, if at least by a little. They came to a narrow passage thick with a fog that came up to their thighs, or waist in Gimli’s case. Legolas seemed distracted by something only he could see. C’yra on the other hand, was darting her own eyes back and forth, circling on her heels, the Sword of Omens drawn and held out in front of her. She had been spending the last few minutes trying to hype herself up.

“You know what? M-maybe it was just the wind after all, and this army we’re here to find was just cursed with eternal life or something and really doesn’t like people visiting! So they found a

way to scare everyone off! There's no such thing as gh- Guh. G-g-g-g-g-g…" She had been interrupted by a most peculiar sight. A green wisp had risen from the fog, taking the form of a skeletal hand and arm, and began to reach for her thigh. C'yra's ears flattened against her skull, her tail shot straight, and her pupils shrank to slits as she let out a high pitched shriek! She jumped high, sheathing her blade and landing on Adora's shoulders! The blonde nearly crumpled to the floor, wrestling with her unwanted passenger before forcing the Magicat back to her own feet.

"C'yra! Get a hold of yourself!" Adora said sternly, yet still clearly amused despite everything. "Look! They can't even do anything to us!" She gestured to their legs as the ghostly hands tried to grip at them, but merely passed through. On the other side of the passage, Gimli was furiously trying to blow and waft the hands away. He stopped at the First One's observation. Aragorn turned to Legolas.

"What do you see?"

"I see shapes of men, and of horses." The Elf said.

"Where?" Gimli asked, looking about. Adora and C'yra tried to find them as well, with the same level of success and varying levels of bravery.

"Pale banners like shreds of cloud." Legolas continued. "Spears rise like thickets through a shroud of mist. The dead are following. They have been summoned." Gimli and Adora made to catch up with the others, while C'yra stood there for a bit, drawing her sword in its dagger form once more.

"The dead? Summoned?" She said to herself. "Well, isn't that just great! That's very great- ADORA!!!" And she broke out into a sprint to follow.

When she reached the next chamber, she saw that everyone had begun to walk more carefully than normal, occasionally glancing down.

“Guys,” C’yra said taking a step forward. “What’s goin o-“

CRUNCH

C’yra felt it as much as she heard it when her foot pressed down on something that clearly wasn’t the floor, the shards further breaking down into a finer gravel as her foot remained.

“C’yra.” Aragorn said calmly. “Don’t look down.” He then turned to continue. Not being able to help herself, C’yra briefly darted her eyes downward before turning her whole head in that direction, before her upon the path was a small pile of skulls and other bones that laid upon the whole length and breadth of the passage's floor. She had stepped upon one of them.

“Aragorn!” C’yra said with a strained squeak. “I’m looking down!”

Not waiting for a response from the Ranger, she began to hobble forward much in the way Gimli was, still occasionally treading upon the bones. An hour passed, and they crossed a great bridge to turn a corner down another hall, coming to a great wide open area that dropped down a great dark pit. Into the wall was carved a facade that resembled something of a great dwelling.

‘Oh great.’ C’yra thought. ‘Another abandoned city.’ She could have sworn that she felt a faint tingle in the area her scar took up.

“Who enters my domain?” Echoed a deep, haggard voice through the mountain. It was hard to see at first, but it soon grew more clear as a sickly green phantasmal figure appeared before them. The ghost of a man, his flesh decayed to the point that most of him was bone. He was adorned in ancient armor that only served to make him more skeletal, and upon his head was a crowned helm.

“One who would have your allegiance.” Aragorn said.

“The dead do not suffer the living to pass.” The ghostly King said.

“You will suffer me.” The ghostly man merely laughed, and his followers made themselves known as he did. In no time the company was surrounded by specters. With her free hand, C’yra clutched on to Adora’s right.

“I’m beginning to think this may have been a bad idea.” Adora said.

“Oh, you’re only realizing that just now?!” C’yra hissed.

“The way is shut.” The King of the Dead said, slowly striding forward. “It was made by those who are dead. And the dead keep it.” Instinctively, Legolas fired an arrow, and it whizzed straight through the King’s head as if he were made of smoke.

“Now you must die!” C’yra shifted unevenly in place, pale-faced and nearly fainting.

“I summon you to fulfill your oath.” Spoke the still calm Aragorn. A portion of the dead army began to follow their king.

“None but the King of Gondor may command me!” The King of the Dead declared, and Aragorn held up Andúril. And with the reforged sword, he blocked the ghost’s incoming strike as if his attacker’s blade was still one of physical metal, the ringing of the clash echoing through the cavern! The King of the Dead seemed just as surprised as anyone else.

“That line was broken!” Aragorn stepped forward to grab him, sword at the ghost’s throat.

“It has been remade!” He let the King go, the ghost stumbling back with a prolonged gasp. Aragorn walked forward, holding his sword in front of him.

“Fight for me! I am Isildur’s Heir!” Aragorn declared. “Fight for me, and I will hold your oaths fulfilled! What say you?” Slowly but surely, the army of the dead disappeared from sight. “You have my word!”

“You’ve been stuck here for thousands of years! This could be your only chance!” Exclaimed Adora.

“Stand ya traitors!!!” Gimli shouted as a deep rumble began to shake the mountain.

“I don’t think that’s helping guys!” A now so very done C’yra yelled. There was a great crack, and the walls of the facade in front of them gave way to a literal avalanche of skulls!

“OUT!!!” Ordered Aragorn.

“YOU DIDN’T HAVE TO TELL ME TWICE!!!” C’yra screamed as she sheathed her blade, the company dashing for the closest exit they could!

In the last five years, C’yra had every so often wondered how she would end up dying. If some of her nightmares during the earlier days of her time in Middle-Earth were anything to go by, she would end up drowning. Sometimes she thought about how things might have gone bad that night at Mount Gundabad, or getting buried alive at Cahadras. More recently, those nightmares featured the more unfortunate outcomes of her close calls in Moria and at Helm’s Deep. Never in a lifetime though, did she think she’d get crushed to death by countless skulls and falling rocks.

Somehow though, the five of them all managed to dash out of the caves and clear through to the other side of the mountain before being crushed to death. As luck would have it, they were close to the river where Aragorn had been planning to lead them, and the Corsair sailors that he had intended to intercept were right on time. The only problem being that they were down an army. Aragorn slumped to his knees in defeat as C’yra caught her breath next to Adora. Legolas and Gimli stepped forward to comfort the despondent Ranger.

“That’s it!” C’yra gasped. “If I ever go underground ever again, it’ll be WAY too soon!”

“Agreed!” Adora said.

“By the way, if you tell anyone that I screamed, you’re dead!”

“Gotcha!” Came Adora’s breathless chuckle.

“And don’t tell anyone that I’m afraid of ghosts!” C’yra said defiantly. “Because I’m not!” As luck would have it, that would be when the King of the Dead decided to walk out of the mountain and up to Aragorn. Almost immediately, C’yra sprung into the air with another terrified shriek.

“We fight!” The King declared, pausing a moment to look off to the side before returning to the mountain to gather his troops. Aragorn, Legolas, and Gimli turned around to what he had been looking at to find a now blushing C’yra clutching onto Adora as the blonde held her in her arms. Adora looked down at her and cocked an eyebrow.

“Hey C’yra.”

“Meh-meh, fwee…eh?” C’yra said with a weak chuckle, her blush growing deeper. Aragorn, Legolas, and Gimli gave a set of knowing smiles. C’yra looked over to them.

“What are you chuckleheads looking at?!”

The Siege of Minas Tirith

Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon knew a thing or two about facing the insurmountable, for a while it felt like she was doing so on a daily basis and still every time she and her friends came out on top. But this…

This was very, very different.

Sauron's forces were one hundred thousand strong, and that was just the Orcs. None of the other factions Gandalf had informed her and Bow of had even shown up yet. As she stood on the knife's edge of the upper level's grand courtyard, the enemy stood out from the fields of Pelennor like a great mass of darkened corn stalks. The Nine had begun the assault, taking to the skies astride their Fell Beasts, spreading a chilling supernatural terror to the populace with their mere presence as the rest of the army prepared to lay siege to the White City. Glimmer turned back, where she could see Lord Denethor stew in a mixture of despair and grief. Two days ago, he had sent out his youngest son, Faramir with a small host of riders in a futile attempt to take back the ruined city of Osgiliath. Faramir's horse was the only one to return, dragging along its unconscious rider with it.

Seconds ago, Faramir's body was presented to the steward, who immediately proclaimed the death of his son despite Pippin's clear observation that Faramir could yet be saved with proper medicine. But it was all for naught. Whoever Denethor had been holding counsel with clearly sought to drive him mad with that despair and grief, and had clearly succeeded.

"ABANDON YOUR POSTS!!!" Denethor bellowed out to the city out of nowhere. "FLEE!!! FLEE FOR YOUR LIVES!!!" Alright, that was enough! It just so happened that Gandalf had managed to sneak up on the mad steward as he turned on his heel, giving him a hearty whack across the face with the head of his staff! Glimmer summoned her own staff and within an instant, teleported beside them to render onto Denethor a strike across the back of his head as he reeled! Gandalf gave a sigh of disgust and followed up, hitting Denethor in the chest before Glimmer followed up with a strike to his back! This sent Denethor careening straight into Gandalf's next strike to his gut, and the duo finished him off with a double hit to the back of his head, knocking the steward out cold!

“You have no idea how long I’ve wanted to do that!” Glimmer exclaimed. Gandalf gave her a slight nod before raising his own voice.

“PREPARE FOR BATTLE!!!”

Glimmer teleported manically up and down the city, doing her part to rally the troops. Once she had given each level a twice over, she made her way to one of the upper levels, barely dodging an incoming stone hurled from Orc catapults! As she teleported out of the way, she managed to grab onto the most senior soldier, saving him from being crushed in the falling debris.

“Get ready to return their fire!” Glimmer ordered.

“Milady, we have nothing to load the trebuchets with!” Exclaimed one soldier. Glimmer looked to where the shot she had dodged landed.

“They seek to destroy Minas Tirith.” Glimmer said, an idea forming. “How about the city returns the favor?”

Thankfully, it appeared that the other garrisons had the same idea, loading the rubble of the very city they swore to protect and returning a volley! Rent stone flew past haphazardly carved globes of rock, flying into the horde below, crushing all manner of Orc, Troll, catapult, and the odd siege tower! Wait, siege towers? And despite any efforts, the lion's share of them were getting much too close for comfort.

“Oh, this is gonna be bad.” Glimmer said to herself.

Bow meanwhile, had managed to catch up with Gandalf on the outermost wall, just barely getting his quiver full of a side project he had been working on sling to his back and adjusting his new armor.

“Send these foul beasts back to the Abyss!” Gandalf cried, and the archers of Gondor let fly! Arrows sunk into many a target, but a good portion were still caught by the closest siege tower. Bow studied the tower in question, and found a most curious feature. At every level of the tower was a small hole intended for firing arrows or sticking spears through. Holes that were currently not being manned as it had not come close enough just yet. Bow gave a smile, and pulled out a very special arrow. Since coming to Middle-Earth, Bow was stunned and somewhat upset for a bit upon realizing that something seemed to effectively jam most advanced tech here. Not even his custom arrows were spared. Thankfully, Bow had been quick to recognize this as a challenge in making do with what he had and coming up with more creative solutions. One of which had been a discussion he had with Gandalf a few weeks ago on the subject of fireworks.

The item attached to this arrow was small, but Bow had ensured that it would be powerful. Now the only problem was igniting it without the need for a torch of any kind. So Bow had taken some flint and attached it to the middle of the weapon he shared his name with, and put the fuse of the firework close enough to the arrow’s head so that the spark would have a better chance of catching. He’d only been able to test this out a few times, and the results had proven mixed.

But not mixed enough to totally disregard his current plan. Bow took aim and fired, the spark catching as his arrow flew over the wall and flew true! The arrow threaded itself through the hole perfectly just as the fuse burnt home, and the firework exploded, blowing a sizable hole in the tower and burning a good few Orcs in the process! Their shrieking would be short lived however, as it would turn out that luck really was on Bow’s side with this shot. In the absence of a crucial support structure, there was enough weight on the break and the hole was sizable enough to cause the topmost part of the tower to lean down on itself and snap in two! The top of the tower fell onto the Orcs below, and one of the Trolls that had been pushing it along! A round of triumphant cries came from the archers closest to Bow in congratulation.

“That was a really lucky shot!” He admitted. “Don’t think I can pull an encore! There’s got to be a better way of slowing down these towers. The Trolls! Everybody aim for the Trolls!” Gandalf ushered Shadowfax along the wall, repeating the order to those who could not hear it.

From atop one of the higher walls, Glimmer did her best to aid in directing the shots of the trebuchets. From above, a deathly shriek pierced the air! Glimmer shot her head up, the Nazgûl were attempting another pass. She held her staff in both hands and took aim, thrusting it forward to fire out a blast of pure magic energy that exploded in a burst of light as it struck its target! The Wraith in question briefly lost control of its Fell Beast, and veered off to fly over the fields once more! With an invigorated grin, Glimmer fired off more blasts, diverting three more Wraiths before she heard an odd sound from behind her. Turning, she was met with the sight of a Fell Beast gliding toward her, mere feet from the floor of the wall as it plowed through the line of Gondorian soldiers with its mighty talons!

“Oh shit!” She exclaimed, grabbing onto the two men closest to her and diving off the wall. “Get down!” Glimmer hit the ground, groaning in pain but glad her armor absorbed most of the shock. She turned onto her back and beheld the devastation wrought by the attack. They were now down one trebuchet. Gritting her teeth, she stood back up, defiantly clutching her staff.

“Milady,” Asked one of the soldiers she had saved as he too, stood. “What do we do now?”

“Search for any survivors of that attack and save as many as you can.” Glimmer ordered. “I’m going to see about evening the odds.” And with no further clarification, she teleported away.

Bow fired arrow after arrow, yet the enemy seemed to always have more Trolls to pick up the slack of those the defenders managed to fell. The towers were getting much too close for comfort now. A puff of shimmering pink smoke appeared next to him out of nowhere, from which Glimmer emerged.

“How are we doing, babe?” She asked, her face set.

“Not so good!” Bow exclaimed. “We’ve got a huge siege tower problem!” Glimmer tightened her grip on her staff and closed her eyes. Slowly, she rose up into the air, beginning to glow a brilliant pink as pure magical power gathered around both her and the head of her staff. The Queen of Brightmoon hung in the air for a few seconds, before opening her eyes to reveal blinding light issuing from them!

“Not anymore.”

Glimmer swung her staff, sending out a great crescent shaped wave of magic that flew out over the fields and knocked all but one of the siege towers up and backwards into the air! They spun as they fell, crushing large swaths of the Orcs beneath them as they landed with a great splintering crash! A cheer rose up from the defenders of Minas Tirith, but it was to be short lived. The final siege tower managed to hit the wall, the panel at the front opening to reveal a steady stream of Orcs that then flowed into the defending ranks! Glimmer landed back on the wall and caught her breath, looking over at the new breach where Gandalf and Pippin headed up the defense.

“Are you gonna need a break?” Bow asked.

“No. I’ll be fine.” Glimmer answered. “Come on, we’ve got some Orcs to mop up.”

The conflict went on for a quarter of an hour, the moon now halfway to being completely set in the sky, that is if it could have been seen through the dark cloud of Mordor. The defenders had

managed to eliminate the remaining Orcs that had breached the wall with Glimmer's help. Off in the distance, a distinct pounding noise could be heard.

"Sounds like they're trying to ram down the gates!" Bow observed.

"It's been going on since I took out those towers." Glimmer said. "It'll probably take them the rest of the night to get through." Upon her finishing of the statement, the sound of a chant began to issue up the walls of the city from the fields below. Faint at first, but then all too clear:

"GROND! GROND! GROND! GROND!"

Glimmer turned to Gandalf, who had walked up the ramparts to witness the new development.

"Gandalf? What's a 'Grond'?" Bow looked over in the direction that Gandalf was, and his eyes widened.

"Well Glim," Bow said. "If I had to hazard a guess, I'd say that it's probably the giant battering ram shaped like a wolf's head that they're pulling up to the gates." Gandalf turned away, walking to find Shadowfax.

"Bow," He said. "Go and find Peregrin! Aid him in whatever endeavor he has undertaken. Glimmer, follow me!" Glimmer stole a quick glance over the wall.

"No argument here!" She agreed. "Let's go!"

Of all the places that Glimmer suspected Gandalf would lead her, the main plaza of the city just inside of the very gates that the enemy wished to breach was not high on the list, but quite obvious now that she thought about it. She teleported to a stop just as a sizable host of Gondorian soldiers took position in front of Gandalf and Shadowfax.

THOOM

The gates rattled violently, ages of dust and small bits of wood falling to the ground.

THOOM

“You are soldiers of Gondor!” Gandalf shouted over the noise.

THOOM

“Whatever comes through that gate, you will stand your ground!”

THOOM-CRASH

The wolf’s head menacingly burst through the gate as it rendered the doors to splinters! Out of the smoke of the destroyed doors, six great Trolls in full battle armor and wielding giant maces emerged!

“Oh, fuck me!!!” Exclaimed Glimmer as she raised her staff.

Bow weaved in and out of streets and alleyways, searching for Pippin. Level after level he ran, encountering only wounded soldiers, citizens, and the various dead that had perished beneath falling rubble. Those that were still able to scurried about, doing what they could to mitigate the chaos. He was about to give up his search for the Hobbit when he quite literally ran into the Took in question!

“Pippin! There you are!” Bow exclaimed. “Gandalf sent me to help you!”

“Well as much as I appreciate that, it’s Gandalf’s help that I need! Lord Denethor means to do something quite terrible!”

“At the very least I will have been keeping fit for the day!” Bow exclaimed as he caught his breath, realizing that he’d have to run

back down the tiers of the city. “Do you need a lift?”

Glimmer would have found the sight almost comical if the situation had been different. She and Gandalf had only just managed to help the remaining men bar the doors to the lower parts of the city when she saw Bow running at them with Pippin clinging to his back. Pippin then informed them of Denethor’s total fall into madness and his plans to burn both himself and Faramir alive. For a brief moment, Glimmer figured that she and Gandalf should have found somewhere to lock the steward in before the battle began. Gandalf was more quick on the uptake, and bade Bow and Pippin to join him upon Shadowfax, with the Hobbit in the front and Bow in the back. Glimmer followed close behind as she could, magically enhancing her speed. None of what she had gone through over the last day would have been for anything, especially her efforts to vaporize three of those Trolls, if the only remaining sane man in the lineage of stewards was lost.

It was just beyond the gate where the fifth level of the city gave way to the sixth where they were cut off by the last thing that they would have wanted to impede them. Landing with a great rumble and rush of wind, a Fell Beast now stood in their way, eyeing the lot of them with an undeniable hunger in its eyes.

And atop the winged creature, a dark form that would have remained shapeless if not for the shrouded hood and robe that hung from it. It would have been easy to write off this figure as any one of the Nine if not for the great helm upon his head. Reaching out from where brow terminates to the forehead, a series of horrid, jagged spikes sprouted from it, and one final spike standing upwards from the forehead took the majority of its weight. From him exuded an aura of pure malice and dread that would have caused those of a lesser mind to flee at the very sight of him, and failing that, the ragged, airy breath of his speech.

The Witch King of Angmar had come to take his prize.

“Go back to the Abyss!” Gandalf commanded, holding his staff aloft. “Fall into the nothingness that awaits you and your master!”

“Do you not know death when you see it, old man?” The Witch King hissed, reaching for his belt. As soon as the Wraith had spoken, Glimmer nearly stopped short. For but a brief moment, she had been taken to when a similar voice was practically all she could hear in her head. A voice that had haunted her even still over the past five years. But she did not freeze. Fear gave way to fury as Glimmer leapt between her friends and the Witch King, brandishing her own staff and staring both the Wraith and his mount down.

“Go!” She shouted back at the others. “He’s mine!” Gandalf, taken aback, tried to say something. But Glimmer had already made her move, blasting the Fell Beast upon the snout with a brilliant spark of power!

“GO!” She shouted again, and Gandalf reluctantly urged Shadowfax on. He, Pippin, and Bow’s escape was covered by another blast from Glimmer. The Witch King was equal parts upset yet strangely amused at the fire of this girl, he raised a single finger, pointing at her as his mount recovered.

“Come not between the Nazgûl and his prey!” He rasped. “Or he will not slay thee in thy turn. He will bear thee away to the houses of lamentation, beyond all darkness, where thy flesh shall be devoured, and thy shriveled mind be left naked to the Lidless Eye!”

“There’s nothing you can do to me that hasn’t already been done short of killing me!” Glimmer exclaimed, her grip upon her staff tightening.

“We shall see.”

Glimmer struck first, swinging her staff at both her sides, gathering energy into its head before thrusting it forward, sending a blast straight at the Witch King's face! The Wraith drew his sword as the blast approached and swung, cutting through the bolt of energy! The Fell Beast thrust its head forward in attempt to catch Glimmer in its jaws, but she simply teleported out of the way! She reappeared on the creature's left side, shooting a bolt directly into its hide, leaving the Fell Beast reeling with a smoking hole in its hide the size of a bowling ball! She followed this up with a volley of three smaller bolts aimed at the Witch King, who deflected them all with his blade!

"Your power is great, and not of this world." The Lord of the Nazgûl said, managing to somehow catch and hold another blast in his left hand! He gave the sphere of sparking energy a curious look. "A demigod. Fascinating."

The Witch King wound back and tossed the spell right at her, and Glimmer caught it with her staff, spinning around to launch it back at him! He batted it with his sword, sending it back again, and Glimmer made a similar move, making sure to put even more of her power into the still active spell. They continued this back and forth for a full half minute, the ball of energy growing and growing. But then, upon the Witch King's twelfth hit in the rally, Glimmer caught the energy with the head of her staff, where it traveled down the body of the weapon as she wound her arm back! The staff, her body, and especially her eyes were akin to a small star with the glow of her power as she concentrated the absorbed energy for one last charge and shot her staff forward! The energy dispersed in the form of a great beam of hot pink energy, around the size of a large man's fully clenched fist, and shot directly into the left side of the Witch King's face! His head was knocked back and he pulled on the reins of his mount, sending it staggering to the edge. Glimmer breathed heavily where she stood, a furious smile upon her face. The Witch King turned back to her, the left half of his helmet's faceplate nearly blown off in its entirety and melted where shards remained! Smoke issued from beneath the hood of his cloak, which bore its own singes on the fringe. He took in a deep, wheezing rasp.

“All of that for a mere scratch?”

Glimmer’s face fell. Though the Lord of the Nazgûl had felt the impact, her best only seemed to have the effect of a particularly strong punch. This Wraith had earned his title for a reason. A sense of unfathomable discomfort overcame her, and it felt as if the Witch King’s eyeless void of a face had peered right into her soul.

“Wayward Queen far from home,

Foolish Queen all alone.

Few can resist the Blackest Breath,

But none are immune to the ice of death.

You stand tall with furious eyes,

Under the spell of your own lies.

A chance you’d have with allies true,

But alone this tale you cannot force through.

Only the Great Eye can wield such power, know ye now,

This is MY hour!”

His words said and the Queen of Brightmoon caught off guard, the Witch King raised his sword as the signature glittering sparkles of Glimmer’s magic began to swirl around the blazing flame that had ignited upon his blade! Glimmer looked down to see that the energy, only a little at first but gaining even more volume, seemed to have been drawn from her staff itself! As more energy was drawn, she felt her weapon begin to tremble terribly in her hands, and a fatigue began to set upon her. Glimmer set her face and grit

her teeth, now actively fighting back in this battle of wills as she tried to pull the magic back to her! Her struggle lasted all of six seconds. A great whistling hiss filled the air as a practical cyclone of flame and sparkling energy spun around the Witch King's blade, and Glimmer's staff exploded in her hands with a mighty crack! The force of it flung her backwards, and one of the splinters flew across her face, raking through her left eyebrow and diagonally back towards the topmost of her left ear, the wound terminating just a half inch away from the side of her hairline! Glimmer hit the ground with a yell of pain and skidded along the road. Her lower right arm felt as if it had been crushed in a great vice, and her left hand went up to place pressure on her stinging brow. Her gaze drifted to the splinters and snapped halves of her father's old staff, then back up to the Witch King, her face in pure disbelief.

"You have failed, girl." The Wraith said. "The World of Men will fall, and you will suffer along with it!" The Witch King raised his sword, but at the crux of his stroke, he stopped at the distinctive blast of a horn from behind and to the east of the fields below. He turned, and was met with the sight of the battle's latest development ere the sun rose. The Lord of the Nazgûl spared Glimmer one more passing glance, and made his choice, ushering his mount back toward Pelennor Fields. The Witch King left, and the defeated Queen shakily rose to her feet, tears welling in her eyes at the sight of a shattered heirloom. The horn sounded again in the distance, breaking her out of her thoughts. Too tired to teleport, Glimmer began the weary, staggered walk up to the final level of the city to regroup with the rest of her friends. The battle below could wait a while longer.

Rohan had come at last.

The Return of the King Part VI

The Battle of Pelennor Fields

C'yra turned the wheel of the commandeered ship as it sailed downriver, allowing herself to just live and enjoy the moment she found herself in. Never in all her years did she think that she would come to actually enjoy the experience of traveling upon the water, much less find herself to be actually decent at piloting such a craft as this one. Maybe it was the relatively calm nature of the river, maybe it was because anything was better than being back in a haunted mountain, but nonetheless the Magicat found herself oddly enamored with the sailor's life.

Legolas was apparently enjoying it as well. When he wasn't thinking over the full implications of the gull's call that had greeted their day yesterday morning. Even now he stood at the starboard edge of the ship, looking contemplatively off into the distance. Nearby and just a little closer to C'yra, Adora and Gimli sat upon a barrel and a box respectively. C'yra looked back to the seemingly unmanned ships following them, then turned forward again. Aragorn was at the bow, and she could just barely make out the ghostly head of their reinforcements hovering next to him. Her tail flicked unconsciously.

"What's on your mind Legolas?" C'yra asked, they still had some ways to go yet, and she had figured that she'd rather not spend that time bored out of her mind.

"The Lady of the Golden Wood spoke true." Legolas said. "Even now, I can hear the waves calling for me. But, now is not the time. There is a task to do, and I would still linger in the company of my friends a great while longer before I depart."

"Can't say I blame you." C'yra answered with a chuckle. "There's a strange appeal to this sort of thing. Who'd have thought that

Galadriel's tidings for both you and Aragorn would come to pass so close to each other?"

"I'd call it coincidence." Adora said, chewing on a bite of lembas. "Mostly because I'm starting to get a little tired of all the prophecies that seem to be going around. Still, it's kind of nice to have some fortelling something kind of pleasant for once."

"To be fair, the words for Aragorn sound way more like extra cryptic advice than anything else."

"Well, I guess that when you live long enough, giving advice while also not managing to say anything is one of the few things that stays consistently fun." Adora supposed. She looked at C'yra for a while as the nautical air blew through her hair and fur. It was still weird, how happy her old squad mate looked these days. Even with the evidence of older, grander things scattered and shattered about these lands, Arda had something to it that saw fit to invigorate the hearts of those with a certain spirit. C'yra hadn't even gotten upset when a stray splash hit her during their boarding of the ship. And she was actually enjoying being at the helm of the vessel. Though, Adora had begun to suspect that C'yra had planned something with Aragorn soon after they'd set off. Even with how much both of them had changed, she could still recognize that mischievous glint in the Magicat's eyes.

"What?" C'yra asked, noticing the stare of the First One.

"It's just… Weird." Adora said. "I've never seen you this comfortable around this much water."

"It's been a process." C'yra said. "I landed in a river when I came here, you know. That was not fun. Then a few months of trying to find a way around them and getting caught in a rainstorm or two later, I figured 'fuck it' and started to teach myself to swim. Thank the ancestors nobody was around to see those first few tries."

"If it was anything like when you fell off our boat and into the Anduin, I'm sure it was just as amusing." Gimli said. C'yra's face

fell.

“I thought we all agreed we weren’t going to ever talk about that.” She said flatly.

“You fell out of a boat?” Adora asked. “How?”

“C’yra was leaning over the side.” Legolas explained smugly. “She caught a glimpse of a shining scale in the water and fancied herself a fisherwoman. She overestimated her grasp, then tumbled over the side.” Adora burst into a fountain of laughter. C’yra’s ears pinned back and a blush came to her face.

“I was hungry!” She said, mortified. “And I had a bandage over my eye! My depth perception was all wonky!”

“And I had thought that you swore off fish after our encounter with the Watcher in the waters outside Moria.” Gimli added.

“The what?” Adora said, getting control of her laughs.

“Oh right.” C’yra said. “Forgot about the giant squid monster.”

“Okay, first you tell me there’s a giant fire demon, then we recruit an army of ghosts, and now there’s a monster squid in all this mess too?” Adora said. “What’s next? A dragon?!”

“Not anymore.” C’yra said. “Gimli’s dad and Frodo’s uncle helped take care of that one.”

“You’re kidding me.” Came her flat response.

“That’s what I thought too. The whole business about it came up early into our little Road Trip. The guys spent the next couple weeks telling me the whole thing.”

“It took that long?”

“The journey to reclaim our home in the Lonely Mountain took Thorin’s company all across Middle-Earth.” Gimli said. “Tales like

that can take quite some time to tell, lass."

"Well." Adora said, looking down the river. "We've clearly got at least another day ahead of us before we get where we're going."

"And there isn't much else to talk about I suppose." Legolas said.

"You do have a point." C'yra agreed. "I just hope I remember enough of it right."

"We'll help where we can, C'yra." Gimli said, the Magicat nodding in response.

"Alright then, where to start?" She said in thought as she adjusted the ship's wheel. "Ah! That's it!" And thus, the story began:

"In a hole in the ground, there lived a Hobbit…"

The siege of the city had been going splendidly if you were to ask the second in command of the mighty Gothmorg. Or at least it had been until the Horse Men came in from the northeast with the dawning of the day. Now all was the exact sort of chaos that the Orc did not appreciate at all. Their forces scattered and trampled, only half of the city fallen, and nearly their entire army now reliant on the barely tolerated assistance of the Easterlings and the forces from Harad. While they were in no real place to question the Dark Lord, the Orc deeply despised that they were expected to fight alongside these Men. After all, dominion over the land was to go to Orc-kind once Sauron controlled all. Perhaps they would make a feast of these erstwhile allies as well once everything was said and done. Swallowing their discomfort, the second in command led a fraction of their forces to the river to greet their reinforcements.

"Late as usual Pirate scum!" The Orc shouted to the docking lead ship. "About time you got here! There's knife-work that needs doing!" It was only then that the Orc caught sight of the banner that had been flying upon the ship's mast. The standard was jet

black, bearing seven gems arranged as stars, and a crown stitched in gold and mithril above them. The most eye-catching element though, was the unmistakable white tree in the center. The crack of a whip was heard from within the rigging, and a figure swung to land on the port side bannister of the hull. The apparent captain on the ship stood there proudly, wrapping up and reattaching the whip to her belt.

“Ahoy gentlemen!” She said jovially, holding her arms out to her sides. “The Corsairs of Umbar regret to inform you that they were not able to attend!”

“What is that?” Said an Orc.

“It looks like some sort of Seacat!” Said another, the group began to fidget nervously.

“There is no need to be upset though!” This Seacat announced. “I come bearing gifts!” Still perfectly balanced, she gave a flourishing bow.

“Behold my tribute to the Great Eye!”

At her signal, Aragorn, Legolas, Gimli, and Adora hoisted themselves from their hiding spots and over the ship’s side, landing upon the ground with their weapons drawn! She joined them soon after, drawing her own sword. The Orcs were fully panicking now, and started their attempt to scramble away.

“There’s plenty for all of us!” Exclaimed Gimli, “May the best Dwarf win!”

“Oh-ho! I can take you up on that!” Adora challenged excitedly. “For the Honor of Greyskull!”

In a flash of light, Adora transformed into the eight foot form of She-Ra and the five charged, the Army of the Dead soon appearing and following behind them!

“Gagh!” C’yra exclaimed as the last of the ghosts glided through her. “I’m never going to get used to that!”

And so the battle was joined.

C’yra soon found a pleasant surprise through the rush of enemies that she weaved in and out of. She-Ra had stuck close to her, and despite the many years of separation between now and the last time she and Adora had fought side by side, they had already begun to naturally sync up in the defeating of shared opponents. Even after everything that had happened, they still had an innate sense for each other. The fact they both bore similar weapons now was likely a great help as well. What C’yra was not used to though, was Adora’s voice coming in a regular roar as she counted every last Orc she took out aloud.

“Of fucking course they dragged you into this Adora!” C’yra yelled over the clamor. “Unbelievable!”

“What?!” She-Ra said as she changed the sword into the form of a polearm, sweeping away a near baker’s dozen of enemies. “You got a problem with it?!” C’yra stopped for a moment, then smirked.

“Actually no.” She said, pointing behind She-Ra at a couple of approaching Trolls. “How about you put our boys in their place and outfight them both? Starting with those guys.” She-Ra turned to meet the oncoming challenge.

“Oh, they’re big.”

“Just wanted to give you a fair fight is all, ‘Dor!” C’yra exclaimed as she bounded over to assist Aragorn with a group of four particularly large Orcs. She-Ra could only give a grin in exchange as she turned to face the Trolls. She changed the sword back and held it in both hands.

“Okay then. Which one of you wants to go first?”

Having cut down the small squad of Orcs, C’yra found herself gravitating towards where she heard Gimli’s war cries issuing from the crowd. The Army of the Dead it seemed, was much more focused on the hordes further away on the other sides of the fields, leaving quite a few for the Grey Company to take care of themselves. C’yra chopped her way through another enemy, and stabbed one more that tried to get at the Dwarf’s back!

“I think we’re starting to scare them off!” She exclaimed.

“Their ranks are thinning much faster than they should, even with the five of us!” Gimli observed as he crowned an attacking Orc with his axe. A short distance away, She-Ra cut a sizable swath through the enemy. “Adora has been holding out on us!”

“Well, to be fair, this is the first actual fight we’ve gotten into since Helm’s Deep. She hasn't really had the chance until now. I’ve almost forgotten how satisfying it is to cut these monsters down!” She parried an attack and returned it in kind, beheading the Orc as Gimli found another to sink his axe into the guts of! “Wait, do you feel that rumbling too?” Aragorn was much more quick on the uptake this time, spying the latest development before anyone else.

“Legolas!” Aragorn shouted, getting the Elf’s attention. “Mumakil!!!”

It’s quite odd how when one is significantly distracted, even the most large and obvious of details can be overlooked. C’yra had her attention diverted by Aragorn’s cry as much as Legolas had, and now they both bore witness to a very large, pachyderm-shaped problem. Known colloquially as an Oliphaunt, the Mumakil of Southern Harad were enormous beasts that greatly resembled what you and I know as elephants. Albeit these creatures were of a far greater size. The Haradrim often used them as transport,

and in this case, beasts of war tasked with carrying anywhere from twelve to sixteen men, barring the one tasked with directing the great beast. Of the forces that Sauron had been able to coerce into fighting for him, this particular Mumakil was only one of the remaining two left active in the battle. But it would not be for long if the look on Legolas' face was anything to go by. As he rushed to climb the great colossus, C'yra sheathed her sword and bounded after him on all fours, cautiously running beside the creature before leaping onto its left back leg, imbedding her claws into its tough hide! C'yra then began to climb, managing to outpace Legolas as he too ascended the creature.

As C'yra reached the summit of her climb and drew her sword, she stopped short. Her newest adversaries weren't Orcs. Turning to her with bows and spears ready were a group that were clearly human men. C'yra's eyes widened in shock and despair, then set to fury. This war was ugly enough with the Dark Lord setting his monsters on innocent people, but Sauron had seen fit to manipulate other people into this as well? How was an army of unfeeling borderline feral monsters not enough?! Having to fight and possibly kill fellow sentient beings was something that C'yra had thought she'd finally left behind. To her horror, a good many of them looked not much older than she did. Some even looked younger. What lies had they been fed to lead them here? How many of them would have been content to just stay at home with their mothers, fathers, and lovers? Was it really all that likely that every one of them was even near the level of Evil as the Dark Lord who had called them here?

C'yra was beyond furious now. As if she did not need another reason to know that Sauron had to go. Legolas made it to the top of the Mumakil and stood beside her. As the Haradrim moved to repel their borders, C'yra knew that unfortunately only one party was getting off this thing alive. She did the only thing she could, recalling an ancient warrior tradition of the Magicats, or Thunderans she supposed, that she had read of in her mother's journal.

These young men were only her enemies because they had the misfortune of being on the opposite sides of a war that they had been dragged into by the Dark Lord. She raised the Sword of Omens so that the crossguard came to her offhand's shoulder, and then with a flourish, swung it back to her side in a salute. These Men were not monsters to enjoy the slaying of, but fellow warriors that demanded the very most of the very little honor there was in making war. Legolas regarded her gesture and they exchanged a nod. The Elf went left, and she went right.

C'yra brought her sword down on the first man's spear, cutting right through the shaft! She followed up with a left hook to his jaw, knocking him out of the war tower and off the creature! She dodged to the side of the next's arrow and countered with a stab to his shoulder. She then kicked him to the structure's floor, moving on to trade blows with a pair off opponents. Legolas had been much more efficient, and was now in a skirmish with the Haradrim solider in charge of guiding the Mumakil along. An opponent that was much more formidable than he had anticipated. Thinking fast, the Elf jumped back and grabbed onto the ropes binding the war tower to the beast! Drawing one of his long daggers, Legolas cut the binding, and waited for gravity to do the rest as the entire structure began to slide off the right side of the Mumakil!

With C'yra still on it.

"What the?!" She exclaimed as she noticed the tower beginning to fall, her next course of action was decided, and she was none to happy about it. "I can't believe I'm actually doing this!!!"

Thankfully, she was close enough to the edge for this plan to have some chance of working. So she made a mad dash to leap off, having to drop her weapon in order to spring from her launch point with full force!

"OH SHIT!!!" She screamed as she tumbled through the air, the Haradrim war tower crashing to the ground in a hail of splinters!

She only hoped that the height was not so great that a tuck and roll would end up doing harm.

Legolas now stood atop the bare back of the Mumakil, weighing his options. Drawing three arrows at once, he sprinted to the neck and sank them in with a mighty draw of his bow! The beast cried out and began to fall forward. Legolas jumped, gracefully sliding off the Mumakil's forehead and down its trunk, landing safely on the ground in front of an awestruck Gimli with a small hop! They made eye contact, the Elf giving a small shrug.

"That still only counts as one!!!" Gimli bellowed, rushing off to mop up the rest of the Orcs.

And what of C'yra, you might be asking? Well dear reader, it would turn out that her appointment with the ground was to be postponed. As she fell, prolonging her scream of profanity, a gold and white blur rushed upwards, snatching her midair! The two figures hit the ground, and C'yra looked up to see that she was being held aloft in the left arm of She-Ra, Princess of Power.

"Oh, hey Adora." C'yra said casually, a light blush on her face.

"We really must stop meeting like this C'yra." She-Ra said smoothly.

"I dunno, I'm actually starting to kinda like it." The Magicat admitted. She-Ra raised an eyebrow.

"Is that so?"

"Yeah." She said with a cocked smile. And with that, C'yra reached up to grab her face, bringing their lips together in a most passionate kiss.

You've probably heard of them. Those kisses that are just so… Much that they drown the rest of the world out and cause those participating to hold each other even more tightly, as if their lover

would vanish from existence should they let go. They are not exactly a common occurrence, but many who have traveled the worlds over a great many years had been able to both experience and bear witness to enough of them that they knew this for sure. These kind of kisses tended to happen in two specific situations with an almost alarming regularity. One, when the lovers are reunited after an extended time apart, and two, right in the middle of a furious battle.

"Ladies!" Came the voice of Aragorn, bringing the two back to reality. "Now is NOT the time!" The kiss broke, and C'yra and She-Ra both looked to Aragorn with an awkward smile, their faces akin to a tomato and strawberry respectively.

"Heh, you're right." She-Ra said. "Sorry!" She put C'yra down.

"Don't worry too much about it." C'yra said. "He's probably just annoyed that HIS girlfriend's halfway across the world right now." She-Ra was struck still by the implications the emphasis on the word "his" brought with it, her blush somehow deepening.

"Oh wow. Girlfriend."

"Come on ya big dork." C'yra said with a chuckle, raising her arm in the direction of the war tower rubble. "We've got some Orcs to mop up. Sword of Omens, come to my hand!" There was a quick series of snaps and a whistle as the blade flew from the rubble and to C'yra's waiting palm. She-Ra flinched a little at its sudden arrival.

"Whoa!"

"What? Yours can't do that?" C'yra asked with a grin as she ran forward.

"No! At least I don't think it does." She-Ra called ahead, looking curiously at her blade. She then began to charge forward as well.

The Army of the Dead had started clearing out the city, all they had to do now was take their pick of the stragglers.

The Houses of Healing

Smoke blew across the fields of Pelennor as Orc bodies were burned and the Men of both sides were gathered so that they could be organized and given proper burial. Those not tasked with the moving of the dead set about searching for survivors to take to the great tent brought in from the White City and erected to serve as a healing house. Gandalf the White strode through the ruin, coming upon the sight of Aragorn convening with the Army of the Dead. As the Heir of Isildur declared their oath fulfilled, the specters slowly faded, finally passing on.

C'yra treaded lightly across the fields, soon reuniting with Legolas, Gimli, and Adora near the point where they had started their search near a fallen Mumakil and what appeared to be a beheaded mount of the Nazgûl.

"That's all I could find in that sector." C'yra said gravely. "So many didn't make it. But some at least still lingered." She looked to her companions, and noticed the apparent tension between them.

"Okay, I've known you all long enough to tell something's up. What's the problem?"

"Legolas and Gimli are of the opinion that my final count of one hundred and ten should be split up because I used She-Ra." Adora said. "Evidently, transforming into a magic warrior Princess is cheating." The trio looked at her expectantly.

"Oh ancestors help me." C'yra groaned, bringing her palm to her face. "I am way too biased to be dragged into this. If you guys

really need a fourth party to mediate you this much, go bother Aragorn. There's no way I'm getting tangled up in all th-" She was cut off by a pained wail some yards away, and turned to see Eomer kneel to the ground, clutching onto the unconscious body of someone who could only be Eowyn. It was around that time that Pippin had approached the area as well, frantically searching and calling for Merry. C'yra, Adora, Legolas, and Gimli rushed over.

"She's still alive!" Adora exclaimed as she set her hand on Eowyn's arm, her brother still weeping. "Barely."

"Holy crap!" C'yra exclaimed upon getting a good look at the fallen shieldmaiden. "What happened to her?" Eowyn looked almost comically too worse for wear, and a series of tar black veins lanced across her body. From off to the side, C'yra heard a familiar groan. She turned around to see a familiar Hobbit-sized lump pinned underneath an Orc.

"Merry?!" She asked as she and Gimli rolled the corpse off of him. "Pippin! Over here! We found him!" She didn't think she'd ever seen a Hobbit run so fast as the Guard of the Citadel did then. Legolas examined the barely conscious Hobbit, then turned his eyes to Eowyn.

"We need to get them to Aragorn." He said. "Now!"

As it would turn out, that was easier said than done. If the mutterings of the elderly head healer within the tent were accurate, it was said that the Hands of the True King of Gondor were healing hands, and the only thing that could stave off the Black Breath employed by the Nazgûl. Even so, the old woman seemed to have an annoying tendency to get in the way more often than naught, and Minas Tirith's only resident (and extremely haughty) Warden and Herb Master wasn't helping matters either. It took some doing, but soon Aragorn had the Kingsfoil needed and Eowyn and Merry were brought before him. At Aragorn's

request, Eomer and Pippin were to stay beside them in order to aid in bringing the two out from the influence of the curse.

C'yra saw fit to stick by Adora as she used her own power to heal those with more pedestrian afflictions, but found her attention diverted to a cot on the far side of the tent. There sat Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon, a bandage tied to her forehead and slumped in her seat. Next to her at the foot of the cot, there were two halves of a broken staff, and in her right hand, a small length of a bone-white branch. C'yra walked up to her.

"Never thought I'd ever say this, but I'm glad to see you made it out, Sparkles." She said with a chuckle.

"I couldn't beat him." Glimmer said flatly.

"What?" Glimmer turned her head up, the unfamiliar sight of a despondent look upon her face. C'yra had only ever seen her angry, calm, or in some few cases, content before.

"The Witch King. I gave him all I had. But he shrugged it off like it was nothing! All I could do was break that stupid helmet he had!" At this, she brought her free hand to the back of her neck, grabbing at that odd scar. C'yra sat down on the cot next to her, her face now serious.

"Sparkles." She said. "What happened? What did Horde Prime do?"

"Why do you want to know?" The Queen spat.

"Because I spent four years running away from what happened to me with both you and your mother's screams waking me up every other night. And something tells me you haven't even given Bow the full story." C'yra said. "Trust me Glimmer, it only gets worse the longer you go without telling someone. And it took Gandalf pretty much dying to get me to do it. I'd rather not have it come to something like that in your case." Glimmer looked at her again, shocked.

“I think that’s the first time you’ve actually called me by my name.”

“I only do it when I’m dead serious.”

“Fine.” Glimmer said, taking a deep breath. “After Prime kidnapped me, he soon realized just who I was and started to refer to me as a guest, even if I was anything but. Things escalated as the weeks went on and I became less and less cooperative with him. It took me sending off a distress signal to the others and trying to escape, but his patience won out. Now that he knew She-Ra was coming for him, and me, he decided to use me as a tool to throw Adora off. Implanted a chip in the back of my neck, I still don’t know exactly how it worked but it linked me to his hive mind of clones and I spent the next who knows how long getting used as a puppet. Even after we killed him and saved the universe, I still kept hearing his voice in my head. So I tried to drown it out, pictured every single bad guy I fought since was him, hoping to beat it away.”

“But it didn’t?”

“It kept getting worse. Especially after we confronted Saruman. He sounded so much like Prime. So I fought like Hell against the first minion of Sauron’s that I could who was scary enough, and he shattered my staff like he was breaking a toothpick.”

“Why didn’t you tell anyone?”

“I didn’t want to bother them.”

“Glimmer, stuff like this is part of what our friends are there for in the first place! If it weren’t for the Fellowship, I’d still be running around up North being a depressed sad sack in between getting drunk and killing monsters. How could you know if you’d be a bother to others if you don’t ask? Bow and Adora care for you, and from what I’ve seen, they’ve been wanting to help you for some time now. But they can only do that if you want them to. Hiding your pain gets you nowhere. You’ve been in their corner for

years. Let them be in yours. And you don't have just them anymore either. You've got me and the rest of the guys now. We've got to look out for each other." There was a silence as Glimmer beheld her, the words sinking in.

"Who are you and what did you do to Catra?" C'yra burst out laughing. That one was actually pretty funny.

"Let's start over." She said. "Hi, I'm C'yra Halfmoon, I volunteered to help a Hobbit throw a magic Ring into a volcano, went on an epic road trip, found a set of adoptive brothers, and eventually decided that Catra was a total bitch, so I threw her into a river and turned my life around."

"You left out quite a few things." Aragorn said from in front of them. "But yes, that is an accurate summary of what happened." Their eyes shot up to him.

"Aragorn, we were kind of having a heart to heart here." C'yra said.

"How long has he been standing there?" Glimmer asked.

"Long enough." Aragorn said. "I wanted to make sure that you would still be ready to talk to your friends in case C'yra ended up putting her foot in her mouth."

"Well she didn't." Glimmer said. "If anything the fact that it was her made me pay more attention for once."

"There's way better ways to get me back for the Bedroll Incident you know." C'yra snarked to the Ranger.

"The what?" Glimmer asked incredulously, reaching up to take her bandage off.

"I'll tell you later." C'yra said, noticing the fresh scar on the Queen's brow. "Whoa. That definitely looks permanent. Guess we're both extra hot now, huh?"

“You’re never going to let that one go, are you?”

“Only until I stop finding it funny.” Glimmer gave a noncommittal harumph at that and reached for the head of her father’s broken staff, pulling out the gem that had been inserted in it. She eyed it curiously for a while and then stood before putting it in one of her belt pouches.

“Still, I am a bit sore that I couldn’t give the Witch King a piece of my mind.”

“Oh, about that. I think you’re either gonna be really jealous of Eowyn or want to kiss her now.”

“Why’s that?”

“If Merry was telling the truth about what he saw, she apparently killed him by stabbing his lack of face.” Glimmer’s eyes widened, and she thought for a bit.

“I’m so buying us drinks once this is all over.”

“That works too.”

“Alright then. I have a lot to tell Adora and Bow now. Better do that sooner rather than later.” Glimmer said with a shaky sigh. “Where is Bow anyway? I haven’t seen him since we came into the tent.” At this, Aragorn stroked his chin. Was C’yra seeing things or was he looking awkward about something?

“I may have charged him with removing the city’s Warden from the Houses of Healing.” Aragorn admitted.

“Honestly, that’s a pretty weird order for your first one as King.” C’yra said as she stood find where she might next make herself useful. “Not that I’m complaining. We can actually get some work done now.”

“Yeah.” Glimmer scoffed, amazed that she was still actually AGREEING with C’yra. “That guy’s a real douche.”

Some time later, Glimmer sat cross legged upon the tallest tower she could find in the city. The Shadow of Mordor had retreated from the lands, and the moon shone down upon the White City once more. In her left hand she held the sky blue oval shaped gem she had taken from her broken staff, and the white branch laid before her. Her thoughts drew back to during the battle, as she walked across the Fountain Courtyard hoping that the others had gotten to Faramir in time. As she passed by the White Tree, an errant wind had managed to blow a weaker branch of the dead plant off, where it clattered to the courtyard ground as she passed by. Glimmer did not understand it at the time, and to be honest she still didn't, but something had possessed her to pick the branch up. The light of the moon reflected in the gem she held, and she absentmindedly brought her right hand up to the lavender colored one that hung from her right ear, a keepsake of her mother. She detached it and held it up and next to the other gem. Then her gaze turned down to the branch. Her eyebrows lifted in fascination as an odd feeling came over her. Is this what Adora had meant when she said Arda itself was speaking to her?

Reaching down, she placed the two gems in the small collection of twigs that made up the thinner end of the branch, then cupped her right hand over it, grabbing the body of the branch with her left. With a determined look on her face, Glimmer closed her eyes and concentrated her power.

A change in the wind came over the land of Gondor, and as far as Osgiliath, one could see a small speck of glowing pink light grow ever larger and brighter before exploding quite brilliantly. All without a sound.

Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon stood. Clutched in her hand was a now much longer and polished length of pure white wood, bearing

a streak of dark lavender that twirled around the shaft of it before leading to a small knotted bramble of twigs at the tip, arranged in a formation resembling a wisp of smoke blowing backwards. Just underneath the bramble, the two gems from both of her parents had been slotted into the bottom of the new staff's head, side by side. Glimmer gazed upon them one last time as she tested the staff's weight.

"I always had you with me." She said to herself. "And I have all my friends now." She looked off into the distance, over the mountains where the fires and lightning of Mordor still rumbled.

"But Sauron's all alone. We can do this."

The Return of the King Part VII

The Last Debate

"WHAT DO YOU MEAN THERE'S EVEN MORE ORCS?!" Glimmer shouted as she, Adora, and Bow made their way to the throne room of Minas Tirith to convene and plan the next move.

"Gandalf said all the forces from the last battle were either in Osgiliath already or came from Minas Morgul." Bow said. "There's no way Sauron would keep all his forces there, and Mordor's a pretty big place."

"Then what the Hell are we gonna do?" Glimmer said as they reached the door to the throne room's hall. "If Frodo and Sam are still alive, and still moving, then they'll hit Mordor's mainland any day now and have to sneak past a practical ocean of monsters. We need a plan like, yesterday!"

"Don't look at me." Adora said. "C'yra's the strategist."

The entire Fellowship, sans Merry and Pippin had gathered and Gandalf had officially brought everyone up to speed on Frodo and Sam's last truly known progress.

"I've sent him to his death." Gandalf finished mournfully. The others looked expectantly at C'yra as the Best Friend Squad entered the room, Glimmer's new staff rhythmically clacking on the floor as she walked.

"Why's everyone looking at me right now?" The Magicat asked. "I'm totally stumped." Glimmer's jaw dropped.

"You've gotta be fucking kidding me."

“Well, what else do you expect from me?” C’yra said. “The best plan I could ever think of to take care of Sauron is actually happening, and even then it’s looking like a shot in the dark.” To herself, C’yra wondered what the look upon Boromir’s face would be had he lived to see this. The early days of getting to know him had been underneath the heavy cloud of their first meeting/disagreement at the Council of Elrond.

“At least Sauron doesn’t know they’re coming.” Bow said.

“Bow is correct.” Legolas said. “The enemy still thinks that we have the Ring. That alone appears to be our main advantage.”

“So he’s just waiting for us to make a move then.” Adora said.

“Let him stay there!” Gimli’s voice echoed through the hall from where he sat and smoked in the Steward’s chair. “Let him rot! Why should we care.”

“Because Gimli,” C’yra said. “We still have the odds stacked against us in the order of upwards of I’d say at least five hundred thousand malice wrought death machines standing between Frodo, Sam, and Mount Doom. And that’s not even counting the chance that he decides to relieve the remaining eight Wraiths from active war duty so they can seek the Ring again. You did say they feel its presence at all times, right Gandalf?”

“Yes.” The White Wizard answered. “His focus on the war at hand has thankfully been a saving grace in that department.”

“It’s a good thing that Hobbits are at least quite good at sneaking around.” Adora said. “Luck may be enough on their side to slip past all the Orcs.”

“There is another problem.” Glimmer said. “The Great Eye himself. If he sees all, who’s to tell when he’ll notice two guys who clearly aren’t Orcs walking up to his volcano?”

“He sees all,” Aragorn said, nodding. “And at the same time, too much. What if we rode out to confront him?” What followed would

have been quite possibly the biggest silence in the history of Middle-Earth, if it were not for Gimli choking on his own smoke.

“Aragorn,” Bow said. “Be honest with us. Did you happen to take a large hit to the head during the last battle?”

“And gain a death wish in the process?” Glimmer added.

“I know well the danger we would be riding toward, but it would keep Sauron’s eye firmly focused on us, and buy Frodo and Sam time.”

“As much time as we could.” C’yra muttered, going over it in her head.

“A diversion.” Legolas stated.

“Yes Legolas,” Adora said, more than a little concerned now. “That’s what they’re called.” There was another round of silence as the entire group mulled over Aragorn’s proposal.

“Certainty of death!” Gimli declared. “Small chance of success! What are we waiting for?!” Everyone exchanged a few glances between each other. C’yra’s face began to brighten up, and her demeanor became oddly cheery.

“You know what? I love this plan!” She exclaimed, throwing her hands out to her sides. “I’m excited to be a part of it! Let’s do it!” And with that she began to walk out the hall.

“Come on babe, let’s get our stuff ready.” Adora looked to everyone else, and just shrugged before following C’yra out. The rest stood still until the doors closed behind the pair.

“When did they become official?” Bow asked.

“What would you say to the suggestion that it was right after one of them had to save the other after she did something stupid?” Glimmer said.

“I would say that you are remarkably perceptive.” Aragorn said.

“It’s been five years since I’ve known them. Everything has changed, but it’s always the same shit with those two.”

“Kinda makes you wonder though. If we got sent here when we did for a reason.” Bow thought out loud. Aragorn, Legolas, Gimli, and Gandalf all joined him in assuming a ponderous demeanor. Glimmer caught wind of it immediately.

“Oh no! I got enough of this existential philosophical crap from that little green guy we met a year ago!” Glimmer said, holding her staff over her head. “I’m gonna get OUR stuff ready!” She slammed her staff to the floor, and disappeared in a great puff of smoke and sparkles.

Adora walked into the small, yet cozy room that she had been staying with C’yra in since they had arrived in the city. The Magicat in question was flitting back and forth, making sure everything was ready for the ride ahead. C’yra then slumped onto the bed once she was done, and Adora sat next to her. As she did, she pulled C’yra into a gentle embrace.

“You can act as excited as you want, but I could feel you tensing up from out in the hallways.” Adora said. C’yra looked forward and gave a grim smile.

“I think this could really be it this time ‘Dor.” She said. “We’re not gonna make it out of this.”

“I think you might be right.”

“I’m… I’m really glad you guys came here.” C’yra said. “If I’m gonna die, there’s no one I’d rather do it with than my family. All of you.”

“And if only some of us make it out, they’ll probably just end up naming their kids after us anyway.”

"Ugh. By the ancestors, I hope not. The last thing we need around here is a little C'yra running around causing trouble."

"She'd have a lot to live up to in that regard." They both gave a little chuckle at that.

"Well then. I don't know about you, but if this is gonna be the last time I get to be in an actual bed, I'd like to make the most of it."

"I couldn't agree more."

The night came to pass. At dawn, the Free Peoples of Middle-Earth would ride to meet their fate.

The Black Gate Opens

The road to Mordor's gates was paradoxically long and all too short. Past the ruin of Osgiliath and into the barely living forests of Ithilien they rode, and the land eventually became all the more barren as they went.

On the morning of the third day out, C'yra caught a whiff of the most oppressive stench she had smelt since she was a small child.

"Ugh, does anyone else smell that?" She groaned, having to hold her nostrils.

"Just barely." Adora said. "It's like someone left the Fright Zone's sewers to rot for a couple hundred years." Bow sniffed the air intently.

"I think we're getting close to a swamp." He said.

"Aye lad." Gimli said. "This is close to where one of our original roads to Mordor would have taken us. With luck, this path will avoid the bog."

“It’s worse than any swamp I’ve been near!” Glimmer said, her nose wrinkling.

“Yeah, there’s only a few things in existence that could make a stink like that.” Adora said gravely. Aragorn spoke next, having caught the implication of her words.

“The marshes we are near were close to the site of a great battle during the Last Alliance of the Second Age. Man, Elf, and Orc alike are entombed within the treacherous bog. I’ve had to navigate through there myself once, in pursuit of Gollum.”

“And I’m guessing you have no intention of going back?” C’yra asked, more of a statement than a question.

“And that would be the first time I have ever heard an understatement from you, C’yra.”

“Yeesh.” The Magicat breathed. “Really bad then. Figures though, that a Dark Lord would choose to live close to something as rotted as him.” Not much else was said for the rest of the journey, until they came upon the Black Gates themselves.

The Gates were built into the mountain range surrounding Mordor’s borders, a pair of great towers wrought from blackened iron, from which the equally imposing doors made from the same material swung. Or at least they would be, if the Gates had not been shut. The small army of able-bodied Rohirrim and Gondorians beheld the massive structure, and after a while, Aragorn, Eomer, Gandalf, and the rest of the Fellowship rode forward with their standard bearers.

“I don’t know why exactly,” C’yra said to herself and Adora. “But I’m getting this odd feeling that Sauron’s compensating for something.” Up close, the Gates were all the more imposing, reaching to the sky with their wicked, spiked spires. If anyone’s nerves threatened to get the better of them, all present managed

to fight them back. Aragorn looked upwards, trying to discern the shape of any manning the Gates.

"Let the Lord of the Black Lands come forth!" Aragorn challenged. "Let Justice be done upon Him!!!" After a small pause, C'yra decided to say her piece at this time as well.

"COME ON YOU GREAT FLAMING ASSHOLE!!! WE KNOW YOU'RE IN THERE!!!"

"Oh." Glimmer said. "That'll get his attention for sure."

"And the attention of every other being in Mordor that possesses ears I'd imagine." Legolas added. With that, there was a tremendous creak as the Gates opened only the smallest crack necessary to allow a horse and rider to come through. And a horse and rider did.

Black were his robes, and black was the spired helmet that covered all but his mouth. This was appropriate, as the figure that rode toward the company was tasked with acting as that feature in the Dark Lord's stead. The messenger of the Tower of Bara-dur he was. And the reaction to the sight of him was a mixture of confusion, interest, and disgust. As he rode closer, C'yra could tell without a doubt that whatever he was now, he had started as a Man.

"My Master, Sauron the Great bids thee welcome." The Mouth spoke, and as he did several lesions opened up and widened all around his lips. The very words he spoke in service of the Great Eye so dark and repulsive that they had cracked them, and putrefied his teeth. The very sight of it all gave the company pause.

"Is there any in this lot worthy to treat with me?" The Mouth then asked, apparently unimpressed by the party he had met with.

C’yra gave him another once over, then spoke up.

“And what play into this ridiculous display of pageantry that your master decided to put on to show how hopeless we are? We were quite aware of that long before we even set out in the first place! So how about you turn your overdressed ass around and go tell Sauron that we don’t have the time for any of his theatrics.”

“So this is the best you could produce?” The Mouth asked, almost shocked. “A mongrel that would ride as if she were human?”

“That’s rich coming from the one that willingly betrayed his entire people. Tell me, what did the self proclaimed Lord of the Rings promise you in return for parading around in his stead? By the looks of it, it sure wasn’t worth it!”

“Silence!” Gandalf interrupted. “For all your perceptiveness C’yra, your desire to disarm the enemy with words could very well play into his hands regardless. We do not come to treat with Sauron, faithless and accursed. Tell your master this, the Armies of Mordor must disband, he is to depart these lands never to return!”

‘I don’t think we’re really in a position to be making demands,’ Glimmer thought. ‘But it’s worth a shot I guess.’

“Ah, Old Greybeard.” The Mouth said. “I have a token I was bidden to show thee.” From within his saddlebag, the Mouth brought forth a small gleaming shirt of chainmail. At the instant recognition of it, C’yra let out a gasp.

“Frodo…” Pippin whispered in dread, and the Mouth carelessly threw the mithril shirt at Gandalf, who caught it.

“Frodo!” Pippin exclaimed once more.

“No!” Declared Merry.

“Keep quiet!” C’yra shouted. “Don’t give him anything!”

“She’s right!” Adora said. “All he had was the mail shirt, that alone can’t serve as full proof! What would have stopped him from showing a severed head?!” As she finished, Aragorn ushered Brego forward.

“And who is this?” The Mouth inquired. “Isildur’s Heir? It takes more to make a King than a broken Elvish blade!” The Mouth wouldn’t get the chance to follow that up, as Aragorn drew his sword and beheaded the Mouth as he spoke!

“I guess that concludes negotiations.” Gimli said as the Mouth’s body fell to the ground and his horse cantered off to places unknown.

“I do not believe it!” Aragorn declared. “I will not!”

“Did we just… Commit a war crime?” Bow asked.

“Our opponent is literally an undead, otherworldly Necromancer that used to be the servant of a primordial Evil, Bow.” C’yra said. “I’m pretty sure war crimes don’t really apply to our situation.”

“And let’s be honest.” Glimmer said. “Isn’t the term ‘war crime’ a bit redundant?”

“One thing’s for sure.” Adora said. “We’ve definitely made him angry now.” The Gates began to open once more, and the entire party turned their horses around, rejoining their army and all dismounting with the exception of Aragorn, who began to pace Brego back and forth across their front line. From behind the Black Gates came not an army, not a swarm, and not even a horde, but a group of legions upon legions of Orcs. In droves they poured out from Mordor, almost completely surrounding the small army of the Free Peoples.

“C’yra,” Adora asked upon seeing the Magicat’s reaction. “Are you okay?”

“As okay as I can be. I knew we’d be outnumbered, but that’s a lot more than I thought there’d be.”

“Never thought I’d die fighting side-by-side with an Elf.” Gimli thought out loud. Legolas turned down to him.

“What about side by side with a friend?” Gimli looked up and smiled.

“Aye. I could do that.”

“It’s not a bad way to go out.” Bow said.

“Yeah.” C’yra responded. “If we are going to go down fighting, there’s no better way to go.” Aragorn looked to the assembled army, while they were still holding their ground, that courage was hanging from a frayed thread. He set his face and began to speak.

“Sons of Gondor! Of Rohan! My brothers and sisters! I see in your eyes the same fear that would take the heart of me! A day may come when the courage of Men fails, when we forsake our friends and break all bonds of Fellowship, but it is not this day!

An hour of wolves, and shattered shields when the Age of Men comes crashing down, but it is not this day! This day, we fight! By all that you hold dear on this good earth, I bid you stand Men of the West!”

He held Andúril aloft, Brego reared up with a whinny, and as one, the entire army drew their weapons! Aragorn dismounted, and took his place at the head of the front line. In the far distance, atop the dark tower of Barad-dur, the light from a great sinister lidless eye, wreathed in dark arcane flame, bore down upon them. If anything else, the plan at least was apparently working. Aragorn paused for a long while as the Orc ranks completed their formation, gazing upon the army and Dark Lord before him. C’yra slightly lowered her blade, looking to her brother-in-arms questioningly with the rest of the Fellowship and Best Friend Squad. He looked back, and gave the smallest of nods.

“For Frodo.”

He turned on his heel, and with a great cry, charged headlong into battle! A couple seconds later, the rest followed, and then the army behind them!

“ARAGORN!!!” C’yra shouted in mad laughter. “DON’T JUST GO RUNNING IN BY YOURSELF YOU CRAZY BASTARD!!!”

I do not think, even if I lived well into the first century of my life, I could find the proper words to describe the true chaos of the battle that followed. Not even the accounts from the Red Book of Westmarch, the journals of House Halfmoon, or the songs dedicated to this conflict as told in the Sagas of the Traveller’s Tales were enough to muster the proper dictation to bring full illumination to the sheer havoc wrought before the Black Gates. What I could find though, were the specific experiences of the Heroes that fought that day.

“Has anyone seen Merry or Pippin?!” Adora shouted, even though she towered over most Orcs as She-Ra, the battlefield had become much too crowded to find the Hobbits.

“Glimmer and I can find them!” Bow responded as he managed to slay two Orcs with a single arrow. “We’ll watch their backs!” Glimmer nodded, and waded through the fighting to her left with Bow following. Though faintly, she was sure she had heard a call of “over here”!

“C’yra! Adora!” Legolas called. “Gimli and I are at your side!” The First One and Magicat had begun to fight back to back, and adjusted their position to allow the Elf and Dwarf to complete a circle! There was no counting of kills to be heard, for the first time in a long while for any of the four, they were fighting for their lives.

“Hey! C’yra!” Adora said, managing to turn as much as she could to C’yra. “If we make it out of this alive, will you marry me?!”

“This is NOT the time for this, Adora!!!” C’yra shouted back, somehow managing to sound amazed at her nerve.

“What are you talking about? This is the perfect time for this!”

“Yeah, if you’ve totally lost your mind! Guys, back me up here!”

“I’m going to have to agree with Adora on this one C’yra!” Gimli shouted. “This may very well be your last chance!”

“WHAT?!”

“Agreed!” Legolas said, firing another volley. “In fact, I believe that I might have the authority to officiate a wedding where we stand! Although, we would have to hope that our friends have not yet perished, and regroup with them so that Gimli wouldn’t be the sole witness!”

“What about the Orcs?” Adora asked, parrying and counter attacking. “There’s definitely enough of them!”

“I don’t think they’d be interested!” The Dwarf observed.

“Oh, ancestors help me!” C’yra shouted to herself. “Sparkles and Arrow Boy had still better be taking this seriously!”

Pippin had just barely managed to pull himself out from under the hand of the great Troll that he had slit the throat of after it had grabbed him.

“Too close!” He exclaimed as a worried Merry helped him up. They looked forward, and a very large Orc spotted them. The Orc bellowed and made to rush them down, only to be blasted to the side by one of Glimmer’s magic bolts!

“Merry! Pippin!” Glimmer greeted as she and Bow took positions near them, looking a little too excited to still be in the thick of the chaos. “Bow and I are getting married!!!” The Hobbits stood in

shock, and exchanged a glance. In unison, they said the only thing that could come to their minds.

“Congratulations?!”

The battle seemed to last forever with no sign of change in sight. C’yra was sure that she had seen Aragorn locked in a duel with a heavily armored Troll, but had trouble finding him again. That was when she heard it. That damned unmistakeable shriek. She glanced skyward, and was met with the arrival of the remaining eight of the Nine.

“Ah Hell! I forgot about those creeps!” Before any one of the Nazgûl could press an attack however, a series of great, brown blurs rocketed overhead from the other direction, colliding midair with the Fell Beasts!

“The Eagles!” Pippin cried as he looked to the sky. “The Eagles are coming!” Sure enough, the Great Eagles had come to aid the Free Peoples. But C’yra was beginning to fear that it wouldn’t be enough. Any sense of how long the battle had gone on escaped her, and she hadn’t felt this tired in ages. A great, deafening roar rumbled from within the land of Mordor, and the Nazgûl inexplicably turned back! C’yra was body checked by an Orc, and all around her she saw her family and allies fading. Slowly, she struggled to her hands and knees, not noticing the faint growl coming from her sword. However, she could have sworn that the hilt was beginning to heat up as if it had been dropped into a forge.

In a daze of weariness and confusion, C’yra looked into the ruby slotted into the crossguard and blade of the Sword of Omens, and watched as the slitted eye within awakened before her! There was a bright flash of light, and she was no longer kneeling on the ground outside the Black Gates of Mordor. She was standing.

As for where she was, she had little idea, as the brilliant light around her slowly faded to reveal the grand hall of an unknown throne room. A banner hung over the throne, bearing the same symbol etched into the cover of her mother's journal. The light had cleared out enough to see everything, yet had not retreated entirely as it still poured in through the great windows on either side.

"Am I… Dead?"

"No, you are not." Boomed a jovial voice from behind. "At least not yet anyway." C'yra turned around and watched as a tall, broad shouldered figure walked out of the light and into the room, passed by her and regarded the throne before them before turning to her. C'yra's eyes widened.

The man before here was just as much both beast and man as she was, though of a lighter fur and a long red mane draping past his shoulders. He was around six feet and two inches in height, and wore quite ancient looking ornate garments that toed the line between battle armor and formal wear. Resting upon his head was a circlet slotted with a red gem in the center. The circlet terminated downwards at both sides of his face as if to add some modicum of protection. The great blue cloak on his shoulders was clasped with a brooch bearing a matching symbol to the banner.

"All the same, it is good to know that our people yet endure, even though we are scattered." C'yra looked the man up and down and understood.

"So I'm assuming that you're a long-gone Magicat King then?" She asked.

"Yes." He said. "And of the other tribes of Thundera. In fact, I was to be the third to last before we were forced to abandon our planet and seek other worlds. You may be wondering why I specifically appeared before you, and not the last?"

"It may have crossed my mind."

“It is quite simple, I was the last of my line to fully awaken the secrets of the Sword of Omens.” He said, gesturing to the sword that was still in C’yra’s hand. “I spent the most time using it. Both in the defense of our people and those that we would call our friends. As such, I still have enough of a connection to it to appear before its current master should things turn dire.”

“Some master I am.” C’yra scoffed. “You’re a King! And just by looking at this thing, I can tell it was made with Kings and Queens in mind. My mother just found it by random chance at a dig site and managed to send it to Arda before the Horde could get a hold of it. The blasted thing barely even listens to me.” The King chuckled.

“From what I’ve seen, you’ve had a better go at it than I did. It was almost a full year before I was able to use Sight Beyond Sight. And you were able to summon the blade to your hand on the first try! You are only partially right C’yra Halfmoon. Yes, the Eye of Thundera was forged into the Sword of Omens to serve the Royal Line of our people, but it is not an exclusive weapon. In case you haven’t noticed, our Royal Line is much more extinct than that of your adoptive brother-in-arms. Any Thunderan, no matter where they came from or their lot in life can use the Sword and gain access to its powers as long as it deems them of heroic enough spirit. It just took a while for the Sword to wake back up after centuries of lying dormant. You have as much a right to wield it as even the most revered of our old Heroes.”

“So is that why you’re here now?” C’yra asked. “Field promoting me to the next Queen?” The old King gave a peal of hearty laughter.

“No, my appearing before you has more to do with the innate connection the Magicat tribe has to the plane of our ancestors. Though you are not the most spiritual individual yourself, and understandably so, we have been able to look down on our people nonetheless. Admittedly though, you have been the loudest. And most entertaining. Panthro in particular finds the cut of your jib to be quite amusing. That being said, your current possession of the

Sword of Omens does entitle you to reclaiming the throne and starting the Lordship of Thundera anew, but what you choose to do with the sword is your choice alone. There is a time and a place for all things, and it may yet not be the time for our people to retake our world. In fact, it may never be."

"Reuniting the Thunderans would imply that the sword and its bearer do live to see the sunrise. Even if I were to just pass it on." C'yra said.

"Ah yes." The King said. "Your current Dark Lord problem. We had our own to deal with in my time. Blessedly, ours was a lot less competent, and lucky for that matter. But regardless, Sauron is just like any self proclaimed Dark Lord before him or who will come after. I have watched our people though the ancestral plane for nearly a thousand years now, and I have noticed something. More often than not, evil brings about its own defeat, whether from those who would oppose it, or from within itself."

"That might be all well and good, but it sure as shit doesn't change the fact we're really out of time. He wouldn't have called off those spooks in bathrobes without a reason. And if I remember correctly, I was practically dead on my feet before the ruby flash-banged me."

"Indeed. That was the primary reason why I called out to you in fact. The Sword has one last feature that your mother was unfortunately not able to uncover in her research of the old tales." He placed a hand on her head. "This secret I will impart onto you now, when your need is at its greatest."

"Well, I've learned not to question gifts from ancient people who have no issues looking into the minds of others." C'yra said. "So thanks I guess. Your Highness."

"Please," The King said. "Call me Lion-O. Now go on, C'yra Halfmoon, to the aid of your family and friends, and may we meet later in the afterworlds beyond!" The Eye of Thundera glowed to a

blinding flash once more, and C'yra found herself back where she had been, kneeling on the ground.

She gave a quick glance around the battlefield, the army of the Free Peoples was really starting to fade fast. Aragorn lay pinned beneath the foot of a Troll, Legolas struggled in vain to aid him. She-Ra was being overwhelmed by a pack of Goblins that had seen fit to treat her like a jungle gym, and even more enemies were closing in. C'yra tightened her grip on her sword and balled her free hand into a fist. She grit her teeth and stood. 'Here goes nothing.' She held the Sword of Omens outstretched from her with one hand and began to swing it about.

"THUNDER…

THUNDER…

THUNDER…

THUNDERCATS HO!!!!"

She thrust the blade to the sky, and the Eye of Thundera within the sword changed from its usual slit eye to the symbol that hung on the banner above the throne! That very symbol, a great black silhouette of a roaring wildcat facing to the left upon a circular ruby background appeared in the sky above C'yra in the form of a spectral beacon!

All around the battlefield, anyone who would ally with a Child of Thundera that saw the beacon felt their energy well up within them as if the battle had only just begun! As for the enemy, they cowered, and appeared to be knocked back as if by some otherworldly force!

Reinvigorated, Aragorn fought back the Troll attacking him and stuck it down! He held Andúril aloft!

"Press on my friends!!!" He bellowed. "Elendil!!!"

“Gúthwinë!” Eomer shouted. “Gúthwinë for Rohan!!!”

“For the Shire!!!” Declared Merry and Pippin as one.

“For Mirkwood!!!” Legolas exclaimed.

“For those that fell in Moria!” Gimli hollered. “Baruk Khazâd!!! Khazâd ai-mênu!!!”

“For Eternia!!!” She-Ra yelled, charging forward. “For Greyskull!!!”

“For Brightmoon!!!” Cried Glimmer, charging up a spell of blinding light.

“For Etheria!!!” Declared Bow, drawing a firework arrow. The arcane energy still flowing through her, for once in her life bringing her power instead of pain, C’yra couldn’t help but let out a cheesy smile.

“For Thundera!!!”

And so, with a great cheer, one last effort was made! Glimmer slammed her staff into the ground, a great magical wave of flowing in all directions, as soon as the wave made contact with a servant of the enemy, be it Orc, Goblin, Warg, or Troll, all disintegrated into clouds of dust that billowed away with the force of the wind, leaving the allied army unharmed! They ran forward to meet those out of the spell’s range! Gimli and Legolas worked in tandem to fell a Troll, Bow fired his arrow to explode against an oncoming pack of Wargs! Merry and Pippin became a cyclone of blades, Aragorn and Gandalf beat back a squadron each! C’yra and She-Ra fought as one, tearing through all in their way!

The Forces of Mordor were briefly cowed, but they knew this second wind would not last, the numbers of the Dark Lord were too many. They were the greatest and largest force in all of Middle-Earth!

But that's just the thing about size, isn't it? It is understandable that many would find the greatest size possible to be the most desirable, the most effective. But the thing is, sometimes, it is the smallest of things, of creatures, of people. They are the ones that make the biggest difference.

And that is what the Dark Lord Sauron realized all too late as something very small, and very precious, melted away like a bar of chocolate over a campfire.

Another great bellow resounded from the Great Eye. But this was not one of triumph, but one of shock and pain. Every last combatant stopped dead where they were, and turned their eyes to the tower of Barad-dur as the sound continued on, and the flames of the Eye spat out in every direction. There was a low rumble, then a great cracking noise as the tower began to fall, its structure shattering like a glass cylinder being crushed beneath a great weight! The armies of Mordor did a double take in pure terror, and then ran for the hills as the Great Eye shrank in on itself then exploded out, decimating the rest of the tower and sending the lands of Mordor itself into a great earthquake and upheaval! Even the mighty Black Gates began to fall! The Fellowship was just as shocked, until Merry's face lit up in joy as he thrust his blade into the air!

"Frodo!!! Frodo!!!" The rest of the Fellowship followed in relief and triumph. And then, Mount Doom itself began to explode. Their faces all fell, except for Gandalf, who made eye contact with one of the Great Eagles, then called for Glimmer mount the one near her as he flew off on the leader.

"I swear to all the ancestors watching." C'yra said, desperation mixed with hope. "You'd better find them, Gandalf."

The Return of the King Part VIII

The Fourth Age Begins

With some great effort, Frodo Baggins managed to drag himself out of sleep. Briefly, he considered the possibility that he was dead, but quickly disregarded it. If he were dead, he figured, then he wouldn't be this sore. Adding to that was the distinct sensation of a bandage around his right hand, and the feel of a bed beneath him. Frodo doubted that any afterlife would have need or use for such things.

Still, wherever he was, it was almost unbearably bright. The morning sun shone through the windows behind him onto polished walls of white stone. Then, he questioned his status once more as he beheld the figure before him.

"Gandalf?" He asked, beginning to sit up in his bed. In turn, the Wizard could only smile, and began to laugh, just like when they had met on the road such a long time ago before Bilbo's birthday. And what could Frodo do but laugh in pure joy as well?

The door to Frodo's room opened, and through it came Merry and Pippin, cheering out as they ran to embrace their cousin. As Merry and Pippin celebrated on the bed at Frodo's sides, Gimli was next to arrive.

"Gimli!" Frodo exclaimed in greeting, as the Dwarf gave a cheer of his own, Legolas crossed the threshold.

"And Legolas!" Frodo said, next Aragorn entered. "Aragorn! Have we all made it?" The Hobbit got his answer as C'yra entered with the biggest and most genuine smile Frodo had ever seen her give.

"Catra!" Frodo greeted, and for once, C'yra did not even feel the slightest urge to correct someone calling her by her discarded name. And she began to give out an uproarious laugh of her own, much to the surprise of the assembled Fellowship. Frodo paid this

new occurrence only brief attention though, as Samwise Gamgee stepped into the room. The two Hobbits shared a meaningful look.

They had done it.

The Fountain Courtyard of Minas Tirith was packed to near discomfort for the Coronation of King Elessar Telcontar, High King of Gondor and Arnor. No longer wearing their usual armor and traveling clothes, the four travelers that had come from Etheria to Middle-Earth had all been given proper formal wear according to their color schemes. Although, C'yra had been quite insistent that her Elven cloak remained upon her shoulders, proudly keeping it on as a symbol of her newfound family of choice. That being said, it was hard to miss the shine of the new buckle at her belt, bearing a perfect recreation of the symbol shown by the Eye of Thundera. Gimli knew that it was the same sigil imprinted upon the journal of C'yra's mother, and had seen fit to craft the new buckle as soon as they had returned from the Black Gates. While C'yra may have argued that the leaf-shaped brooches were more of a signifier of herself and those she held dear, she supposed that the symbol of her people fit her just as well, and accepted the gift with a smile.

Aragorn knelt before Gandalf as the Wizard placed the crown upon his head. Gimli watched on from where he had stood as the bearer of the article.

"Now come the days of the King!" Gandalf announced as Aragorn stood and the crowd applauded. "And may they be blessed." Aragorn turned to speak to the assembled crowd.

"This day does not belong to one Man, but to all." The King announced. "Let us together rebuild this world, that we may share in the days of Peace." The crowd let out another round of applause and cheers, and a light snow of white petals was dropped into the courtyard from above. Aragorn began to walk

forward, and as he did, he began to sing for his friends and people. The words of which were known as Elendil's Oath:

"Et Eärello Endorenna utúlien.

Sinome maruvan ar Hildinyar tenn' Ambar-metta"

Which, in the Common Tongue is:

"Out of the Great Sea to Middle-Earth I am come.

In this place I will abide, and my heirs, unto the ending of the world."

The King walked amongst the crowd to formally greet them, Faramir of the House of Stewards with Lady Eowyn of Rohan, then her brother Eomer, the soon to be new King of Rohan, as Theoden had passed in the Battle of Pelennor. Each greeted him with a slight bow of their heads, then began to follow him along with Gandalf and Gimli. The procession came to C'yra, Adora, Glimmer, and Bow next, and they followed suit. Although Aragorn could not help but be curious at the conspiratoral glint to C'yra's eyes. Legolas had a similar look about him as Aragorn reached his friend next. Lord Elrond was behind him, and standing next to him was someone veiled by the very banner that they had sailed under after taking the ships of Umbar. The one bearing it revealed herself to be the same one who had created it, Arwen Undómiel, the Evenstar.

The King embraced his Queen and they shared a long awaited kiss at their reunion. The people began to celebrate once more.

"Get a room you two!" C'yra chuckled as she clapped, and was met with a playful elbow to her ribs from Adora. "Oof! It hurts, but it was worth it!"

As Aragorn and Arwen finished, they led the royal procession to just beyond where the now blooming White Tree sat. Before them all were Frodo, Sam, Merry, and Pippin. The four Hobbits began to bow, but were stopped by the King.

“My friends.” He said. “You bow to no-one.” And with that, he and Arwen both knelt before the Hobbits in a show of honor, and everyone else followed. C’yra had knelt before only one other in her life, back on Etheria in a disingenuous show of sycophantic loyalty with her metaphorical fingers crossed behind her back. What would Catra of the Horde of thought of C’yra Halfmoon’s genuine devotion to her friends, her brothers? Well, my opinion on the matter is the same as C’yra’s.

Who fucking cares?

And thus it was, the Fourth Age of Middle-Earth began. And the Fellowship of the Ring, though eternally bound by friendship and love, was officially ended. Well, for the most part at least…

Twenty One Years Later

The crackling of one final shift in reality came to a final halt, and seven figures found themselves upon a hill in the Kingdom of Arnor, in the far distance, one could make out the silhouette of Weathertop through the spring mist. The three youngest members of the party turned eastward in the direction of Rivendell. The trio were a group of young Magicats, clad in sturdy traveling clothes of black, green, and dark blue from the one who led the walk to the one who stayed closest to the adults they walked ahead of. Each also was draped in a cloak and hood of red, blue, and brown respectively. Despite their clear preferences in color, all bore the same red brooch as a cloak clasp, bearing the sigil of Thundera.

The eldest of the children adjusted the two mismatched sabers at their left hip as one of the younger ones made to rush past them.

“For the ancestors’ sake Mara!” Exclaimed the blonde feline. “Will you slow down? Mom and Mother said to keep close!”

“I can’t help it!” Said their sister, and the eldest of their twin siblings. Her dark blonde, almost brunette mane swung behind her as she turned, and the arrows in her quiver clattered. “Even if we got sent back to where and when we were pulled from, we can’t keep Elladan and Elrohir waiting!” The youngest of the three walked forward to match pace with his oldest sibling, leaning on his staff, and adjusting the broadsword on his right hip.

“More like she wants to boast about beating Mother, Uncle Legolas, and Uncle Gimli for actually beating them in kill counts.” The tall and strongly built brunette said. “Let her have her fun, Finn.” Finn Halfmoon turned to their brother.

“Last time we let her run off, you both got swept downriver to Lake-Town, and spent half our visit to Dale and Erebor with a fever.” Finn snarked, raising an eyebrow. “So forgive me for wanting the rest of our way to go smoothly for once Boromir!” Boromir Halfmoon’s golden eyes narrowed. He had a reputation for acting quite loopy when ill, and did not like being reminded of that fact, however indirectly.

“Peace young ones.” Spoke Legolas as he and Gimli caught up with them. “The day is still young, and we will reach the Last Homely House by evening.”

“Once the two lovebirds are done staring into space that is!” Gimli griped, although the fond tone in his voice was impossible to miss.

C’yra Halfmoon looked out westward over the lands she had wandered in the eve of her teenage years. She would have never anticipated at the time just how much this particular bit of wilderness would hold such a fond place in her heart. But then again she supposed, this is where she first spent a whole day where each meal was fulfilling and bore actual flavor, where she spent her first week and more with each breath as fresh as the one before it, where she first saw stars in the sky. Where she met the first of eight men she would eventually call her brother.

“Not even a full minute and they’re off on their next adventure.” Adora Halfmoon of House Greyskull mused, looking at her children. “They get that from you, you know.”

“And they have your knack for running to help others half-cocked and without a plan.” C’yra said. “So we’re even in passing down our annoying parts. I’m just glad we managed to avoid our unsavory ones.”

“Weren’t you complaining just a week ago about Boromir going back for seconds at lunch?”

“That has nothing to do with how much he needs to eat. It’s not his fault he’s got your stomach. I just didn’t want him to eat poor old Butterbur out of business.” Adora laughed at the memory of the look on the innkeeper’s face. She’d almost forgotten that the approximate two weeks of their latest misadventure hadn’t technically happened for the rest of the universe.

“Well, at least Finn didn’t try to drink Gimli under the table again. You’d think with their cleverness, they’d wise up to knowing their limits.”

“They’re nineteen Adora, we all did stupid things at that age. I’m just glad that they’re getting drunk instead of ripping open holes in reality.”

“The fact that you have a point with that is still as oddly hilarious as it is sad.”

“Such is life ‘Dor.” C’yra said. “You go on ahead, I’ll catch up.” As Adora left to meet with the rest of their family, C’yra turned westward once more to look over to the watchtower where her life truly began.

“Well, I’m back.”

The End.

Written by Hotshot95

Based Upon She-Ra and the Princesses of Power created by N.D. Stevenson

and

The Lord of the Rings by J.R.R. Tolkien and the Film Trilogy directed by Peter Jackson

Starring

Elijah Wood

AJ Michalka

Sir Ian McKellen

Liv Tyler

Viggo Mortensen

Sean Astin

Cate Blanchett

John Rhys-Davies

Bernard Hill

Christopher Lee

Billy Boyd

Dominic Monaghan

Orlando Bloom

Hugo Weaving

Miranda Otto

David Wenham

Brad Dourif

Karl Urban

John Noble

Featuring

Andy Serkis as Gollum

With

Ian Holm

Aimee Carrero

Karen Fukuhara

Marcus Scribner

and Sean Bean

Appendices

Appendices Part I: Behind the Scenes

The Lord of the Rings is but one small part of an almost ridiculously large collection of stories, letters, and scraped together notes put down by a man who was for a large part doing it all for fun and to give a background to the languages that he was creating. As such, a lot of extra material was put into the back end of the book to further flesh out the content within, which apart from various descriptions of things, persons, and objects that were taking up the story's present, I find were left quite vague.

In addition, the film adaptations released at the turn of the 21st Century decided that they would put all their extensive behind the scenes documentation to good use, and cheekily referred to the bonus features that came with the Extended Editions of The Lord of the Rings as their own appendices. Thus were the DVD collections complete, and a certain young lad's undefeated streak in the official LotR Trivial Pursuit board game ensured.

So I figured about a week ago as of this writing, why shouldn't this story have its own? To start off, I felt that I would like to share some of my experience in writing this tale.

It started one night around March of 2023 as the concept of Tenth Walker fics drifted into my mind as I tried to get to sleep. I'm a bit of a notorious night owl you see, and I fear that my high functioning autism leaves thoughts rushing through my head at speeds that range from the swiftness of Shadowfax to Barry Allen screwing with the timeline for the umpteenth time.

At first, what would become simply The Tenth Walker started as The Tenth Walker Project, an ambitious series of crossovers wherein I would retell The Lord of the Rings with varying additions to the Fellowship's numbers as a way to hopefully leave behind at least a few more of these sorts of fics that were not

merely the obvious brainchild of a teenage girl inserting herself so she could smooze up to Orlando Bloom in a blond wig and foam latex pointy ears.

I chose Catra from She-Ra first as I felt that she was the most interesting solo candidate. My first real idea for the Project was having Luz Noceda and Amity Blight of the Owl House joining up and eventually deciding to stay in Middle-Earth, taking up residence in Isengard and becoming known as The Ladies of Orthanc. Another group of four was also considered, which would allow me to tell all of the story as opposed to just the path of Aragorn and company.

And then I had to write the Council of Elrond.

While I will always smile at the other versions of the Quest that will never be written as they come to my mind, there is no way in Hell that I'm going through this whole thing another twice and Lord knows how many times, even if I stuck to the original plan of having "vignettes" in lieu of traditional chapters.

And so, The Tenth Walker Project was sacrificed for the quality of what is now The Wildcat of Arnor series, and my profile on this site may have been saved as well from becoming a one trick Bill the pony as it were.

In setting out to hopefully breathe some new life into what is possibly the mother of all dead horses in fanfiction next to writing salacious tales regarding James T. Kirk and Mr. Spock, I had something of an epiphany, and developed a duo of guidelines on how to go about writing a Tenth Walker story in the best faith possible.

Firstly, try your best to not have the Tenth (or even Eleventh and so on), Walker steal the thunder of the rest of the Fellowship or anyone they meet. Allow them to do awesome stuff of course, but

give them their own enemies to fight and problems to solve. To paraphrase Gimli, there's plenty for everyone.

Secondly, and most importantly, when setting out to write a Tenth Walker fanfiction do not ask how the new character, be they original or part of a crossover, changes the Quest to Destroy the Ring. Ask how the Quest to Destroy the Ring changes the character. Roughly a year passes in universe during the trilogy, and a Hell of a lot happens. None of the Fellowship are static in canon, even the smallest character arc counts for something.

Speaking of which, we have Catra. Or C'yra Halfmoon if you will. Out of all the characters who could cross over into Middle-Earth, not only is she one of those who would best benefit from the Mother of All Road Trips, but she also is one who has one of the most canonically sound methods of being brought to Middle-Earth as well. I usually dislike writing fanfiction that takes place during or before a series, as I strive to keep the characters I work with as close to their canon selves as possible, and particularly how they are when their stories come to an end. It is a personal quirk of mine that I much prefer the question of what may be next as opposed to what ifs outside of the more "esoteric" types of alternate universes, like for instance, taking the cast of Star Wars and placing them on modern day Earth, or something even more out there, like making the Goonies into a team of Power Rangers.

But Catra's special like that, for as much as I do love it, I still felt that She-Ra Season Five had to rush her redemption arc a little bit in terms of how much crap she had done. That being said, it was more than likely out of the showrunners' control, and the complaint is rich shit coming from me, considering that I will forever be the one Star Wars fan you will meet that tries his damndest not to be a total dick about it, and all Anakin Skywalker had to do was throw the Multiverse's most evil senior citizen down a shaft.

The Galactic Empire's apparent habit of putting death drops very close to where people will be walking aside, the year long journey of the Fellowship and a little tweaking with the events of the

Portal on Etheira and a final four and a half years to provide a cushion for potential growing pains and inaccuracies of my writing for Catra's character proved to be a great opportunity in my mind to spend a little more time with her. Before she shifts from what I consider her canon Neutral Evil alignment, Catra starts out the fic somewhere in the neighborhood of Chaotic Neutral, and develops into the eventual Chaotic Good that almost every Heroic character I write for seems to end up as by the time I'm done with them.

As with everything, the reader's mileage will vary in terms of whether or not it works. What I was more concerned about was the snarking.

I fear that this really might not have been the best time to add such a volume of bathos to LotR as I did here. But then again, this is primarily a worry on my part regarding the subjectivity of the usage of this style of humor.

I am something of an idealist, but I am not blind. A great many people, or at least most of the Internet, is really starting to get tired of the whole snarky character saying the snarky thing, regardless of whether or not the joke lands in their subjective viewpoint. While understandable, I feel that this paradigm shift happened bizarrely fast, and with such a speed that I found a great deal of hypocrisy in the statements of those expressing the sentiment, as by my tracking of time they were singing the praises of this style of humor just mere minutes ago.

Alas, I fear that I have been saying a lot without saying nothing at all myself. So I will simply conclude it is all about having a proper balance as with everything else. And it remains, I just had one of the most snark prone animated characters of the last five years join the Fellowship of the Ring, and at the start of it she has to deal with a quartet of Hobbits with little to no outside world experience between them, a long suffering Wizard, a future King who is still pretty new to the whole being around people thing due to his nomadic lifestyle, an Elf and a Dwarf mere minutes away from throwing hands, and guy who is so gung ho that he still wants to bring the Ring to Gondor well after being told multiple

times just why that is a very bad idea. What was I supposed to do, have Catra keep her mouth shut the whole time?

That was when I remembered why I was really writing this thing. For fun. I love doing this kind of thing, and what is putting a Snark Knight in the Fellowship but an opportunity to share the stuff that goes through your head during iconic scenes and lines? That being said, I do hope my efforts to retain some sort of emotional core and treat the truly serious things that need to remain serious as such held fast. If there are those who think that the jokes in this story are bad, then I'm sorry, but that is entirely your problem.

Speaking of humor, it has long been a talking point that the film version of Gimli, Son of Gloin was made into too much of a comic relief character. While I still laugh at every instance of such events even to this day while watching the movies, I do agree it has had its consequences. So I figured one way to deal with the issue was to balance it out a bit by giving everyone something of a running gag. Especially Legolas.

I don't think that many people realize just how much potential there is in making him the butt of a joke or two. In the books, Legolas is oddly enough, the Three Hunters' source of snark, while in the films he is much more the Comically Serious. I decided to synthesize these two versions of the character, by having him be ready to engage in brotherly banter with Catra/C'yra when needed and have him be the victim of my personal favorite joke in the whole story: "The Force Captain's Promotion". Inspired by Discworld's ever popular "Hedgehog Song", and the sprinkling in of just enough detail to get the reader's imagination going in the right direction, this was in my mind the greatest comedic hurdle of the fic. If this blasted bawdy song bit falls flat, I may very well lose my entire potential readerbase. It might possibly be the stupidest thing I've ever written in my life, and believe me that's probably not saying much. I still think it is one of the best ongoing jokes I've ever put

into a story. As for Aragorn, I found that he fit surprisingly well into something of a long-suffering older brother figure for the group, and therefore the comedy synergized in my mind with the emotional core I was going for. A win on both accounts I hope.

On that note, I feel I have gone on about whether or not people may think my jokes are funny. The last bit of behind the scenes info that I felt important to note is how I decided to develop Catra herself. Outside of what was going to happen anyway regarding the opening up of her past, I wasn't expecting how much I'd take the implications of what I had chosen as Galadriel's gift to Catra and run with it. What initially started as a cheeky wink and nod to another 80's cartoon that made sense in context became something of a crux for the shift between Catra of the Horde and C'yra Halfmoon, the Wildcat of Arnor. The introduction of that journal not only gave me an excuse to do my own take on the ever intriguing riddle for the ages that is Catra's birth name, but also provided something of an exercise in how one may embrace the heritage that they never knew they had.

Of particular note is how C'yra begins to pick up a new way of swearing via the medium of Magicat/Thunderan ancestors. I found some degree of amusement when I actually began to think about my implementation of this, as I have always seen Catra as what TVTropes would call a "Nay-theist". That being, someone who upon being given proof of a higher power of any kind, decides that said power is neither worthy or deserving of worship. Considering by that time she had seen Durin's Bane for herself and had spent months traveling with Gandalf, who is basically the Middle-Eath equivalent of what we would call an angel, she would definitely know that such things exist in the universe in which she resides. So why does she still invoke her ancestors as much as she does? I then figured that she would be so open to embracing her people's culture in favor of the Horde's at this point that just about anything would stick, and I'm sure plenty of non-religious or non-spiritual people find themselves saying expressions like "Jesus Christ!" on the regular anyway. And then of course there was the

whole catchphrase thing courtesy of the Sword of Omens. I knew there was no real point in including it without doing the bit at least once, and the Battle of the Black Gates seemed like the only logical place to put it.

The addition of the Cast List at the end was something of a spur of the moment thing I felt would be nice, and is presented in its current form to simulate that the reader has just finished watching the Lord of the Rings film trilogy of an alternate universe where the She-Ra characters were present.

As for the matter of any odd inaccuracies to the sequence of certain events or speaking of certain lines, those are solely my fault, as I was writing the majority of the major events of the story relating to The Lord of the Rings through memory alone, with occasional consultations with the books and my Blu Rays of the Extended Editions.

Appendices Part II: A Shout Out to the Shout Outs

As I am a giant dork, I couldn't help but make references to the other things I love throughout the story, whether it be through borrowed dialogue or overt in universe cameos via the characters mentioning past ventures of theirs. In particular some of my personal favorite bits outside the stuff that was most obvious to come up, i.e. the existence of the rest of the Masters of the Universe franchise and the presence of Thundercats, are the titles that follow in no particular order:

Metroid

Star Wars Episode IV: A New Hope

The Legend of Zelda

Marvel: Ultimate Alliance 1

Ghostbusters

Shrek

A quite amusing Fellowship of the Ring-era fanfic I found whose title and author unfortunately escape me at the time of writing wherein the company really should have picked a better dinner conversation in retrospect

And other She-Ra fan content that I wish I had more concrete clues as to properly credit them, particularly the piece of fanart of Catra and Adora that inspired the marriage proposal during the final battle. Add the seeking out of these Easter Eggs to your unofficial Wildcat of Arnor Drinking Games at your own peril, as there may even be some things I unintentionally made a reference to!

Appendices Part III: Regarding the Children of House Halfmoon

Finn: You know them, you love them, you probably have only just been made aware of their existence as a semi-canon She-Ra character as you read this fic! Introduced in a charity livestream as little more than concept art and a few scant details regarding their personality, Finn has gone on to be so embraced that AO3 has given them their very own character tag. Not bad kid, not bad. The version of Finn briefly met in this story is therefore a spin on my own personal interpretation of them, given a required Middle-Earth twist. Of particular note is their age. Most fics I have seen regarding Finn seem to be avoiding their teen to young adult years like a plague, so of course I found much appeal in exploring how they would develop around then.

Finn Halfmoon was born three years after the destruction of the Ring and final defeat of Sauron. As the third eldest of the post War of the Ring generation (at least barring the children of Sam, Merry, and Pippin), Finn spent a great deal of their childhood in Minas Tirith, growing up alongside their honorary cousin, Eldarion

and his numerous sisters. Much to King Elessar's chagrin and Queen Arwen's amusement, Finn developed something of a talent for finding trouble at a young age, and often dragged Eldarion along with them into said trouble.

A child of three worlds, four if you count the still undiscovered whereabouts of Thundera, Finn eventually developed their mom's taste for adventure and something of a flair for the dramatic. The crux of this came to a head around their fourteenth birthday during a most hilariously ill-fated hunting trip with Aragorn and the visiting Double Trouble. After the dust had cleared, Aragorn and DT both agreed to never speak of the incident ever again. Then, with no small amount of theatricality and a shit-eating grin, Finn revealed the whole story in detail at the next Fellowship/family reunion dinner in the form of an epic poem of their own composition. This led to Finn earning the name of Tale Singer, and they were subsequently grounded-but-not-really-grounded by Adora and C'yra for the next month as a "consequence".

Finn bears a pair of saber swords, one of Magicat make recovered from the ruins of Halfmoon, and the other found in an old First One's vault on Eternia. Extensive training has left them with a particular skill in dual wielding, which combined with their acrobatic prowess makes them one of the last persons you'd want to end up in a skirmish against.

Mara: Another three years after Finn's birth, the twins came into the world. As the eldest by around twelve minutes, Mara forever reserves the right to remind her brother of this fact at the most inappropriate of moments for as long as they both shall live.

The twins' birth was cause for much celebration across the lands, and many were hopeful and praying that at least one of them would be a normal and well behaved kitten that did not delight in the making of mischief as they grew, if at least for the sake of the King's stress levels. You could imagine their surprise then, when

young Mara turned out even more of a troublemaker than her elder sibling, and Finn found themself having to be the responsible one all of the sudden.

In an effort to find a proper outlet for his niece's hyperactive nature, Legolas Greenleaf took it upon himself to instruct Mara in the art of archery, only for everyone's worst fears to become realized when the lessons only served to increase Mara's effective range. It was only after the fateful Stinkbomb Arrow Fiasco of Emyn Arnen, followed by a most terrifying dressing down from Lady Eowyn, and finally being actually-grounded-for-real-this-time by her mothers that Mara began the long road to maturing as a person. Thankfully, Faramir found the whole incident to be actually quite funny, and gave the Magicat a full pardon, even if the smell never really did go away.

As she grew, Mara Halfmoon found herself to be well regarded across Middle-Earth for her jovial nature and beauty, often drawing comparisons to Elanor Gardner the Fair, maid in waiting to Queen Arwen and her close friend. Upon Mara's coming of age, no small number of suitors sought to court her. They were driven off partly by a lack of interest on Mara's part, and mostly by the intense look of warning from Finn whenever they happened to be nearby as they not-at-all subtly wrapped their hand around the hilt of one of their swords.

Due to her close relationship with her Uncle Legolas, Mara is the most fluent in Elvish of the three children.

Boromir: The youngest of C'yra and Adora's twins and youngest child overall, Boromir is something of an odd one out among his siblings. While both Finn and Mara are fair haired, blue eyed, and quite lanky, Boromir has eyes of gold, dark fur, and a tall and strong build resembling that of his namesake. He also is the most laidback of the three, preferring to solve issues through kindness and words as opposed to wit and weapons when he can manage it.

Even still, he was his mothers' son, and had the spark of adventure within him. This manifested in his younger days as he took to exploring the restored forest of Fangorn. Much to the shock of many, the trees of Fangorn turned out to be very fond of the young Magicat, and Treebeard delighted in teaching the youngster the ways of poem and verse. Such was Boromir Halfmoon's friendship with the woods, that an oak of Fangorn that he often climbed would curiously give up a branch of its own accord to him, which he later crafted into his staff.

It was not long before it was discovered that Boromir had the gift of magic within him, and his studies under his Aunt Glimmer began as soon as possible. He proved to be quite adept in studious pursuits, and after his graduation by way of making his staff, he would learn what he could of craftsmanship from his Uncle Gimli.

While he personally detested violence, he found himself in agreement with Faramir in loving swords solely for that which they defend, and accepted lessons and a blade from the Steward of Gondor, which he learned to wield with his left hand while casting with the staff in his right in the event that he had no choice but to fight.

He also was in possession of an impressive metabolism that became famous amongst the Dwarves of Erebor when, on he and Mara's sixteenth birthday, he consumed one whole chicken, three servings of salted pork, half a dozen apples, one loaf of bread, half a wheel of cheese, and five slices of cake. He then proceeded to wash it down with an entire barrel of ale and one glass of Dorwinion red wine over the course of the night's celebrations. If the statements of Finn and Mara were to be believed, Boromir had been holding back that night.

Appendices Part IV: The Road Goes Ever On and On…

Before I close this off, I'd like to divulge a curious occurrence that took place as I was writing that I feel doesn't really fit the Behind the Scenes material. Somewhere between the time I had finished the Fellowship of the Ring arc and was about a seventh of the way into the Two Towers, a collection of three songs from my personal collection got attached to this fic in my mind as a sort of substitution for the end credits songs of each LotR film that better matched the spirit of Catra/C'yra's personal journey and involvement in the War of the Ring. This is not to disparage the actual songs commissioned for each of the films' credits, but I felt that I might as well share my thoughts on the matter:

The Fellowship of the Ring: This Is The Day by The The

I will make it no secret that I am a huge fan of Guardians of the Galaxy, and regularly (read: debatably too much) listen to their soundtracks, which is why two tracks from the third film appear here. The explanation for this one is half because I feel the song has the perfect end credits vibe, and then I looked up the lyrics and realized that a good 98% almost perfectly matched up with Catra's journey throughout the arc. Was it the mother of all coincidences, or a subconscious act on my part? We may never know.

The Two Towers: Since You've Been Gone by Rainbow

The other selection from Guardians 3, it was originally going to be San Francisco by The Mowglis. But the more I listened to it while actively imagining the cut to black after C'yra addresses Adora for the first time in five years, it worked less and less. I then happened to glance a little bit upward on the track list and I nearly burst out laughing. While the song probably fits Adora's feelings on the situation a lot more, it brought a much better punch in my opinion.

The Return of the King: Wings of Time by Tame Impala

If it were not for Tolkien, there would probably not be a Dungeons & Dragons. Or at least, not in the form we have it in. The

presence of the She-Ra characters in this story always added a bit more of a blatant Rock'n'Roll energy to the LotR narrative, and Tame Impala really channeled Led Zeppelin for Wings of Time. It probably fits the least out of the three, but now I can't help but imagine it blasting as Catra/C'yra, Adora, Glimmer, and Bow join the portraits that accompany the main cast as the credits roll.

At last then, we come to the final end. Is this where I will say my last goodbye to these versions of characters new and old that are so dear to me? Well, perhaps not just yet. I am planning a series of one shots that will likely be posted out of chronological order in a story I'm calling "Tales Of The Fourth Age", that will detail the slice of life dealings in the twenty one year gap between the Coronation scene and the Epilogue. To be totally realistic though, these will come few and far between, as there are other things on the horizon.

I think I'm quite ready for another adventure.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!